

1971 WAR

EASTERN THEATRE

COMMAND & STAFF COLLEGE MILITARY HISTORY PRIMER: 2011

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* A pocket map of East Pakistan is attached at the end to facilitate reading.

PREFACE

1. Pursuant to the COAS General Ashfaq Parvez Kayani's orders, the task of writing a primer on Indo-Pak War 1971 (Eastern Theatre) was assigned to the Command and Staff College in November 2010. A two member team of Directing Staff comprising Lieutenant Colonel Khurram Nazir Mirza, Baloch and Lieutenant Colonel Rehan Mushtaq, Baloch was assigned the responsibility. The primer is the outcome of three months of effort and is by no means the final word on the subject. The main purpose of this endeavour is to provide, the candidates of Staff Course Entrance Examination in particular and others officers in general, relevant and accurate material on the subject in a compiled form. The campaign has been selected for its relevance to our obtaining environment where a two front war scenario has fast become a reality.
2. To begin with, a deliberate search for the reference material was carried out which revealed many surprises and provided abundant material in the form of books, magazines and articles from the college library. Over thirty different books and magazine articles by Pakistani and Indian historians and Generals have formed major sources for this primer. Besides that *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission* published in 2003 and military history presentations compiled at National Defence University, Islamabad have also been consulted, especially for assertions relating to the higher direction of war.
3. The methodology pursued involved sifting and editing of available material for putting it across in a crisp and palatable form. During compilation the team struggled on two accounts: good quality maps and lack of detailed and impartial accounts for "conduct of the battles". To resolve the first problem an atlas on the subject by Colonel John H Gill became handy. While to ensure correctness of account, the material presented has amply been referred to from the primary sources. The primer describes the environment but, essentially gives a detailed battle account of own and Indian forces. Air and naval operations have not been covered here.
4. The primer deals with an event that evokes emotions and sensitivities of every Pakistani. Despite being an academic exercise and completely based on published material; the college takes no responsibility for its complete accuracy and cannot vouch for exactness of its each and every word. It therefore should be studied in this spirit, essentially as a frame reference for further study by budding military leaders of Pakistan Army.

INTRODUCTION¹

1. Shared interest in the protection of cultural, economic and political rights brought the Muslims of British India to a common platform, with the leaders of Bengal playing a seminal role in the formation of the Muslim League and the formulation of the demand for Pakistan. After the state came into existence, the unity of the two wings came under strain as a result of several factors; some of which were inherent in demography, differential-colonial-legacy and resource endowment, while others arose from narrow and short-sighted politics.
2. Difference with the distant centre's view began to surface in East Pakistan soon after independence, when a group of students protested the Quaid-i-Azam's speech in Dacca in 1948, that Urdu alone would be the national language. Two years later in 1950, the East Pakistan Muslim League asked for maximum autonomy. Then in 1954, after elections in East Pakistan, the United Front, which won with overwhelming majority, asked for a complete autonomy according to the *Pakistan Resolution*. The central government's manipulation to deny power to the elected majority in East Pakistan added to the accumulating grievances. Delays in constitution-making and holding national elections exacerbated East Pakistan's sense of exclusion.
3. East Pakistan's isolation during the 1965 War and its lack of self-defence capability gave a fillip to the existing demand for autonomy. In March 1966, the Awami League leader Sheikh Mujibur Rehman put forward the *Six Points*. Ayub Khan's highly centralised government equated this demand for autonomy with secessionism.
4. Alert to the brewing trouble and growing alienation in East Pakistan, India encouraged the separatist sentiments. The same year, a group of extremists in Agartala planned sabotage. A raid on an armoury led to the arrest of twenty-eight people including armed forces personnel in January 1969. The government also implicated Mujibur Rehman in this case, though he was in custody during the Agartala Conspiracy period. Mujib's Six Points and his trial made him a hero out of nothing. As if this was not enough, the federal government's indifference to the plight of the people in East Pakistan after 1970's flood broadened the mistrust fissures.

¹ Most of the details or historical facts have been taken from following books: (a) Abdul Sattar, *Pakistan's Foreign Policy 1947-2005: A Concise History* (Karachi: Oxford University Press, 2007), 112-122. (b) Stephen Philip Cohen, *The Idea of Pakistan* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2006), 73-77. (c) Sumit Ganguly, *The Origins of War in South Asia: Indo-Pakistani Conflicts Since 1947* (Lahore: Vanguard Books Private Limited, 1988), 101-126.

5. The December 1970 elections further politicised the troubles of East Pakistanis. As a result, Awami League, led by Mujibur Rehman, swept polls in East Pakistan winning absolute majority in National Assembly. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto of Pakistan Peoples Party emerged as a runner up. These election results indicated with devastating clarity the polarization of popular feelings between East and West Pakistan. Faced with this unexpected outcome, the leaders of military regime and Bhutto sought for other means to maintain their pre-eminence in Pakistani politics. He tried to stall the convening of the National Assembly, an act that added fuel to the fire.

6. Mujib, unable to get his fair share in power, took an extreme position. He declined any invitation to visit Islamabad for talks. The political situation got worsened. Yahya – Mujib talks in Dacca broke down on 23 March when the Awami League proposed Pakistan should be made a confederation. On 25 March, the military started a crack down in East Pakistan to restore ever deteriorating law and order situation. Though the military within a month reasonably restored law and order situation but their actions and heavy handedness further alienated the masses in East Pakistan. The condition worsened beyond control.

7. After Yahya Khan's military crackdown in East Pakistan, the Indian government with revisionist designs moved into a higher gear. India saw in the crisis an opportunity of the century to cut Pakistan into two. Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) operatives smuggled out Tajuddin Ahmed, an Awami League leader, to a border village in India to proclaim independence of Bangladesh and installed him as head of the Provisional Bangladesh Government in Mujibnagar, a house in Calcutta rented by RAW. On 31 March, the Indian parliament adopted a resolution assuring the East Pakistani insurgents that their struggle and sacrifices will receive the wholehearted support of the people of India. The Indians first secretly, and later openly, began building up a rebel force called the Mukti Bahini.

8. Where the Pakistanis believed that the Indians would restrict their assistance to moral and material support, the Indian government ordered plans for a campaign to take over East Pakistan. It however, deferred the implementation in light of their Army Chief General Manekshaw's view that the army needed six to seven months to prepare for war. The Indians planned their offensive in November when the weather in Himalayas would make Chinese intervention more difficult.

9. The Indians started an all-out war in end November. With the complete numerical superiority in air, sea and land its forces defeated the Pakistani Eastern Command on 16 December 1971.

AIM

10. The aim of this primer is to compile the history of 1971 politico-military debacle (Eastern Theatre only)² that led to the dismemberment of Pakistan.

SCOPE

11. The primer has following parts:-

- | | | | |
|----|------------|---|--------------------------------|
| a. | Part – I | - | Tracing the Marks of Missteps. |
| b. | Part – II | - | The War: Playing the Last Act. |
| c. | Part – III | - | Analysis. |

12. Part – I deals with the historical background that led to the debacle. It traces the genesis of the problem and highlights the important decisions of the federal government which affected the environment. It also mentions briefly the creation of Mukti Bahini, their organization and operational modus operandi. This part, towards it's end, has details of Eastern Command military crackdown of 25 March – Operation SEARCHLIGHT.

13. Part – II carries the the information pertaining to the war accounts. It has details of conduct of battle in different sectors. Both Pakistani and Indian conduct of operations have sufficiently been elaborated for fruitful analyses.

14. Part – III covers strategic, operational and tactical analyses of 1971 War in the Eastern Theatre.

² For details on 1971 War, the Western Front, refer to *Warfare Foundation Studies: Military History Primer* 2003, C&SC Quetta, 305 - 324.

MAP – 1

PART – I**TRACING THE MARKS OF MIS-STEPS****ENVIRONMENT****Domestic Environment - Historical Context**

15. **The Bengali Sentiment.** During the British Raj, except for a short period between 1905 and 1911, Bengal remained united. During this period, the politics and economy of Bengal were largely dominated by the Hindus who had won favours from the British. Muslims, who were largely down trodden, were represented in two categories: the aristocrats i.e. likes of Nawab Salim Ullah Khan etc, symbolizing the Persian-Urdu speaking culture of northern India and the native lower middle class Bengali peasants, representing the local Bengali culture. Despite the Hindu-Muslim socio-cultural divide, Bengalis were comparatively more regional than people of many other parts of the country. This was partly due to the influence of nationalists like Rabindranath Tagore and Romesh Chunder Dutt³ and partly because Calcutta remained the capital of the country till 1911. The strength of Bengali sentiment was vividly displayed when the partition of Bengal carried out by Lord Curzon in 1905, had to be undone in 1911. The strong Bengal centric sentiment continued till 1937 elections, when Muslim League was able to form a coalition government with AK Fazlul Haq's Krishak Party in Bengal. This coalition was an uneasy one, largely due to Fazlul Haq's provincial agenda, which did not go in line with the Muslim League's vision. It was during this period that Lahore Resolution was proposed and the word 'states' included in it. The coalition finally collapsed in 1941, only within a year of the *Lahore Resolution*. The Bengali sentiment was partially overshadowed by the overwhelming force of the "Idea of Pakistan", resulting into landslide victory of Muslim League in 1946 elections. The under currents however, remained.

16. **Socio-Cultural Aspects.** Bengal projected a very vibrant socio-cultural environment, which cut across the Hindu-Muslim divide. The socio-cultural environment was, however, largely dominated by Hindu traditions, which were willingly accepted and followed by the Muslims. The province also had a far eastern touch on its culture and society, which was because of its geographic and climatic contiguity with some of those cultures. Except for religious values, Bengal did not share a common ground on social

³ Romesh Chunder Dutt was a Bengali writer, civil servant, economic historian and translator of Ramayana and Mahabharata. He had been president of Indian National Congress.

and cultural aspects with Muslims of northern India. This was visible in food, dress, language and festivals etc. It is also worth pointing out here that Bengalis, despite their self belief in the richness of their customs, traditions and intellect, were not so well perceived by many others in the country which included the British, who considered them non martial race. Their language was also looked down upon by the Muslim aristocrats.⁴

17. **East – West Equation.** It is in the backdrop of socio-cultural environment and Bengal centric sentiment that creation of Pakistan and east-west relations should be studied. At the time of partition there were inbuilt inadequacies in the relationship between both the wings, which fundamentally boiled down to constraints imposed by geography and economy. As for economy, East Bengal had been a poor province during the British rule; whereas, areas that constituted West Pakistan were quite prosperous. The socio-cultural and economic differences were underpinned by the facts of geography. Sensing the likely troubles between both the wings, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad made a prophetic statement about a decade and a half before 1971. He said, “Mr. Jinnah and his followers did not seem to realize that geography was against them. These two regions have no point of physical contact. People in these two areas are completely different from one another in every respect, except only in religion. No one can hope that East and West Pakistan will carry all their differences and form one nation.”⁵ Quaid-e-Azam also appeared to have fully understood the likely complications of east, west relations: while addressing an East Pakistani audience in Dhaka on 21 March 1948 he said, “You belong to a nation now; you have now carved out a territory, vast territory, it is all yours; it does not belong to a Punjabi or a Sindhi, or a Pathan, or a Bengali; it is yours. Therefore, if you want to build yourself into a nation, for God’s sake give up this provincialism.”⁶ Such was the broad environment, which set the stage, for an uneasy twenty four years relationship between East and West Pakistan.

Sowing the Seeds of Discord - Initial years (Upto 1965)

18. **The Language Issue.** With the domination of Urdu speaking community both at the central and provincial levels, the already partially aggrieved Bengalis (due to award of Calcutta to India) were further antagonized by the announcement that Urdu would be

⁴ Gordon A. Leonard, *Bengal: The Nationalist Movement 1876-1940* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1974), 9.

⁵ Maulana Abul Kalam Azad’s saying. Mohammad Ayoob & K. Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War* (New Delhi: S. Chand Publishers, 1972), 1.

⁶ Shuja Nawaz, *Cross Swords: Pakistan, Its Army and the Wars Within* (Karachi: Oxford University Press, 2008), 77.

the national language. The language row started on February 25, 1948, when a Hindu Bengal member, Mr Dhirendra Nath Dutta, moved a resolution in the constituent assembly that Bengali, along with Urdu, should be used in the assembly proceedings.⁷ To this, Prime Minister Liaquat Ali Khan responded that “Pakistan is a Muslim State and it must have as its lingua franca the language of the Muslim nation...It is necessary for a nation to have one language and the language can only be Urdu and no other language.” This was taken with a pinch of salt by Bengalis as their language was spoken by 54.6 % of the people of Pakistan while Urdu was the language of only 7.2 % of Pakistan’s population.⁸ Quaid-e-Azam’s assertion of the same in Dacca only after one month did no good in settling the issue. The central government’s insistence to bulldoze the issue resulted into *Language Riots* of 1952, which resulted in some deaths and quite a lot of bad taste.

19. Constitutional-cum-Political Issues

- a. The immediate legal-cum-political challenge faced by the newborn state was formulation of a constitution, which should have been drafted at the earliest, due to peculiar dictates of geographical, political, economic and social differences between the two wings. The assembly however, failed to draft a constitution till its dismissal in 1954.⁹ The consequences were obvious: politics reverted to provincial levels and trust deficit started to increase between both the wings and there were calls for more autonomy from East Pakistan.¹⁰ If evidence was needed, 1954 provincial elections provided it, wherein the provincial tendencies clearly emerged in the

⁷ Lieutenant General Kamal Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors: East Pakistan Crisis 1968-1971* (Lahore: Wajidalis Private Limited, 1994), 48.

⁸ Population Census 1951. Ayoob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 51

⁹ “The development of East Bengalis nationalism to the pitch which it reached in the December 1970 election - assisted by the accident of cyclone disaster - might perhaps have been avoided if a constitutional structure had been evolved in Pakistan after 1947, capable of engaging the consent of the Bengalis and ensuring their access to power and to the fruits of economic expansion and communal self expression”. Robert Jackson, *South Asian Crisis: India-Pakistan-Bangladesh* (International Institute for Strategic Studies, USA: Praeger, 1975), 147

¹⁰ As early as 1950, voices had started to appear about more autonomy. Significant was formal recommendation of the Working Committee of East Bengal Muslim League which stated that, “although a federal constitution was necessary for Pakistan, in setting up the actual federal structure the geographical position of East Pakistan, its detachment and distance from other units and also from the federal capital itself has to be seriously considered and provisions made in the constitution to accord maximum autonomy to East Pakistan and to that effect it is essential that a separate list of subjects to be administered by East Pakistan be incorporated in the Constitution and the residuary powers should rest in the units. And also that since the railways and navigation system of the eastern wing were separate from the west, communications cannot and should not be a central subject. The committee declared that so far as the export and import trade of East Pakistan is concerned adequate provision should be made subject to the least possible control of the centre for the administration of this subject by the Government of East Pakistan.” Richard Sisson & Leo E. Rose, *War And Secession: Pakistan, India, and the Creation of Bangladesh* (Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1990), 11

election results in which United Front, a coalition of East Pakistan based parties swept elections in the province by winning 223 out of 237 Muslim seats.¹¹ 1954 is also generally the time period, when sub-national tendencies started to appear in East Pakistan. AK Fazlul Haq pioneered these tendencies, when as Chief Minister of East Pakistan, he made statements which were suggestive of independent Bangladesh. It is unfortunate to point out that government failed to fully comprehend the consequences of such divide. This was made obvious by its almost inaction to the United Fronts' 21 points, which asked for greater autonomy for East Pakistan.¹²

- b. The constitutional problem lingered on. Dismissal of various governments, formulation and abrogation of 1956 Constitution and introduction of a system of *parity* through *One Unit Formula* furthered the divide between both the wings. Imposition of martial law in 1958 put brakes on the political process and thus paved the way for political polarization. Ayub's 1962 Constitution also failed to provide any solution to the problem, as it contained substantial executive powers for the president and thus became presidential in nature.¹³ These sub-national tendencies, which started surfacing in 1951, finally dominated the political scene in 1966. These were manifested in Mujib's Six Points, which ultimately led to the breakup of the country.

20. Economy

- a. "East Bengal was the poorest part of the province of Bengal in undivided India. It had the lowest percentage of urbanization, industrialization,

¹¹ Sisson & Rose, *War and Secession*, 12.

¹² The main features of the 21-Point Programme, which summed up Bengali grievances and aspirations, were (Ayoob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 39) :-

- a. Complete provincial autonomy for East Bengal with the central government to retain responsibility only for defence, foreign affairs and currency.
- b. Naval Headquarters to be shifted from Karachi to East Bengal and ordnance factories established there.
- c. Bengal to become a state language on par with Urdu.
- d. Nationalization of the jute trade and complete freedom from the centre in regard to the export of jute.
- e. Devaluation of the Pakistani rupee in order to boost the export of jute and jute products, East Bengal's primary cash crop.
- f. Consultation between the centre and East Bengal on the allocation of foreign exchange.
- g. Abolition of existing trade restrictions between East and West Bengal and abolition of the Indo-Pak visa system.
- h. Radical land reforms.
- j. The dissolution of the existing Constituent Assembly and its replacement by a directly elected body.

¹³ Sisson & Rose, *War and Secession*, 18

literacy, electrical power capacity and per capita income at the time of independence.”¹⁴ WW Hunter also observed as early as 1871 that “East Bengal was a down trodden province, in which the Muhammadans have suffered most severely under British Rule.”¹⁵ The economic activity suffered further at the time of partition by award of Calcutta – the economic hub of Bengal - to India.¹⁶ The arguments of economic injustices committed by a West Pakistan led central government (on East Pakistan) need to be seen in this context. It may however, be noted that the central government did not do enough to alleviate the economic sufferings of East Pakistanis, instead its economic policies further alienated the Bengalis.

- b. A retrospective view suggests that the government did not suitably factor in the geographical aspect, while formulating economic policies. Geography demanded decentralization of trade and relatively liberal fiscal policies. However, these were quite strictly controlled by the centre, which had negative effects on East Pakistan.¹⁷ Military operations of 1965 War, which did not have any geographical linkage with East Pakistan, also affected East Pakistani economy, as its trade with India, which among others included jute and tea, was severely affected. As a result, some East Pakistanis developed the feeling of being economically left out while others considered that they were being looted. It was in this background that politicians used figures - some of those were correct - such as gap in per capita income,¹⁸ flow of money from east to west,¹⁹ trade balance and expenditure on health and education etc to further alienate the Bengalis. The Bengali population was of course more than willing to accept these

¹⁴Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 97.

¹⁵ Ayoob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 32.

¹⁶ Pervaiz Iqbal Cheema, “The Politics of the Punjab Boundary Award,” *Working Paper No 1* for South Asian Institute Department of Political Science, University of Heidelberg, September 2000.

¹⁷ Ayoob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 39

¹⁸ West Pakistan’s per capita income which was Rs 355 in 1960 rose to Rs 492 in 1970. During the same period, East Pakistan’s per capita income registered a meagre rise from Rs 269 to Rs 308. Thus the difference in per capita income which had been Rs 86 in 1960 more than doubled to Rs 184 in 1970. Ibid., 39.

¹⁹ Government of Pakistan Planning Commission Reports, *Fourth Year Plan 1970-75, Vol. I, Appendix 3*, July 1970. The net transfer of resources from East Pakistan to West Pakistan during the period 1948-49 to 1968-69 amounted to approximately 2.6 billion dollars.

figures as an evidence of West Pakistan's injustices and the concept of 'internal colonialism'²⁰ by West Pakistan slowly gained currency.

21. **East Pakistan's Share in the Government Services.** Notwithstanding the inbuilt inadequacies in representation of East Pakistan in the armed forces, civil services and other government institutions, and also the fact that government did quite a bit to improve the situation, the overall political and economic environment lead many in the East to believe that enough was not being done in this regard. Politicians used the otherwise statistically correct data to prove that west was skimming the share of East Pakistan.

Drawing of Battle Lines

22. **Mujib's Six Points.** After 1965 War, Ayub was criticized by politicians in both the wings. In West Pakistan, Bhutto resigned as foreign minister and started leading a campaign against the government. In East Pakistan, Mujib and his cohorts felt that West Pakistan, in event of a war, cared less about them; they felt economically further strangled by the war. As a result sub-national themes gained full support in East Pakistan and in March 1966, less than six months after the war ended; Mujib advanced a six point programme to resounding public response.²¹ The programme fundamentally called for a separate foreign exchange accounts for both wings and asked for permission to raise para-military forces at the provincial level.²² Politicians of West Pakistan felt that six points were secessionist in nature and therefore, did not support them. However, the six points became a popular political slogan in East Pakistan.

23. **Round Table Conference.** Distrubed by agitations in both wings and a constitutional impasse, General Ayub decided to call a Round Table Conference (RTC) in early months of 1969. Mujib, who was under trial in Agartala Conspiracy Case – an event which in itself aggravated the already uneasy situation - was acquitted from charges and honourably released to attend the conference. However, Bhutto and Maulana Bhashani refused to attend.²³ The conference provided an opportunity to sort out the fundamental issues of provincial autonomy, representation in the National Assembly, the status of One Unit in West Pakistan and restoration of parliamentary democracy based on universal adult franchise. However, except for the last point, all others were pended to be taken up by the future National Assembly. West Pakistani

²⁰ Jackson, *South Asian Crisis*, 19.

²¹ Sisson & Rose, *War and Secession*, 19.

²² Ayoob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 66.

²³ Ibid.

politicians accepted the proposals whereas Sheikh Mujib, Nurul Amin and SM Murshid – all Bengalis displayed reservations.²⁴ Results of RTC further alienated the Bengalis, who felt that their basic demands were put under the carpet; and in so doing, most of the West Pakistani politicians also supported the government.

24. Elections and After

- a. After assuming office, Yahya announced elections under universal suffrage to be held in December 1970. 'One Unit' was also done away with, which implied permanent majority for East Pakistan in the National Assembly. There are indications that Yahya was expecting a split mandate in East Pakistan, but it turned out to be otherwise and Awami League got thumping majority, winning 160 out of 162 East Pakistan National Assembly seats.²⁵ The results in the west were also quite unexpected, wherein PPP of Bhutto won 81 out of 120 National Assembly seats. As a result of elections, Mujib rightly expected to be offered the seat of Prime Minister of the country. However, Bhutto insisted on some power sharing formula, which would keep him part of the government. He continuously refused to go to Dhaka to attend the assembly session, which had been called on 3 March. He also threatened physical harm to any members of his party, who dared to go to Dhaka to attend the assembly session. Unfortunately, Yahya caved in to demands of Bhutto and on 1 March postponed the assembly session, a decision which had far reaching effects on the already fragile situation in East Pakistan. He also cancelled a RTC that had originally been planned for 10 March. Postponement of the assembly session was seriously resented in East Pakistan. It resulted in a wave of protests and demonstrations, which only increased in intensity with the passage of time. As a last ditch effort, Yahya tried to broker a deal between Mujib and Bhutto, but that was too late. It is generally agreed upon that Bhutto's decision not to attend the assembly was very unfortunate. Mr Salman Taseer, the former Governor Punjab in his book, "Bhutto, A Political Biography" noted, "Perhaps another politician with more moral scruple and with a greater respect for democracy would have bowed before the will of the majority and quietly

²⁴ Ayoob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 77.

²⁵ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 153.

entered the Constituent Assembly to debate the future of Pakistan. Bhutto, however, possessed none of these gentle characteristics. He never had much faith in the parliamentary process.”²⁶

- b. Postponement of the assembly session resulted into wide spread protests in East Pakistan. Awami League called for civil disobedience. Rebels took over the administration. Writ of the government virtually evaporated. Army and civilian mobs clashed, which resulted in casualties and return of army to barracks. Mujib ran the administration through directives issued on his behalf. All government offices which included banks, TV and Radio station obeyed commands of Mujib. There was also wide spread killing of non Bengalis in East Pakistan. Tales of mass murder and killings of non-Bengalis are horrifying. Dhaka was physically barricaded by Awami League activists. At this juncture, the government decided to use force against force, which was resented by Lieutenant General Sahibzada Yaqub Khan who tendered his resignation. A military operation code named Operation SEARCHLIGHT was launched on night 25/ 26 March. The operation, details of which will be covered later on, was partially successful as writ of the Government was established in many parts of the country and Mujib and many others were arrested. However, at the strategic level it was a total failure.

International Environment

25. **India.** Post 1965 period was much more conducive - both politically and economically - for India as opposed to Pakistan. India was politically stable, was developing armed forces at a fast pace and was internationally much stronger as compared to Pakistan, which was struggling on all fronts. India used this leverage to give fillip to anti-Pakistan sentiments in East Pakistan. Having first engineered Agartala Conspiracy against Pakistan, she followed it up with continuous connections with politicians and officials inside East Pakistan in addition to her intelligence agencies' active involvement in East Pakistan.²⁷ Courtesy Indra Gandhi, Indian successful exterior manoeuvre, by mid 1971 attained strategic freedom of action against Pakistan, which she successfully employed during the conflict.

²⁶ Ardeshir Cowasjee, “A Little Bit of Objectivity,” *Dawn*, 13 July, 2008.

²⁷ A.A.K. Niazi, *The Betrayal of East Pakistan* (Karachi: Oxford University Press, 1998), 35.

26. **USA.** Pakistan was an ally of USA since 1954.²⁸ It was part of SEATO and CENTO and had been given written and unwritten assurances that USA would support Pakistan, in case of aggression from any country including India.²⁹ However, India was equally, if not more important for USA, hence USA was hesitant to interfere in a bilateral dispute between the two neighbours. The leverage offered by this ambiguous stance allowed India to plan operations in East Pakistan, while on the other hand Pakistan felt over assured that US would intervene and prevent its disintegration. However, US followed a coldly calculated policy, which concluded that East Pakistan was destined to become independent; therefore, efforts should only be focused on preventing dismemberment of West Pakistan.

27. **USSR.** USSR, which followed a reasonably balanced policy towards India and Pakistan after 1965, almost openly supported India in the months before and during the conflict. This was largely dictated by two factors; one, Pakistan refused to follow Soviet Containment of China policy at the cost of its relations with Beijing; second, India was sharply reacting to Soviet aid to Pakistan and wanted it to be terminated. Although in the South Asian context, USSR's interest was to facilitate Indian domination of the region, its grand strategic interest was to humble United States so that other countries in the region supporting USA, namely Iran, Turkey and Saudi Arabia could become wary of USA. It also wanted to frustrate China by bringing its South Asian ally to knees. Soviet Union's support to India was formalized through the *Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation* signed between India and USSR on 9 August 1971.³⁰ During the conflict, Soviet Union provided military equipment to India, acted as a counter balance to China at the regional level and USA at the international level. It also played a major role at the UN Security Council by vetoing resolutions directed against India.

28. **China.** China was in support of Pakistan in 1971 crisis. The support however, remained restricted to moral, material and political levels because of unavoidable compulsions. Sino - Soviet relations were strained after 1969 border clashes and China did not want to escalate them by physically intervening in the Indo-Pak border. It also did not want to get into a military confrontation with India at a time, when Nixon's China initiative was at its peak. An open Chinese involvement in war also had the potential to draw USA into the conflict, for which she was not prepared because of domestic environment and Vietnam issue. Therefore, Chinese restricted their support to material

²⁸ Kursheed Kamal Aziz, *World Powers and the 1971 Breakup of Pakistan* (Islamabad: Vanguard, 2003), 34.

²⁹ Sisson & Rose, *War and Secession*, 51.

³⁰ Ibid., 242.

and political levels. China played its part in the UN Security Council where she supported Pakistani perspective in a strong manner.

29. **United Kingdom.** During the initial months of the conflict, UK remained neutral. However, after Operation SEARCHLIGHT, it started to openly support India. On 23 June, it stopped all economic aid to Pakistan.³¹ It also allowed setting up of a High Commission by “Bangladesh Government in exile” in London from September 1971.³²

30. **Muslim Countries.** Pakistan could traditionally bank on the support from Muslim countries. India in order to guard against any reaction from these countries “developed a set of tactics... This was directed at dividing Pakistan’s support within the Islamic bloc by playing upon the serious divisions inherent in this grouping of nations and thus minimizing the support, other than verbal, extended to the government of Pakistan.”³³ As a result, while the Islamic states were virtually unanimous in their support to Pakistan... The degree of substantive military and financial assistance extended to Pakistan by them was much less.”³⁴

Operational Environment

31. Moral Aspects

- a. **Leadership and Decision Making.** Pakistan and its’ armed forces were lead by General Yahya Khan. As head of state and Commander-in-Chief, he had gathered around him a select group of army officers, who were handling most of the affairs.³⁵ For quite sometime, civilians were also kept at bay: bureaucracy was made to operate through two brigadiers, which denied Yahya their valuable advice on matters of national security. Although himself an intelligent man, “The decision making (by Yahya) was marked by a paucity of paperwork, analysis, and thought and as colleagues observed the decisions were impulsive and sometimes contradictory.”³⁶ During this time institutions meant to provide higher direction of war namely the Defence Committee of the Cabinet, National Security Council and Joint Services Secretariat lay dormant, which introduced shortcuts in the decision making process.

³¹ Aziz, *World Powers and the 1971 Breakup of Pakistan*, 162.

³² Ibid., 165.

³³ Sisson & Rose, *War and Secession*, 204.

³⁴ Ibid., 205.

³⁵ Ayooob & Subrahmanyam, *The Liberation War*, 95.

³⁶ Nawaz, *Crossed Swords*, 251.

- b. **Strategic Thinking.** The leadership in Pakistan appeared to be confused in adopting a strategy to handle the crisis of East Pakistan. It kept on shifting between policy of appeasement and coercion, which only complicated the already intricate situation. Mujib's arrest in Agartala Conspiracy Case and later his exoneration, Yahya's declaration of Mujib as 'future Prime Minister of Pakistan'³⁷ and concurrently his refusal to transfer power are a few episodes, which indicate lack of clear strategic thinking at our end.
- c. **Morale.** Pakistan army was faced with a difficult situation in East Pakistan. Due to ever increasing hostility from the local population, a protracted employment on internal security, feeling of home sickness, lack of resources and above all absence of clear political direction affected their morale. On the contrary, Mukti Bahini and Indians who were in full support of each other, maintained a high morale till the very end.
- d. **Media.** Instead of co-opting the media, authorities in East Pakistan decided to do away with it. On the day of Operation SEARCHLIGHT, foreign journalists in Dhaka were bundled into trucks and taken to the airport to be sent away immediately.³⁸ This proved to be a key mistake as after that "the foreign press became increasingly gullible in accepting, without effort at verifying, the substantial exaggerations that were appended to the list of horror stories from Dhaka."³⁹ Our own efforts to project the situation in our favour miserably failed as no one was willing to accept our version of the facts.

32. Preparedness

- a. **National Spirit.** The nation was not mentally prepared for a military confrontation in 1971. It was embroiled in internal political crisis, which fundamentally focused on political dispensation of the country. On the contrary, spirit of East Pakistan rebels and their protectors was high.
- b. **Equipment of Armed Forces.** Soon after the 1965 War had started, USA had imposed an embargo on military aid on both India and Pakistan. This embargo did not affect the Indian Army but produced major challenges for Pakistan armed forces in the fields of equipment procurement and

³⁷ Jackson, *South Asian Crisis*, 28.

³⁸ Nawaz, *Crossed Swords*, 268.

³⁹ Sission & Rose, *War and Secession*, 217.

maintenance.⁴⁰ It's effects were visible during 1971, as the armed forces had to struggle in equipping and maintaining themselves. On the contrary, Indians had been developing their armed forces at a fast pace ever since 1962 War with China. Post 1965 situation did not affect them much, as their main supplies from Soviet Union remained intact.

- c. **Training and Operational Planning.** Indian army went through a methodical phase of preparation and training for the impending operations. They took the necessary time required from the political leadership and focused on the task by conducting war games and training own troops and Mukti Bahini in an ideal environment. On the contrary, Pakistan Army's commitments in martial law duties and ancillary tasks deprived them of the chance to hone their military skills and prepare for war.

33. **Military Strategy**

- a. **Pakistan.** Our military strategy can be summed up in one sentence. 'Defence of East Pakistan lies in the west'. This concept was developed well before 71, when it was generally perceived that West Pakistan would be the main theatre of war. It was thus felt that in the eastern wing, which was geographically separated and ideally suited for defensive battles, a purely defensive strategy would be adopted, while in West Pakistan, operations were planned to capture objectives of strategic importance to strengthen the post war bargaining position.
- b. **India.** India decided to adopt a defensive strategy in the west and an offensive one in the east. In the east, while Dacca was visualized to be the ultimate objective, the initial plans were restricted to the capture of territory up to the river lines. Land operations were to be launched from all three sides. Indian Navy was tasked to effect a naval blockade in the south whereas IAF was to achieve complete air supremacy from the outset to ensure complete freedom of action to the ground forces.
- c. **Relative Ground Forces Situation.** Indians enjoyed an overall superior relative strength on both fronts:-
 - (1) Pakistan had a peacetime force of only one infantry division of four brigades. Later this strength was raised to a total of five infantry

⁴⁰ Yahya Khan, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Yahaya_Khan (accessed on 5 February, 2011).

divisions including two adhoc divisions. However, two out of the three regular divisions were without their usual components of armour, artillery and engineers.

- (2) India had concentrated eight infantry/ mountain divisions organised in three Corps Headquarters with full logistic and communication back up support. The Mukti Bahini force estimated to be 100,000 strong by the start of full-fledged war also supported them.

- d. **Air Situation.** PAF had only one squadron of twelve F-86 E fighters operating from a single jet capable airfield near Dacca against eleven enemy squadrons operating from five airfields around East Pakistan.
- e. **Logistics and Rear Area Situation.** The rear area situation was far from satisfactory due to a totally hostile population and extremely poor and vulnerable communication infrastructure. Indian naval blockade and complete air supremacy further accentuated the situation. With the induction of additional divisions, the sole logistic area found it very hard to cope with the logistic requirements.

34. A detailed account of military operations will be covered in Part II.

MUKTI BAHINI OPERATIONS⁴¹

Background

35. It is difficult for the armed forces of any nation, however disciplined and a-political they might be in normal times, not to be affected by tumultuous events in their country, more so if ethnic issues are involved. So was the case with the Bengali elements in the military establishment, particularly those serving in East Pakistan, during the days when the election campaign was in full swing. Although the Awami League was not demanding separation from West Pakistan initially, Sheikh Mujibur Rehman and his lieutenants were leaving no stone unturned to widen the existing gulf between the two wings. He was, without any restraint, playing to the tune of Bengali nationalism. His fiery speech on March 7, at the race course grounds, Dacca, left no doubt that he had finally given the call for an independent Bangladesh although he did not declare it openly.

36. The affects of political activism had reached the barracks and the officers' messes in the units and formations, stirring the minds of both the ethnic groups alike. Many Bengali soldiers were attending the political meetings. Others, who had kept away, were following the speeches on the radio. Slowly and gradually they were getting emotionally involved. It was natural for the Bengalis to have rejoiced at the landslide victory of the Awami League.

37. So, when the power was not transferred to the leader of the majority party in March, as announced by the president, there was a sudden wave of disappointment amongst the East Pakistani soldiers as well which gradually turned to bitterness against the military hierarchy and Bhutto in particular and all the West Pakistanis in general. After March 1, when Mujib declared that the postponement would not go unchallenged, and the entire Bengali population seemed to be behind him, the feelings of the Bengali troops were also, quite naturally, aroused.

38. To avoid a rebellion by a large body of native soldiers the British had devised a system of mixing different religious and ethnic groups in any one military unit, especially those of the fighting arms. This practice was followed by the Indian and Pakistan armies even after independence. However, in the case of the Bengal regiments there was a deviation from the established rules of recruitment, which gave a chance for mass uprising.

⁴¹ Mitinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 221-238.

East Bengal Regiments (EBR)

39. The first and second battalions of the East Bengal Regiment were raised in Kurmitola (Dacca) in 1948. Their class composition was 100 % Bengali. As more and more EBR units were raised and some began serving in West Pakistan also, problems arising out of linguistic and cultural differences began to appear.

40. Firstly, Bengali troops were at a disadvantage as, though they could speak and understand Urdu, they could not read and write it in the Persian script. It was only in 1969 that they were allowed to answer their question papers for promotion examinations in Bengali. Secondly, education of Bengali children in local schools with English or Urdu as the medium of instruction became another issue. The duration of the East Bengal Regiments in West Pakistan, therefore, had to be reduced so as not to deprive the Bengali children of their required education. West Pakistan units in East Pakistan faced similar problems.

41. A total of ten East Bengal Regiments had been raised by March 1971. At the time of the military action they were in the following locations:-

Serial	Units	Raised	Location
a.	1 East Bengal	1948	Jessore
b.	2 East Bengal	1948	Joydebpur
c.	3 East Bengal	1956	Saidpur
d.	4 East Bengal	1963	Comilla
e.	5 East Bengal	1965	Sialkot brought to Lahore in December, 1971.
f.	6 East Bengal	1965	-
g.	7 East Bengal	1969	Malir
h.	8 East Bengal	1970	Chittagong
i.	9 East Bengal	1970	-
j.	10 East Bengal	1970	Dacca Training battalion

42. In addition to the six East Bengal Regiments in East Pakistan at that time which had 100% Bengali troops, there were about 4 to 5 % Bengali elements in all infantry units and formation headquarters stationed in East Pakistan. The proportion in the technical arms and in the air force and navy was even higher. The East Bengal regiments, however, like other units in East Pakistan were, during the long election campaign, split up into companies and platoons and spread along the international frontier occupying border out posts (BOP's); sometimes even in section strength.

East Pakistan Rifles (EPR)

43. The East Pakistan Rifles was formed to guard the border between India and East Bengal in peace time and to reinforce the Pakistan Army in defending its territorial

integrity and national independence in war. The border was divided into the following six sectors: Dhaka, Chittagong, Sylhet, Dinajpur, Rajshahi, and Jessore. Each sector was composed of six wings of 450 men each. Most of the men were Bengalis while their officers came both from East and West Pakistan. Mymensingh had an independent wing. The total strength of the East Pakistan Rifles at the time of the military action by the Pakistan Army was 16,000. There were at that time only 4 Bengali officers in the EPR.

44. The total strength of the Bengali elements in the armed forces and para-military forces in East Pakistan in March, 1971 was about 21,000.

The Link Snaps

45. After March 3, 1971 a defacto Bangladesh had come into existence and the loyalty of the Bengali officers and men had been put to great strain. Ex-servicemen had already formed a para-military force in support of the Awami League. It is remarkable that Bengali personnel in uniform did not desert and go over to the other side during those critical three weeks in March. They must surely have been emotionally very disturbed, not knowing what the future was going to be. But they still were committed to the oath they had taken at the Pakistan Military Academy and in the regimental centres. All that was needed was a spark to ignite a chain reaction which would force them to cast aside the loyalty to one's country.

46. The spark came in the form of a military action when the East Bengal Regiments and the Bengali elements in the East Pakistan Rifles were required to hand over their weapons to the West Pakistanis. Quite expectedly they refused to do so, and when were faced with a military confrontation they rebelled and fought their way into the lap of the enemy, turned protector.

47. On the contrary, many Bengalis who were serving in East Pakistan in the mixed units, where Bengalis were present along with West Pakistani troops did not revolt. According to Kamal Matinuddin, "It was only when the Pakistan Army killed Bengali intellectuals and servicemen that they revolted".

Formation of the Mukti Bahini

48. A colourful account of the creation of Bangladesh and the formation of the Mukti Bahini was given by Mr. Nur-ul-Qader, former deputy commissioner of Pabna, a small town in the north-west of East Pakistan. According to him, when the Pakistan Army re-established control over Pabna which had been 'liberated' by the 'freedom fighters' after March 25, he went to the border village of Chuadanga. He was later joined by

Major Usman of the East Pakistan Rifles who brought with him a company of the EPR with their weapons. On April 8, Qader claims that he was met by Lieutenant Colonel Banerjee of the Indian Army. An Anglo-Indian DC, from the Indian town of Krishannagar, helped Qader to get in touch with Mr Tajuddin Ahmad⁴² who had escaped to Calcutta. Later Qader asked the commandant of the Indian Border Security Force, Lieutenant Colonel Rustamjee and the local Indian Sector commander Golak Mojumdar to request Tajuddin and other Bengali leaders including Colonel Osmani to come to Chuadanga and declare the establishment of the independent republic of Bangladesh and the formation of the Mukti Bahini. On April 10, Syed Nazr-ul-Islam, so-called acting president of Bangladesh, had broadcast the proclamation of the independence of Bangladesh from Mujibnagar, which was located at 8 Theater Road in Calcutta, formerly the offices of the deputy high commission for Pakistan. The visit of Tajuddin to Chuadanga was arranged by the Indians and at 1030 hours on April 17, 1971 Tajuddin is reported to have come to Budhonathtola, just 4 kilometres, from the border near the western village of Mehrpur (a place where Lord Clive had taken over Bengal from the local Muslim chieftain). Colonel Osmani was also present there. A small contingent of the self styled Mukti Bahini presented a guard of honour. A 'war council' was formed. Chairman of the war council was Colonel MAG Osmani. Other members of the council were Major Safiullah, Zia-ur-Rahman, Khalid Musharraf, Nur-ul-Aslam and Rafiq-ul-Islam. Colonel Muhammad Ata-ul-Ghani Osmani was appointed the Commander-in-Chief of the 'Liberation Army' (Mukti Bahini) on 17 April, 1971 at Mujibnagar, the provisional capital of the Bangladesh Government in India.

Organization

49. As a result of the military action a very large number of Bengalis, most of them Hindus had moved across the border. The Indians capitalized on this Vishnu (Hindu God) sent opportunity and, in addition to internationalizing the issue, began to arm, train and organise the refugees to assist them in their plan to dismember Pakistan. These 'illegal immigrants' were sorted out into different categories like: intelligence operators, guerrilla fighters, etc. Members of the East Pakistan para-military forces who had deserted their posts were trained separately to carryout subversion inside East Pakistan. The officers and men of the East Bengal Regiment and East Pakistan Rifles

⁴² He was a prominent leader of the Bengali nationalist Awami League Party, serving as its General Secretary before separation of East Pakistan.

formed the core of the Mukti Fauj, which later changed its name to Mukti Bahini on April 11, 1971.

50. The so-called freedom fighters were grouped into regular units of 500 each. They were, known as Swadhin Bengali Regiments (SBR). Two brigades, each of 3,000 persons, were raised at Tura. A women's wing of the Mukti Bahini was also created. By the end of April the Pakistan Army had been able to gain control of almost all the border posts. The rebels had lost their effectiveness and were in disarray.

51. The Indian armed forces were given the full responsibility to turn the Mukti Bahini into some shape whereby they could assist the Indian Army during their invasion of East Pakistan. A control headquarters was established under the overall supervision of Indian Eastern Command and three sector headquarters were also formed, one each at Agartala, Cooch Behar and Balurghat. Their task was to raise Mukti Bahini companies and to plan and coordinate the activities of the guerrillas. Brigadier Shah Beg and Brigadier Sant Singh, both of the Indian Army, were directed to organize the Mukti Bahini. The former operated from Agartala while the latter established contact with 'Tiger' Siddiqui a Bengali rebel officer at Tura, Mymensingh". Later other senior Indian Army officers were each allotted different sectors.

52. Colonel Osmani divided East Pakistan into ten operational areas, each of which was placed under the supervision of one or more officers of the East Bengal Regiment. The different sectors with name of commanders are given on the map:-

53. Anti-Pakistan resistance forces could be divided into three categories:-

- a. The traditional *British style army units* formed out of the remnants of the East Bengal Regiments. These were under the command of Colonel (later Major General) MAG Osmani. Lawrence Lifshultz, a well known American journalist, describes their living style as "carpeted tents, flowing whisky and surrounded by batmen". This group was based inside India and felt no qualms in accepting the Indian military intervention.
- b. The second category was more *nationalist minded*. Majors Taher and Zia-ud-Din wanted to fight a 'people's war' and liberate Bangladesh by an indigenous uprising without India's military involvement. They preferred to have all sector headquarters inside East Pakistan. They did not want to be indebted to India. In this they were supported by Major Zia-ur-Rahman who wanted minimal assistance from India.

- c. The third group consisted of *private armies* of armed civilians operating from within Bangladesh.

54. In addition to the Mukti Bahini a number of other resistance forces were formed by zealous 'patriots'. The largest of which was the Mujib Bahini which was an elite force and according to Major General KM Safiullah, Mujib Bahini was "drunk with political indoctrination." It consisted of 20,000 devoted *Mujibites* committed to carrying out his instructions to the hilt. The force was split into the eastern sector (Sheikh Moin and Sheikh Kamal, both sons of Sheikh Mujib-ur-Rahman) northern sector (Rafiq) northwestern sector (Sirajul Islam) and the western sector (Tofail Ahmad). The leadership of *Mujibites* was trained at the Indian Military Academy, Dehra Dun. The idea of raising such a force which the Indians hoped would be pro-India in its ideological concepts was the brain child of Major General Oben 'a veteran guerrilla expert of the Indian Army.'

55. The other resistance forces were the Zulu force named after Major Zia-ur-Rahman. Kilo force which took its letter K from Major Khalid Musharraf. This was raised by him in June 1971 and consisted of elements of 4, 9 and 10 East Bengal Regiments, commanded by Gaffar Ainuddin and Jaffer respectively. S Force was created by Major Safiullah (later to become Major General Safiullah and the first Chief of Army Staff of the Bangladesh Army). It consisted of 1, 2 and 11 East Bengal Regiments, a total strength of 11,200 men. Safiullah who, by September, 1971, had promoted himself to the rank of a brigadier commanded this adhoc brigade. Both of his staff officers were from the Indian army. His brigade major was Major Gulati a gunner officer from the Indian artillery and the deputy quarter master general (DQ) was Major DR Nijrawan. It is interesting to note that the Indians were openly providing their own officers to operate within East Pakistan even before November 21.

56. A naval wing of the Mukti Bahini was also put in place. They were trained in underwater operations and by August 1971 three hundred rebels were sent to Cochin for under water training. Another 300 frogmen were trained at Plassey in the river Bhagirathi (West Bengal). They sank ships, destroyed coasters and oil tankers, took over barges, boats and launches. The strength of the Mukti Bahini and its sister organizations continued to rise. By the end of June the rebels were estimated to number 30,000. By November, the figure rose to 70,000 and when the all out war started it had reached around 100,000.



MAP - 2

Training

57. “The resistance needed planning, weapons training and leadership and only India could provide them,” accepted Brigadier Jagdev Singh.⁴³ While the organization of the rebels and volunteers had commenced in April, their proper training by the Indian Army began in May. A total strength of 70,000 Bengali dissidents excluding the police, was available to the Indians. Out of this force, it did not take them long to organize eight equipped and fully trained Mukti Bahini battalions. Six training centres were established in India, each commanded by an Indian brigadier. The six sectors, as they were called, were:-

Serial	Designation	Location	Commander
a.	Alpha Sector	Moorti Camp, W Bengal	Brigadier Joshi
b.	Bravo Sector	Raiganj, W Bengal	Brigadier Prem Singh
c.	Charlie Sector	Chakulia, Bihar	Brigadier NA Naik
d.	Delta Sector	Decta Mura, Tripura	Brigadier Shah Beg Singh
e.	Echo Sector	Masirpur, Assam	Brigadier B Wadia
f.	Foxtrot Sector	Tura, Meghalaya	Brigadier Sant Singh

58. These training sectors provided all the weapons and military equipment needed for training and equipping the Mukti Bahini. Each sector had a number of training camps under it. Over 83 training camps were established (according to some, there were 150 training camps) on Indian soil all along East Pakistan, barely a few kilometers from the border. First two days were spent in documentation followed by three weeks of intense training.

59. An Indian major general was made in-charge of the training of Mukti Bahini. The rebels were reformed into sub-units, units and formations. Between 600-800 officers of the Mukti Bahini were trained at regular Indian Army institutions including the prestigious Indian Military Academy at Dehra Dun. Indian Army engineers trained them in the handling of mines and explosives. They were also given training in the use of mortars, machine guns and PRC-25 wireless sets supplied to them by the Indian Army. Every six weeks 2,000 trained guerrillas were turned out for operational purposes. Over 5,000 men were trained at these camps in three months. About 600 rebels received under water training at Cochin and Plassey (West Bengal).

⁴³ Mitinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 230. Brigadier Jagdev Singh is also an author of a book, *Dismemberment of Pakistan, Indo-Pakistan War 1971* published in 1988.

Weapons

60. Arms and ammunition came from the Indian Ordnance Factories (IOF) with no attempt to hide even the IOP markings. The chief minister of Bihar admitted that he was firm on the point of supply of arms and ammunition to Bangladesh. Arms were also obtained from Poland, Yugoslavia and even America.

61. Though Mujib received weapon supplies from several outside sources but according to several diplomats the bulk of the supply of weapons came from Indian arsenals. Some were also obtained by raiding armouries in East Pakistan. Many were taken away by the Bengali units which deserted. Some crude weapons were prepared by the Mukti Bahinis themselves. These included molotov cocktails, home-made grenades, locally manufactured anti-personnel and anti-tank mines. The Bengalis over the months, before the military action, had been accumulating unlicensed arms. Some 200,000 of them were located after the surrender.

Tactics

62. In *First Phase*, between March and April, the Mukti Bahini was used to support the Indian Border Security Forces in keeping the Pakistan Army away from the international frontier to enable the Indian Army to gain as much information about the trans-border terrain as possible. In the *Second Phase*, from May to July, the Muktis dressed in civilian clothes were required to penetrate deep inside their own country and carry out subversive activities: blowing up of bridges, blocking roads, ambushing convoys and assassinating isolated army personnel. (700 trained guerrillas were inducted into Faridpur district alone by the middle of May). The so-called miscreants, undistinguishable from the rest, were everywhere in East Pakistan, present even in government offices. By day they were ordinary citizens and by night they were guerrillas. An Indian writer accepts that many of them were Hindus wearing *dhotis*. Workers instigated by the Muktis, damaged 38 Jute mills in Khulna and Mymensingh. In the battle of Feni (June 1971), the Mukti Bahini claimed to have killed 500. Mukti Bahini supported by regular Indian troops, attacked and captured Bariab Bazaar on the Indo-East Pakistan border on June 20, 1971. A commando element of two companies led by Lieutenant Colonel Shakurjan had to be dropped by helicopters across the river to recapture the area. In this action the Mukti Bahini suffered 500 casualties. Shakurjan lost one of his men.

63. In the *Third Phase* which began in August, 1971 the Mukti Bahini, supported by Indian artillery fire from across the border, were directed to attack Pakistani border posts

and 'liberate' vulnerable enclaves which could later be used as jump off points by the Indian army. A need was felt to provide some political guidance to the so-called freedom fighters. The Indian government, therefore, formed a political committee of eight activists on September 9, from members of the self-styled Bangladesh government in exile, to ensure a greater control over the Mukti Bahini.

64. By October, 1971 the Mukti Bahini had carried out extensive explosions in private and public places. They attacked government offices and godowns, damaged bridges and railway lines, disrupted electric supply lines, robbed banks and killed innocent men, women and children whom they suspected of collaborating with the government. As the date for the Indian attack came near, the rebellious units of the EBR along with Indian Army personnel, tried to capture areas of strategic importance. In this they were supported not only by tanks and artillery but they received the support of the Indian Air Force as well. Belonia salient in the East was attacked on 8/ 9 November, Bhurigram in the north on night 13/ 14 November. These were preliminary operations carried out at the battalion level, even before the all out attack by the Indian armed forces on East Pakistan which began on November 21. The casualties were evacuated to Indian medical centres where they were given medical treatment and the sick and wounded were looked after.

65. By mid-November highly exaggerated reports, for the consumption of the international media, of the achievement of the Mukti Bahini, started coming in. Over 25,000 regular soldiers of Pakistan were reported killed. They claimed that out of five divisions atleast three had been put out of commission by November 21. Not even 10 % of what was being put across was, however, true. The effectiveness of the Mukti Bahini was grossly inflated to build up their morale, lower that of the Pakistan Army and gain more international support.

Effectiveness of Mukti Bahini

66. An interesting aspect of the Mukti Bahini's fighting qualities was depicted by an Indian writer. He mentions that the rebels were mortally afraid of the Pathans. Indian army officers were often asked by some of the chicken-hearted mutineers, "*Pathan marya hai ye nahin*" (Has the Pathan been killed or is he still alive)." *Agar mara nahin to agay nahin jaaon ga*" (If he has not been killed we will not move forward). General Aurora while commenting on the performance of the Mukti Bahini said that the Bengalis had paranoia from the Punjabi Musalman. "They would not get anywhere close enough to them. They only sent small *chokras*' (boys) to gain information" said Aurora.

67. The main contribution of the Mukti Bahini was in giving the latest information about Pakistan Army locations and strength, finding out gaps in the minefields and the current state of communications. It was the Mukti Bahini who informed the Indians that the Pakistani troops had retreated from one place to another. This allowed the Indians to advance into Jessore with impunity. "We had the Mukti Bahini on our side. It was due to them that the Pakistan Army got disorganised and isolated," said General Aurora.

68. Nevertheless, during this period, Mrs Indira Gandhi, kept on insisting that her government was only providing humanitarian assistance to the refugees. She did not allow western observers to go and study the situation along the Indo-East Pakistan border for fear of their coming to know about the presence of the training camps established by the Indians to train the Mukti Bahini. Although Morarji Desai, a former prime minister of India, did admit that not only did the Indian Army train the Mukti Bahini, the Indian soldiers disguised as Mukti Bahini had been fighting the Pakistan Army in East Pakistan from April to December 71.

OPERATION SEARCHLIGHT⁴⁴

69. Lieutenant General Sahibzada Yaqub Khan, commander of the Eastern Theatre had, in February 1971, prepared plans for dealing with an insurgency situation in East Pakistan. The plan was code-named Operation BLITZ. He was, however aware that a military action alone was not the solution to the political impasse. "I need hardly mention that Operation BLITZ will not and should not be an end in itself but must be followed immediately by the projection of political and economic progress at the national level. Such a course would be an essential sequel to this fire brigade action for the wheel would only then be turned full circle", wrote Yaqub to Yahya.

Law and Order Situation Worsens

70. The situation in East Pakistan after the postponement of the National Assembly session was fast deteriorating. Sheikh Mujibur Rehman had given the call for a virtual takeover of the administration of the province by his supporters which, by now, included almost all politicians, the majority of bureaucrats and a large number of the members of the Bengali elements in the armed forces besides the entire Bengali civil population. Although, all the personalities interviewed at Dacca categorically denied that the militants of the Awami League massacred the non-Bengalis even before the military crackdown by the Pakistan Army, however, there was ample evidence to prove that they went on a rampage as soon as the announcement of postponing the National Assembly session was made on March 1. The scene immediately prior to the proposed military action was of complete disorder and total disregard of governmental authority.

71. General Yahya had by then lost complete faith in his military commanders in the eastern theatre. "A first class army in East Pakistan is completely demoralized because of two old women", remarked the President to General Tikka Khan. Implying that if a firm action had been taken earlier things would not have gone out of hand. Yahya's insistence for a military action forced Lieutenant General Yaqub Khan to resign. He was replaced by Lieutenat General Tikka. There were only two alternatives at that stage. Order the army to restore the authority of the government or hand over powers to the majority party. The military junta was split on the question of suppressing the insurgency by a military action. Those in East Pakistan were not in favour of it as they had been witnessing the growing popularity of the Awami League in that province. They knew that even after eliminating the die-hard secessionists, the movement in favour of the *Six Points Formula* would not die down. They were concerned about the mass killings on

⁴⁴ Mitinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 241-271.

both sides which were bound to follow once the army was given a free hand to deal with all those elements which had bottled them up and were humiliating them at every corner. Those in West Pakistan were advocating a strong military action.

Operation SEARCHLIGHT

72. The military authorities in East Pakistan were completely ignored during the political negotiations which had begun in Dacca on March 15. The decision for suppressing the insurgency in East Pakistan by military force, if it becomes necessary, was made on March 22, 1971 at a meeting between the president, the governor and the martial law administrator at Dacca. No party leader opposed the use of force to re-instate the government's authority. On March 23, Pakistan's National Day, Dacca wore a grim look. Instead of the Pakistani flag, black flags fluttered on every house and vehicle. On the afternoon of March 23, when Dacca had given its unanimous vote against a United Pakistan the armed forces chiefs also conveyed their recommendation of a military action; Yahya declared the emergency plan to restore law and order on that very day.

73. However, it was not till March 24, that the final decision to crush the Awami League and its supporters was taken. All avenues for seeking a political solution, short of making Pakistan into a confederation, had been explored with no effect. No amount of persuasion, reasoning or discussion had made Mujib or Bhutto change their rigid stand. The fault of postponing the National Assembly session was to be followed by another one, the military action. The point of no return had arrived. Yahya called General Tikka Khan and Major General Rao Farman and asked them to finalize the operation orders for Operation SEARCHLIGHT. The plan prepared earlier by Farman was given the final touches.

Objectives of Operation SEARCHLIGHT

74. The long term objectives of Operation SEARCHLIGHT were:-

- a. To seal-off the borders.
- b. To create conditions for selecting a civilian set up.
- c. To regain the administration of the province.
- d. To accommodate the non-radical elements of the elected representatives into a new political arrangement.

75. The immediate objectives of the military crackdown were:-

- a. Disarming all Bengali troops. This meant taking away weapons from the six East Bengal Regiments, the 30,000 (personnel of the East Pakistan

Rifles and the police. The reaction of such an action on the Bengali troops in the mixed units was/ not, however, assessed.

- b. Arresting of all prominent Awami League leaders.
- c. Imposing of martial law strictly.
- d. Controlling of all airfields.
- e. Securing of the Chittagong naval base.
- f. Ensuring the security of all towns.
- g. Cutting off East Pakistan from the rest of the world in terms of communication links.
- h. Taking away Radio and TV stations from the clutches of the Awami League and placing them again under the control of the government.

76. A major difference between previous military actions and the one to be carried out in East Pakistan in March, 1971 was that the military action this time was to be carried out in a civil war situation and not in Aid of Civil Power as all authority had passed into the hands of the Awami League. Whereas, all the objectives were to be achieved as early as possible, the first action to be carried out was to deprive the Awami League of its leadership.

77. The troops available to General Tikka to carry out this stupendous task were:-

- a. 14 Infantry Division consisting of four infantry brigades, an armoured regiment, five artillery regiments, two mortar batteries, one light anti-aircraft battery, one commando battalion.
- b. The six East Bengal Regiments and the 16,000 strong East Pakistan Rifles were to be disarmed hence would not be part of the force required to re-instate the writ of the Centre. In fact, as events eventually turned out they joined the rebels.
- c. In all, therefore, General Tikka had about 12,000 men in uniform from West Pakistan and 13 battalions of Mujahids and Razakars against over 100,00 armed Bengalis and 60 million volatile local population spread over 55,000 square miles of isolated territory cut up by non-negotiable rivers and streams.

The Crackdown

78. It did not come too soon. If a pre-emptive strike had not been taken Colonel Osmani's plan would have come into action. The EBR and EPR were to rebel and capture Dacca airfield and the Chittagong sea port. The defecting police and EPR units

were to control the city while the EBR was to storm the Dacca cantonment on the night of 25/ 26 March. Key posts along the Indo-Pakistan frontier were to be occupied to facilitate receipt of assistance from India.

79. In such an environment, Pakistan Army began the military crack-down at 0100 hours, on the night 25/ 26 March 1971. The next day Major Zia-ur-Rahman's voice on the radio proclaimed East Pakistan as People's Republic of Bangladesh. "Today Bangladesh is a sovereign and independent state," said a voice from a clandestine radio station. General Yahya Khan on arrival at Karachi let out his anger and frustration by outlawing the Awami League, banning all political parties, imposing complete press censorship and denouncing Mujib's action as an act of treason.

80. Sheikh Mujib-ur-Rehman was arrested from his Dhonmandi residence by a swift action. Dr Kamal Hussein surrendered without resistance on April 4, at Dacca. All other leaders of the Awami League escaped to India.

Dacca University

81. The Dacca University was made the first target of the military action on the night between 25/ 26 March. Dacca University had several hostels called halls: Jinnah Hall was the residence of junior lecturers and all in-house-teachers, Jagannath Hall accommodated the Hindu students; Iqbal Hall was the centre piece of all political activity, Roqaya Hall was meant for all girl students. Jagannath Hall was barricaded. It was surrounded by barbed wire and within its perimeter '*Mukti Jogda*' (freedom fighters) received their training using dummy and service rifles. The university area harboured most of the armed dissidents and had become a stronghold of the rebellious students, professors and other intellectuals.

82. 18 Punjab Regiment, part of 57 Infantry Brigade, was given the task to clear the university of all rebellious elements. It was a difficult task as it involved fighting in a built up area. The battalion was, therefore, given the support of tanks and artillery in the hope that the rumbling of tanks and the presence of guns near the university would compel the students to give up their weapons and surrender. But that was not to be. A full scale military operation had to be launched. Machine gun fire, mortar shells and recoilless rifles had to be used. Even tanks and artillery had to come into action. Each room of the Jagannath Hall had to be individually flushed out. Iqbal Hall and Roqaya Hall were also fired upon and later searched for incriminating evidence. By 0400 hours, a deadly silence descended on the once humming university campus. The official casualty in the military action in the university area that night was 66 Bengali rebels dead, 31 injured, 4

army jawans lost their lives defending the territorial integrity of Pakistan against its own citizens. He accepted that it was an overreaction and over kill by the troops under his command.

83. Tikka Khan drove around Dacca on March 26 to check the results of the military action. On the way he saw that all Bangladesh flags had disappeared and Pakistan flags had taken their place. He was visibly relieved as the open defiance against the government had at least temporarily subsided. After three days of military action in Dacca and its surrounding areas all was quiet, it did not strike him that the result achieved was through fear and that no Bengali had changed his support to the Awami League. In fact the hatred had increased.

East Bengal Regiments Rebellion

84. **1 East Bengal Regiment.** Commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Raza-ul-Jalil, a Bengali Officer, it was located at Jessore. On March 29, when the commanding officer of 1 East Bengal was informed by his brigade commander that his battalion was to be disarmed he got furious. "It is an insult, this means that I am not being trusted," retorted Raza-ul-Jalil. A compromise solution was worked out. It was mutually agreed that the weapons would be deposited in the kotes (armoury) and the keys handed over to the brigade commander. The next day when the brigade commander came to collect the keys CO 1 East Bengal tore off his badges of rank and along with the keys threw them on the ground in front of his brigade commander. Simultaneously, 1 East Bengal opened fire on 22 and 25 Baloch which had accompanied the commander to forestall any resistance. The two West Pakistani manned battalions replied in kind. Two guns of 55 Field Regiment were ordered to fire directly into the quarterguard of 1 East Bengal. 1 East Bengal retreated into the area of the ranges. A full scale attack by two infantry battalions supported by a field regiment was mounted against 1 East Bengal at about 1600 hours the same day. The East Bengal regiment was finally overpowered and 130, Bengali soldiers were 'captured'.

85. **2 East Bengal Regiment.** It was located at the old palace at Joydebpur (Map - 18) and had been split into companies and platoons. A company was at Tangail, another at Mymensingh, one platoon of the third company was at Rajenderpur and one platoon at Ghazipur. Its task was to enforce law and order. The battalion was commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Masaudul Hussain Khan an officer hailing from East Pakistan. The second-in-command was Major KM Safiullah, also a Bengali officer. Safiullah recalls with pride that after March 1, (when the National Assembly session had

been postponed) he no longer felt obliged to remain loyal to the West Pakistan officers. He decided to support the Awami League and awaited orders from Sheikh Mujibur Rehman.

86. 2 East Bengal began to ambush the Pakistan Army around Mymensingh and in the vicinity of the Madhupur forests which remained their sanctuary for some time. They blew up bridges the most important one being the Ranipur railway bridge across the river Ganges. The unit later moved across to India through Rajshahi, virtually intact. 2 East Bengal had four West Pakistani officers and a few West Pakistani soldiers. All of them were killed by Safiullah's men.

87. **3 East Bengal Regiment.** It was stationed at Saidpur along with 26 Frontier Force Regiment and 23 Field Regiment Artillery. The city and its surrounding villages had a very large Urdu speaking population of Biharis whose interest lay in a United Pakistan. To avoid being confronted by his own battalion in view of the political developments which were fast coming to a head, Lieutenant Colonel Manzoor Ahmad, a West Pakistani commanding officer of 3 East Bengal Regiment, sent his subunits out in different directions for winter collective training. A company was dispatched to Dinajpur, 30 miles to the southwest and another company to Bogra, 60 miles to the south-east. The battalion headquarters and two companies stayed in Saidpur. 23 Field was occupying Azam quarters a couple of hundreds metres away from 3 East Bengal. Brigadier Shafi was given the task to disarm 3 East Bengal elements. Two units of the same army clashed on April 1. After a short and bitter action in which guns were used at ranges of only 800 yards men of 3 East Bengal were overpowered. 40 to 50 of them were taken 'prisoners'. Others ran away with their weapons to Parbatipur, a railway station some 10 miles away leaving behind 69 dead. 26 FF suffered eight casualties. Remnants of 3 East Bengal who had fled to Parbatipur remained entrenched there.

88. Two companies of 26 FF finally cleared Parbatipur but could not prevent the remnants of 3 East Bengal from fleeing to Dinajpur where they amalgamated themselves with their comrades in that town. The company of 3 East Bengal at Dinajpur joined hands with the wing of East Pakistan Rifles and the two together took over Dinajpur. They killed the West Pakistani officers and men including the commanding officer and his second-in-command. Later 26 FF, supported by a battery of 23 Field, had to mount a major operation to retake Dinajpur from the rebels. When Shafi entered Dinajpur he saw both banks of the Kanchan river littered with thousands of bloated dead bodies. The non-Bengalis in Dinajpur had been butchered mercilessly. Aslam Azhar

from Pakistan television who was accompanying Brigadier Abdullah Malik and Colonel Shafi recorded the massacre on his TV cameras. Dinajpur was cleared within a day.

89. 23 Field Regiment was also responsible for clearing Rangpur, and Bogra areas (northern East Bengal). The area of Rangpur was cleared without much resistance from the Bengali elements who had rebelled. However, it faced resistance while securing Bogra, which saw an open fight between the secessionists and the loyalist. The regiment, as a last resort, had to use arty to flush out the mutineers. Bogra was eventually cleared by the end of April but not before hundreds of lives were lost including civilians who were caught in the cross fire. Further north at Thakurgaon the East Pakistan Rifles mutinied and killed their West Pakistani commanding officer. The Bengali elements of 29 Cavalry at Rangpur, however gave up their weapons without resistance.

90. **4 East Bengal Regiment.** Located at Brahmanbaria (Comilla) commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Khizar Hayat from West Pakistan, could not be disarmed. It's second-in-command, Major Khalid Musharraf, placed his West Pakistani officers including his commanding officer under arrest and moved his battalion across to Agartala, in India, intact.

91. **8 East Bengal Regiment.** Commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Abdur Rasheed Janjua, of number 8 platoon, 9th PMA course, was located at Chittagong. He sent his second-in-command, Major Ziaur Rehman to the port to oversee the unloading of a ship from West Pakistan. Zia, however, did not go to the port and soon returned back. It was still dark when Zia woke up his CO and took him into custody. Janjua was soon, thereafter, shot dead by his own batman. Major Zia-ur-Rahman was the first Bengali officer to declare the independence of Bangladesh from a clandestine radio station which he had established at Kalurghat near Cox's Bazar.

92. Major Zia put up the maximum resistance as Chittagong had a very large number of Bengali troops at the East Bengal Regimental Centre and with the East Pakistan Rifles. 20 Baloch the only West Pakistani battalion in Chittagong was heavily outnumbered (20 to 1).

93. Troops available to suppress the insurgency in Chittagong were: HQ 53 Brigade at Comilla under Brigadier Iqbal Shafi; 24 FF located at Comilla; 20 Baloch located at Chittagong; and 63 Field Regiment. 25 FF which had arrived from Karachi on March 26, was flown to Chittagong the same night to reinforce 20 Baloch. Brigadier MH Ansari, the Logistic Area Commander at Chittagong, was asked to assume command of all troops in

the Chittagong area, till relieved by Major General Khadim Hussain Raja who flew into Chittagong along with Lieutenant Colonel Suleiman, CO 2 Commando Battalion. A company of 2 Commando Battalion was also moved to Chittagong.

94. Brigadier Iqbal Shafi was ordered to move to Chittagong with 24 FF to relieve pressure on 20 Baloch. He left 53 Field Regiment to guard Comilla and proceeded towards Chittagong. All went well till he reached Kumera on the outskirts of Chittagong. A road block on March 28, established by a company of 8 East Bengal Regiment prevented his further movement towards the city. A company of 24 FF tried to out flank the road block but it was ambushed. 24 FF, then led its second company to extricate those who had been surrounded. A naval gun boat lying just off the coast also joined the battle.

95. Brigadier Iqbal Shafi then took over the command of 24 FF. 2 Commando was ordered to link up with 24 FF which was trying to clear the road block a few miles away. At 1700 hours on March 29, Ghazi Company of 2 Commando Battalion was also ambushed by the rebels; Commanding Officer (CO) and 21 others got killed. By March 29, the road block was cleared and Iqbal Shafi reached the outskirts of Chittagong next day. He finally reached Chittagong on March 31, and linked up with the garrison in that city. On 1 April, the East Pakistan Rifles headquarters in Chittagong was captured. The same day the clandestine radio station was destroyed by an air strike. By 10 April, the river port of Chandpur was cleared by 33 Baloch and 12 FF had secured the area of Laksham.

East Pakistan Rifles

96. One thousand personnel at the East Pakistan Rifles headquarters at Peelkhana, Dhaka, were disarmed without too many casualties. However, Rajshahi the largest town in western sectors of East Pakistan came under the control of the rebels of the East Pakistan Rifles immediately after the commencement of the military action. Two companies of 25 Punjab located at Rajshahi were surrounded by the EPR. Its two companies had earlier been wiped out by the rebels. General Tikka ordered Brigadier Arbab to re-establish the government's writ in Rajshahi which was the centre of Awami League activities. The Rajshahi University was the focal point of all dissident elements. Rajshahi was about 150 miles northwest of Dacca and was separated from it by the Ganges and the Jamuna rivers each several miles wide. It lay close to the Indo-East Pakistan border. Three separate columns advanced towards Rajshahi. The brigade headquarters with a battalion plus two companies moved by road on night between 7

and 8 April. Another column, battalion-strong, went by boat. A third force was landed in Rajshahi by helicopters.

97. Arbab's force was supported by 31 Field Regiment. The force secured Rajshahi without major casualties to either side by 12 April. Because of this military operation a large number of Bengalis fled to India, adding to the increasing number of refugees which helped India to capitalise on the tragic developments in East Pakistan. A company of 27 Baloch located at Kushtia was isolated from the rest and could not defend itself against the mass frenzy of the locals. It was completely wiped out. Kushtia was eventually cleared by 13 FF on 15 April.

More Troops Arrive

98. General Tikka Khan realized that he would need more troops to quell the insurgency. He sent an assessment of the situation to Headquarters CMLA and to General Headquarters and requested for reinforcements. These began to arrive from 1 April onwards at the rate of a battalion a day but they came without their heavy weapons and without the support of their direct support artillery. This deficiency greatly affected their performance in the war which was by now looming on the horizon. On the return flight West Pakistani families were flown back. 9 Infantry Division and 16 Infantry Division reached East Pakistan by the first week of April.

99. Throughout April and May West Pakistani troops were engaged in clearing road blocks, flushing enclaves from where Mukti Bahini were operating, securing river ports and communication centres, pushing back rebels occupying strategic hill tops and road/rail junctions, not without suffering casualties.

100. In an attempt to seal the borders the formations were being split up into penny pockets. Frequent patrolling exhausted the troops. To enable supplies to be transported inland from the port of Chittagong secure road, rail and inland water transportation was necessary. Boats were not available without local help which was being denied. Mines, ambushes, lack of cooperation from the local and Indian armed intervention all added to the difficulties. Rebels from EBR, EPR, and police entrenched themselves in thick jungles and across formidable rivers. All such pockets of resistance had to be individually eliminated. Dispersion of troops to carryout counter insurgency operations in a very hostile environment became a necessity. It however, had a very adverse effect on the morale of the troops as they were often isolated and cut off from their units and formations for long periods. Large scale killings of unarmed civilians also by the troops demoralized the soldiers.

Casualties

101. The 'civil war' that erupted after March 25, claimed a considerable amount of casualties on both sides as it was a full scale military operation to suppress an armed uprising which had the support of not only the local population but also the encouragement and assistance of an outside power. Mujib claimed that over 3 million were killed during the military crackdown. Indians reduced the figure to 1 million. General Tikka Khan admitted 34,000 casualties. The missionaries in East Pakistan estimated a loss of life of about 30,000.

102. Casualties suffered by the Pakistan Army in the counter insurgency operations between March to November, 1971 were 237 officers, 136 JCOs and 3,559 other ranks killed and wounded.

After Effects of the Military Action

103. By 31 May, the insurrection by the East Bengal Regiments, the East Pakistan Rifles, the police and other paramilitary forces was suppressed and the writ of the government had been restored. West Pakistani troops had occupied almost all of the BOPs and the area in between had in most cases been cleared. However a large number of Bengali troops both from the regular army, the para military forces and the police had gone over to India taking with them their weapons and whatever ammunition they could carry. They formed the core of the Mukti Bahini. One hundred and thirty Bengali diplomats serving abroad defected. Not handing over power to the majority party, after the elections, had already drawn adverse comments in western democracies. The military action, dubbed as genocide, added to the antipathy against Pakistan in several world capitals. The bitterness against West Pakistan leadership in general and Pakistan Army in particular had increased manifold.

104. Although it is generally believed that the military action was successful and all that was needed was to restart political negotiations, the reality of the situation in East Pakistan was that nothing now could undo the error. Even those who were sitting on the fence, or those who were favourably inclined towards a settlement within Pakistan were disillusioned and turned against West Pakistan. Shamsud Doha, general secretary of the Awami League, Rawalpindi branch, said that he was a Pakistani till March 26. After which he was in favour of secession. Munir-ul-Hussein, son of Manik Mian of the daily Ittefaq, Dacca, giving his impression of the military action remarked "Pakistan was finished on that day." Professor Taluqdar of the Dacca University maintained that he was Pro-Pakistan before March 25, but not thereafter. Professor Shamsul Haq (later

foreign minister of Bangladesh) called the “military activity quite illogical.” Enam Choudhry, a very sobre and mature Bengali bureaucrat felt that the military crack-down should have been more selective and targeted only against the die-hards.

105. Before the military action took place all of the thirty five foreign journalists were expelled. They moved over to Calcutta. The Indians escorted them to the border and even into East Bengal from where they covered the events. Angry at being thrown out unceremoniously from Dacca they exaggerated the ‘atrocities’ committed by the Pakistani troops during the operation ‘clean up’. General Tikka accepted the mistake in forcing the foreign correspondents to leave East Pakistan. Brigadier AR Siddiqui, editor of the Defence Journal, Karachi, then principal public relations officer in Eastern Command Headquarters, however, defended his advice to General Tikka to keep the foreigners away. His argument was that they would have seen much more than what they actually saw from their vantage point in India hinting that just as well they were not there to report the actual casualties. Sitreps from East Pakistan to CMLA Headquarters failed to report the true picture. They gave no details of casualties and when they did so it was greatly minimized. Sitreps dated 30 and 31 March, 1971 mentioned that the situation in Dacca and other cities was fast returning to normal. No in-depth study of the mood of the people of East Pakistan after the military action was made by the intelligence agencies. No investigative reporting was carried out.

106. Out of the eight immediate objectives of Operation SEARCHLIGHT only a few could be achieved and that too partially. Some, but not all, of the six East Bengal Regiments were indeed disarmed. Those that went across to India almost intact with their weapons formed the core of the Mukti Bahini. Only two of the die-hard Awami League leaders were arrested. Although they were clever enough to be frequently on the move the intelligence agencies should have kept a tag on them especially when it was becoming obvious that an action against them would probably be necessary. If the majority of the Awami League stalwarts would have been taken into custody the secessionists would have needed more time to reorganise themselves.

107. Although all major towns were secured, the countryside was still under the control of the dissidents and the mobility of the army remained restricted and it's security jeopardized. Radio and TV stations came once again under the control of the government but clandestine radio stations operating from Indian territory continued to wage psychological warfare against Pakistan. News about the so-called genocide in East Pakistan, therefore, was still being picked up by the international media. Except for

resuming the administration of the province the long term objectives were also not achieved as the border could not be sealed, conditions for selecting a civilian set up was only partially obtained and a new political arrangement accommodating the non-radical elements of the elected representatives proved to be only a show piece.

108. Military action was launched to restore the authority of the government and save the country from total disintegration. This action was mostly directed at the elimination of the rebellious elements of the East Bengal Regiment and the East Pakistan Rifles and other 2nd Line Forces including the civil police. It was directed against the Awami League supporters and other rebel groups who tried to resist the military forces in their attempt to restore normal conditions but it did not yield the desired result.



MAP – 3

- | | | |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------|
| 1. South-western Sector | 2. North-western Sector | 3. Central Sector |
| 4. North-eastern Sector | 5. Mid & South-eastern Sector | |

PART – II**THE WAR: PLAYING THE LAST ACT****Terrain**

109. East Pakistan, separated by more than 1600 kilometres from West Pakistan, was surrounded on three sides by hostile Indian territory. On the fourth side lay the Bay of Bengal which could easily be dominated or blocked by the Indian Navy. Only a small tip on the south-eastern border had an opening towards Burma. The communication infrastructure in East Pakistan was poor. Most of its roads ended on river banks from where the loads had to be transferred on to steamers. It had Chittagong and Khulna as two sea-going ports.

110. Geographically, East Pakistan had several advantages. It lay between West Bengal and Assam and the narrow neck joining the two could be cut off provided sufficient troops could be spared for such an offensive operation while keeping the defences intact. Calcutta the pride of India and its economic soul was only thirty miles away. It was well within range of the Pakistan Air Force stationed in East Pakistan. Any movement of ground forces in the direction of Calcutta could cause a panic in the sprawling city of 10 million people. The dissident elements of Nagas and Mizo could be encouraged to rise up against the central government in New Delhi. China could contain a fair amount of Indian forces along its border, during the period when Himalayan passes were not snow bound.⁴⁵

111. East Pakistan also had its vulnerabilities. A number of salients jutting into Indian territory could easily be chopped off. All communications, to Chittagong and Sylhet could be cut off without difficulty as the rail and road network passed very close to the international border. Then, due to major water obstacles the defence had to be compartmentalised. The concept of keeping central reserves would not work as movement to threatened sectors would take a considerable amount of time. With hardly any air-lift capability it would be virtually impossible to react to an enemy threat in time.⁴⁶

112. Terrain-wise, the Province could be distinguished into five sub-sectors (Map – 3). The *Southwestern Sub-sector* located between the Bay of Bengal and Ganges, while the *Northwestern Sub-sector* was bounded by Ganges and Jamuna. The *Central Sub-sector* was wedged in north between the Jamuna and Brahmaputra/ Meghna. Whereas, along the eastern border with India, the province had two sectors: *Northeastern Sector*

⁴⁵ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 334.

⁴⁶ Ibid., 334-35.

till Feni in the south, and *Mid and Southeastern Sector* having Feni in the north and Chittagong. Dacca was in the centre, secured from three sides by major rivers. The only approach to Dacca which did not need the crossing of a major river was from the north.

Enemy

113. Two Indian divisions, under 2 Corps, were deployed in West Bengal against Southwestern Sector while three more divisions, under 33 Corps, were earmarked for operations against Northwestern Sector. For Central Sector stood her 101 Communication Zone, which had been converted into a fighting formation and placed under a major general. Along our eastern sectors were deployed three divisions under 4 Corps. These three corps, consisting of eight divisions and one communication zone, had their full complement of armour and artillery with them. India also had one brigade of paratroops. It had complete air and naval dominance.

114. What were the Indian objectives in East Pakistan? In 1971 many Pakistani strategists assessed that India aimed at nothing higher than capturing a “sizeable chunk of territory to establish Bangladesh” so that she could shift the headquarters of the Bangladesh Government from Calcutta to East Pakistan and transfer the bulk of her refugee burden to the “liberated area”. It would be a constant irritant for Pakistan – much to the relief of India.⁴⁷

Own Situation

115. For our part, we had five lightly equipped infantry divisions (two out of these were adhoc divisions), one squadron of Sabres and four gun-boats to meet this huge Indian force. Besides this military strength, we had about 73, 000 paramilitary personnel including East Pakistan Civil Armed Forces, Scouts, Mujahids and Razakars.

116. After March 1971 military crackdown, the troops were deployed to deny this sizable chunk of territory to the rebels or their Indian patrons. They fulfilled this role for about eight months, and deserve all credit for it. But during this period, India did not unleash her mighty war machine to slice off any sizable territory. She knew this would mean total war. And this she did not want unless she had tied up all loose ends.

117. By November 1971, most of the troops had been living in water logged bunkers, their feet rotten by slime, their skins ravaged by vermin and their minds clogged by an incomprehensible conflict.

118. How best could East Pakistan be defended, was a question that had agitated the minds of Lieutenant General Niazi and his predecessors. The Corps based its defences

⁴⁷ Siddiq Salik, *Witness to Surrender* (Karachi: Oxford University Press, 1977), 123.

on two contingencies: *Contingency A* – A local uprising with India providing moral and material support but not carrying out a physical attack; *Contingency B* – A major insurgency accompanied by India invading East Pakistan.⁴⁸

119. In *Contingency A*: a forward posture was to be adopted. Troops were to be thinly deployed and strung out all along the border to deal with uprisings anywhere in East Pakistan and to prevent the capture of any chunk of territory by rebellious elements. In *Contingency B*: the main defences were to be around Dacca which was to be strongly defended with light elements deployed ahead to delay the enemy advance towards the capital. Sufficient time was to be given to shift from *Contingency A* to *B*.⁴⁹

120. This was in keeping with the General Headquarters' (GHQ) earlier directive of August, 1967 which said, "In the East Pakistan contain and neutralise as many enemy troops as possible inflicting maximum casualties without running the risk of annihilation." On 12 November 1969, an Operational Directive specific to Eastern Command was issued by GHQ which stated the mission to 3 Corps (Eastern Command) in just five simple words – "3 Corps will defend East Pakistan." It also spelt out certain assumptions. These were: (1) we can expect to get a warning of an attack by India upto a maximum of seven days; (2) initiative of starting hostilities will lie with India; (3) main effort will be directed against West Pakistan resulting in major and decisive battles to be fought in the western theatre; (4) normal communication between East and West Pakistan will be disrupted; (5) China's support will be confined to political statements and demonstrations along the Sino-Indian Border and (6) the Pakistan Army should be prepared to continue full scale military operations for atleast three months. As we shall see later, four out of six assumptions specified by the GHQ came true.⁵⁰

121. Eastern Command carried out deployment of her forces as per *Contingency A*. Its planning was based on the earlier evaluation of the enemy threat shared with it by GHQ which visualised the possibility of main offensive being launched in the Northwestern sub-sector with possible auxiliaries in the East. However, around 19 November, the later assessment was that enemy main thrust would come through Agartala.⁵¹

122. The only alternative that the Eastern Command made in their existing plans to meet this new development was to create an adhoc division under Major General Rahim

⁴⁸ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 339.

⁴⁹ Ibid.

⁵⁰ Ibid.

⁵¹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission of Inquiry into the 1971 War*, (Islamabad: Vanguard Books Private Limited, 2003), 419.

Khan called 39-A Division by dividing the former area of responsibility of 14 Division. The area from Comilla, downwards to Chittagong, already described as Mid and South-eastern Sector, was made the area of responsibility of this new division.⁵²

123. Broadly, the operational plan evolved by Eastern Command envisaged the following course of action:-⁵³

- a. The troops deployed on the border would fight on till they were ordered by the General Officer Commanding to withdraw.
- b. While withdrawing to the fortresses they would fight delaying actions so as to "trade space for time".
- c. Finally, they would occupy and defend the fortresses to the end.

124. The plan sounded very reasonable under the circumstances. Nobody raised any serious objections to it. It was presented to General Hamid⁵⁴ during one of his visits to Dacca. He accepted it in principle. Later, it was submitted to GHQ where it was approved with following recommendations:-⁵⁵

- a. Offensive action against English Bazar (northwest of Nawabganj) should be reinforced in the plan.
- b. The plan should incorporate a commando action to destroy or damage Farakka Barrage.
- c. One infantry battalion should form the nucleus in Chittagong.
- d. Dacca should be treated as the "lynch-pin" for the defence of East Pakistan.

125. General Niazi confirmed to the GHQ that all the recommendations had been incorporated in the plan. That seemed to settle the matter.⁵⁶

126. The Indians started an all-out invasion of East Pakistan on 21 November 1971. It was the day of *Eid-ul-Fitr*. Detailed conduct of military operations, from 21 November to 16 December, in each sector of East Pakistan is given next.

⁵² *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 420.

⁵³ Salik, *Witness to Surrender*, 125-26.

⁵⁴ General Abdul Hamid Khan was Chief of Staff Pakistan Army 1969-71.

⁵⁵ Salik, *Witness to Surrender*, 125-26.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.*, 126.

SOUTH-WESTERN SECTOR

The Area of Operation⁵⁷

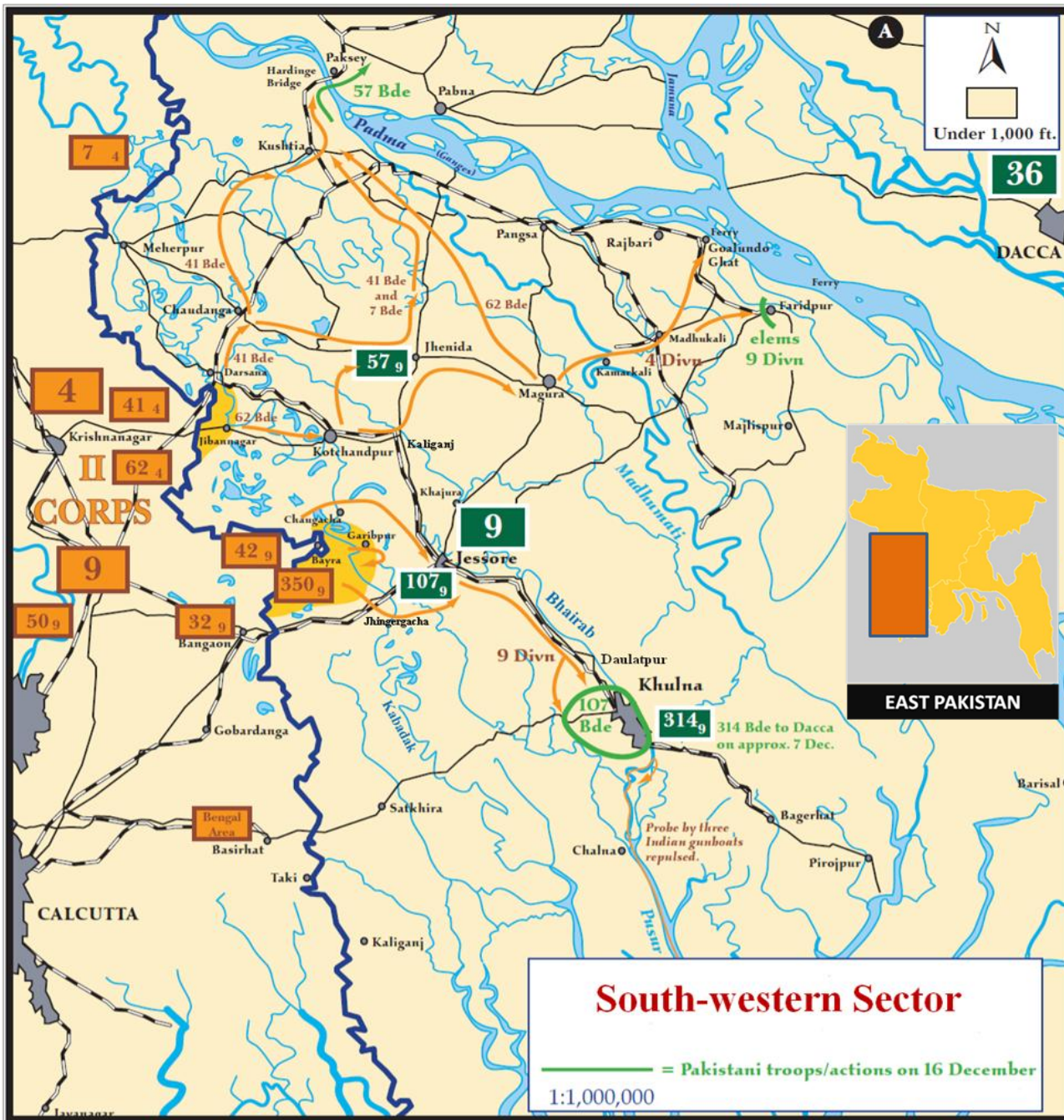
127. General

- a. The South-western Sector was bounded by the Ganges on the north and east, the Bay of Bengal in the south and international border of nearly 600 kilometres with India in the west. (Map – 3).
- b. The grain of the country was from north to south, and the area south of Jessore was deltaic around Khulna. The Sunderbans in the southern portion consisted of numerous water channels, rivulets and thick forests. This sector also had vast number of marshy lakes along the western border which imposed restrictions on manoeuvre.
- c. Jessore was the most prestigious town, with an important cantonment, in this sector.
- d. The South-western Sector could be divided into three sub-sectors: Kushtia Sub-sector in the north, having its southern boundary running along Jibbanagar, Kaliganj and Arpara; Jessore Sub-sector in the centre with its bounds marked by Kesabpur and Daulatpur; and lastly was the Khulna Sub-sector cupped by the Bay of Bengal.

128. Rivers

- a. The South-western Sector terrain was compartmentalised by different rivulets and nullahs, emanating from the main rivers, namely, the Ganges and the Jamuna dispersed through the entire area from the Indian border in the west to the main rivers in the north and east.
- b. Important rivers were (Map – 4):-
 - (1) *River Ganges/ Padma*. Entered East Pakistan from the west and marked the northern boundary of this sector. Joined Jamuna in the northeast and then turned south. Here it became a major obstacle sprawling over miles.

⁵⁷ Most of details about the Area of Operation have been taken from following books: (a) Major General Lachhman Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan* (New Delhi: Vikas Publishing House Private Limited, 1979), 1-6; (b) Major General Lachhman Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh* (Dehra Dun: Natraj Publishers, 1981), 5-6 & 80-84.

**MAP – 4**

- (2) *River Madhumati/ Garai*. It flowed parallel to, and approximately 30 kilometres east of the Jessore – Jhenida highway, and west of the Ganga. The river was nearly 50 metres wide.
- (3) *River Bhairab*. Originated around Kushtia, moved northeast of Jessore and ran parallel and east of road Jessore – Daulatpur.

(4) *River Kabadak*. Ran from north to south just east of the international frontier. It was about 75 metres wide.

- c. Military movement across this area had to overcome water obstacles at every ten to fifteen kilometres.

129. **Important Towns**

- a. *Jhenida*. It was in Kushtia Sub-sector. Was an important communication centre in the northern half of this sector and located at the intersection of the main highway connecting Jessore and Hardinge Bridge and Chaudanga to Magura and Goalundo Ghat. The bridge was tactically important as it provided the only land link between the Southwestern and Northwestern sectors.
- b. *Jessore*. In the Jessore Sub-sector, it was the most prestigious town, with an important cantonment, in this sector. It was a communication centre from where a network of roads and railway lines ran in all directions, chiefly toward Hardinge Bridge in the north, Dacca in the east, Khulna in the south and Calcutta in the west. Jessore had an all-weather airfield.
- c. *Khulna*. The next most important town was Khulna, the second biggest industrial town in East Pakistan. It was linked to the port town of Chalna, which provided an exit to the Bay of Bengal and a link with West Pakistan.

130. **Communication Infrastructure**

- a. The most important road in this sector ran north to south connecting Hardinge Bridge, Jhendia, Jessore and Khulna. It ran parallel to and at a distance of 45-70 kilometres from the Indian border.
- b. Kushtia was the hub of railways in the north. It was connected to North-western Sector through Hardinge Bridge and on the other side was linked to Darsana and Jessore – Khulna.
- c. Sub-sector wise significant road/ tracks were:-
- (1) *Kushtia Sub-sector*. Important roads in this sub-sector which ran from west to east leading toward the main ferries on the Ganges were:-
- (a) *Meherpur – Chaudanga – Jhenida – Faridpur*. This was comparatively long route to Ganges. It also involved the likelihood of fighting in the built-up areas of Meherpur and Chaudanga.

- (b) *Jiban Nagar – Kot Chandpur – Kaliganj – Jhenida – Faridpur*. This was the shortest route to Jhenida after joining the main highway at Kaliganj. It was nearer the Chaugacha – Jessore road and as such offered better scope for mutual support between the two routes.

(2) *Jessore Sub-sector*

- (a) *Bangaon – Jhingergacha – Jessore*. It was shortest and most direct route to Jessore. A north-south track cut this road at Jhingergacha and linked it with Bayra in the north and Kesabpur in the south.
- (b) *Chaugacha – Afra – Jessore*. It was connected to Bagdaha on the Indian side by a motor-able track. This track had a bridge over River Kabadak at Chaugacha.
- (c) Bayra⁵⁸ was connected with Garibpur and Muhammadpur on Chaugacha – Jhingergacha track by ferry as Kabadak was not bridged in this area.

- (3) *Kulna Sub-sector*. A road-cum-track linked Calcutta with Khulna via Satkhira but involved crossing ferries over different rivers and nullahs/ rivulets.

131. **Importance of the Sector**

- a. Jessore was considered as a potential threat to the metropolis of Calcutta, capital of the state of West Bengal and headquarters of the Indian Eastern Command. The capture of Jessore by Indians could not only be a shattering blow to the Pakistanis but would offer additional security to Calcutta.
- b. Jessore was a glittering prize the propaganda effect of whose capture was next only to that of Dacca.
- c. This sector had excellent rail and road communication on the Indian side. Ordnance and supply depots were also suitably located to support operations in it.
- d. Hardinge Bridge was an attractive objective as it provided the land link between the north-western and south-western sectors. To destroy

⁵⁸ Southwest of Chaugacha was the Bayra Bulge, which jutted out eastward towards Jessore and was the nearest Indian territory from Jessore.

Pakistani troops, early capture of Hardinge Bridge had an important role. It's capture would not allow Northwestern and Southwestern sectors to unite and thus troops in these sectors could be destroyed piecemeal.

- e. The airfields around Calcutta could provide excellent close support at short notice and Jessore airfield could be utilised by Indians as a step-up after its capture.
- f. Distance wise, this sector offered the second nearest approach to Dacca from the Indian border, being very close to Calcutta and having many east-west roads linking various important places to the communication systems in Bengal.

Opposing Forces

132. **Pakistani Forces.** 9 Division was defending this area. Division headquarters was initially located at Jessore, later on it shifted to Magura. It was commanded by Major General Muhammad Hussain Ansari.⁵⁹ It consisted of following troops:-⁶⁰

- a. **57 Brigade (Brigadier Manzoor Ahmed)**
 - (1) 18 Punjab.
 - (2) 29 Baloch.
 - (3) 50 Punjab.⁶¹
 - (4) 49 Field Regiment Artillery.⁶²
 - (5) Troop 211 Mortar Battery.⁶³
- b. **107 Brigade (Brigadier Muhammad Hayat)⁶⁴**
 - (1) 15 FF.
 - (2) 22 FF.
 - (3) 38 FF.
 - (4) 12 Punjab.⁶⁵
 - (5) 55 Field Regiment Artillery.
 - (6) Troop 211 Mortar Battery.

⁵⁹ Major General Shaukat Riza, *The Pakistan Army 1966-71*(Lahore: Wajidalis Private Limited, 1990), 134.

⁶⁰ Ibid., 135-137.

⁶¹ The battalion reached East Pakistan on 29 November 1971. Ibid., 135. 50 Punjab was sent as reinforcement to 9 Division by the Eastern Command. It had arrived at Dacca between 25-27 November. *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 422.

⁶² Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 135.

⁶³ Ibid.

⁶⁴ Ibid., 136.

⁶⁵ It was part of Eastern Command reserves. It reached 107 Brigade area on 25 November.

- c. **314 (Adhoc) Brigade (Colonel Fazal-i-Hameed)**⁶⁶
 - (1) Five internal security force (ISF) companies deployed at Khulna, Chalna and Sunderbans areas.
 - (2) East Pakistan Civil Armed Forces (EPCAF) Sector having five companies.
 - (3) Mujahid Battalion.
 - d. **Division Reserves**⁶⁷
 - (1) 6 Punjab.
 - (2) 21 Punjab less two companies.
 - (3) 3 Independent Armour Squadron.
 - (4) Section Special Services Group.
 - e. **Khulna Naval Base (Commander Gul Zarin).** Having four gun boats in support of 9 Division.
133. **Indian Forces**⁶⁸
- a. **4 Division**
 - (1) 7 Brigade.
 - (2) 41 Brigade.
 - (3) 62 Brigade.
 - b. **9 Division**
 - (1) 32 Brigade.
 - (2) 42 Brigade.
 - (3) 45 Brigade.
 - (4) 350 Brigade.
 - c. 50 Para Brigade Group.⁶⁹
 - d. Border Security Forces – five battalions.⁷⁰
 - e. One Medium Regiment Artillery (130 mm).
 - f. 45 Cavalry (PT 76).
 - g. Squadron armour (T 55).⁷¹

⁶⁶ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 136.

⁶⁷ Ibid.

⁶⁸ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 353.

⁶⁹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 198.

⁷⁰ Ibid., 198.

⁷¹ General K.V. Krishna Rao, *Prepare or Perish* (New Delhi: Lancer Publishers, 1991), 173.

Opposing Plans/ Map – 4

134. Pakistani Plans

- a. Jessore and Jhenida were theatre fortresses and no penetration was to be permitted beyond that line. Broadly speaking, 9 Division deployment included: 57 Brigade in Kushtia Sub-sector; 107 Brigade was deployed in Jessore Sub-sector; and 314-A Brigade in Khulna Sub-sector. Troops were deployed well ahead of the fortresses in order to destroy the enemy as far forward as possible. When hard pressed, the troops were to fall back into the respective fortresses and stop the enemy there.⁷²
- b. 57 Brigade was covering a frontage of 80 kilometres. The brigade had put up everything it had in the shop window and had deployed its battalions in company groups, mixed with EPCAF and Razakars, covering the important approaches all along the border.⁷³ 29 Baloch was on the right covering axis to Hardinge Bridge, the only vital link to 16 Division across the Ganges. 18 Punjab was deployed on the left to guard the approach to Jhenida, which had been prepared as a fortress for prolonged defence. A company was detached from 18 Punjab to man an outpost at Darsana right on the border and at the inter-brigade boundary. It was covering the shortest approach to Jhenida.⁷⁴
- c. 107 Brigade was deployed with equal emphasis on the Chaugacha and Jhingergacha axes. 6 Punjab was deployed to guard the Afra defile area, 22 FF on the Jhingergacha Axis, 15 FF along the Satkhira Axis, while 21 Punjab was kept as a reserve in the Jessore area. 38 FF was deployed to guard Chaugacha up to Jiban Nagar area. The brigade was deployed forward to cover the border and was intended to fall back for the close defence of Jessore for the final battle.
- d. No orders were given for withdrawal beyond Jessore or Jhendia as the Eastern Command felt that any indication of an intention to withdraw from Jessore might undermine the determination of troops to fight in forward locations.⁷⁵

⁷² Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 172.

⁷³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 117.

⁷⁴ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 392.

⁷⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 135.

- e. Divisional headquarters was located at Jessore.⁷⁶

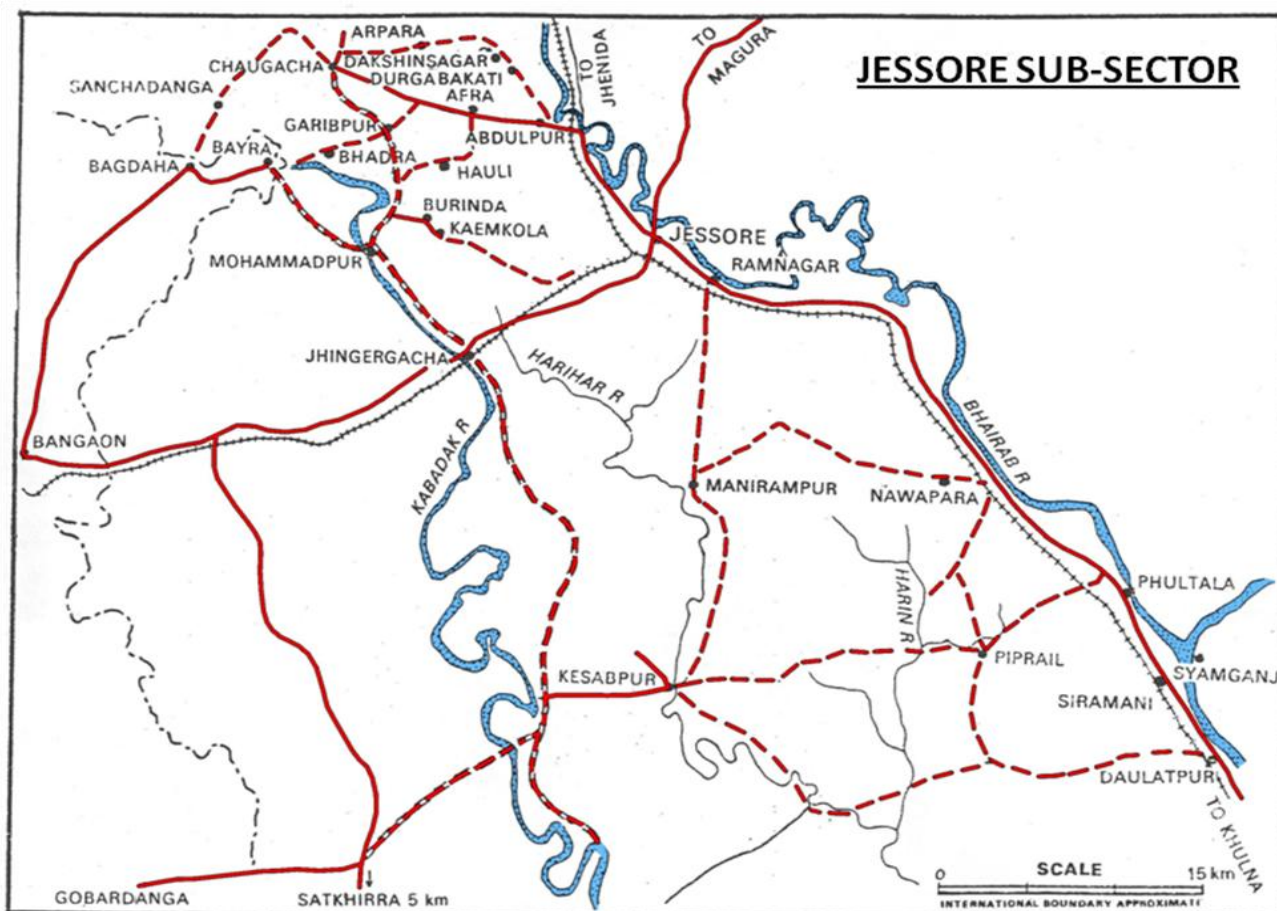
135. Indian Plans

- a. 2 Corps was overall responsible for operations in South-western Sector. It was given the task of capturing Jessore and Jhenida. Subsequently, Khulna, Faridpur, Goalundo Ghat and Hardinge Bridge were also to be secured. 2 Corps kept one brigade of 4 Division as corps reserve and deployed it opposite Meherpur area to show threat to Hardinge Bridge.
- b. 4 Division was ordered to capture Jhenida by D plus 8. Thereafter, it had to secure ferry site over River Madhumati by D plus 11. Subsequently, the division was given a be-prepared task to secure Goalundo Ghat and Faridpur ferries or capture Hardinge Bridge and Kushtia.⁷⁷
- c. 4 Division planned to unfold its operation as under:-⁷⁸
 - (1) 41 Brigade was to advance along Uthali – Kot Chandpur Axis to secure Kot Chandpur.
 - (2) 62 Brigade was tasked along Jiban Nagar – Kaliganj Axis.
 - (3) After the capture of Kot Chandpur, 41 Brigade to advance along Kot Chandpur – Sandhuati Axis and 62 Brigade along the Kaliganj – Jhenida Axis.
- d. 9 (I) Division was ordered to capture Jessore by D plus 7, advancing along the Bangaon - Jhingergacha Axis. 9 (I) Division planned to hit behind the defences at Jhingergacha with one brigade coming from Bayra and another from Gobardanga while the third advanced along the highway from Bangaon. 9 (P) Division forces along the Bangaon Axis were expected to be cut off and destroyed by outflanking moves before it could reorganize to face the Indians at Jessore. After the fall of Jessore, Kulna was to be secured with a brigade group. The division was also asked to be-prepared to capture Jhenida or Magura; and then secure ferries in Goalundo Ghat and Faridpur areas.

⁷⁶ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 420.

⁷⁷ Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 174.

⁷⁸ Ibid.



MAP – 5

Conduct/ Battle Accounts

136. Jessore Sub-sector (107 Brigade)/ Map – 5

- a. Probing attacks against 107 Brigade began as early as 11 November when a company of 1 J&K Regiment occupied a border outpost (BOP) in Chaugacha area. Elements of another Indian battalion crossed the frontier on 12 November and occupied Masalia BOP defended by 38 FF troops. The next day, 107 Brigade ordered a company each from 38 FF and 22 FF to push back the intruders. Their efforts failed.⁷⁹
- b. In the middle of November, there was much skirmishing around the Bayra Bulge. On the morning of 20 November, 9 (I) Division ordered its 42

⁷⁹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 381.

Brigade, to secure Garibpur at night so that the Chaugacha – Afra road could be dominated and cut off, if required.⁸⁰

- c. Gharibpur was held by a company of 38 FF.⁸¹ On 20 November, 107 Brigade received the information that one Indian company with large number of Mukti Bahinis were digging in Garibpur area. The brigade sent troops to clear this straight away. Two companies of 6 Punjab “with one company of 21 Punjab and a squadron”⁸² were ordered to attack from the direction of Chaugacha. The attack was launched at first light.⁸³
- d. Own troops attacked the Indian positions from north and east. They did overrun enemy company of 14 Punjab at Gharibpur but suffered casualties, losing 11 tanks.⁸⁴ As a result of these battle losses 107 Brigade got completely imbalanced. It had used the armour in assault to the point of complete annihilation of the whole squadron.⁸⁵ General Ansari, therefore, decided to withdraw troops to Afra Nullah. The Indians reoccupied Gharibpur on 22 November.⁸⁶ The next day, another company of 38 FF defending Chaugacha was attacked and overrun. Remnants of the company withdrew in haste; some fell back along Afra Nullah, while other went to Jhingergacha.⁸⁷
- e. To strengthen 107 Brigade’s positions in the Afra area, Eastern Command, flew 12 Punjab from Rajshahi to Jessore and reinforced their troops along the Chaugacha Axis.⁸⁸ 9 (P) Division did some major readjustments in defences: 12 Punjab was deployed in the Arpara area, 6 Punjab in the Durgabarkati – Afra area, 22 FF and 15 FF were based in the Jhingergacha and Satkhira area.⁸⁹ “21 Punjab less two companies with elements of 12 FF and 12 Punjab were assigned the responsibility to

⁸⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 136.

⁸¹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 381.

⁸² 21 Punjab Regiment, *War Diary*, 46.

⁸³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 136.

⁸⁴ The same day the PAF went into action. Four F-86s attacked the enemy in Gharibpur area. Indian Gnats intercepted the planes and in the dogfight two Pakistani aircrafts were lost. Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 382.

⁸⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 137.

⁸⁶ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 382.

⁸⁷ Ibid.

⁸⁸ On 25 November, 12 Punjab, a fresh battalion from Pabna (16 Division), was given to 107 Brigade to reinforce the Afra position. Ibid., 384.

⁸⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 137.

defend area Muhammad Pur – Helsa”⁹⁰ approximately 10 kilometres from Jessore on a subsidiary axis.^{91,92}

- f. By the end of November, 9 (I) Division had one brigade at Bangaon while the rest of the division was in the Bayra area. The Indians had shifted 42 Brigade to Bayra from Gobardanga. They now had three options to approach and capture Jessore:-
 - (1) *Northern Approach.* Along the Chaugacha – Jessore road. They could additionally use the track from Chaugacha to Arpara-Durgabarkati to bypass Afra.
 - (2) *Central Approach.* Along Burinda – Kaemkola track to Jessore.
 - (3) *Southern Approach.* Use the Bayra – Jhingergacha track and also advance to Jessore along the main highway.⁹³
- g. Indian 42 Brigade pressed on toward Arpara but was held up against Durgabarkati by 4 December. Similarly, 350 Brigade was held up against Burinda, where they encountered stiff resistance; nevertheless, they captured it on 5 December after suffering nearly 62 casualties.⁹⁴
- h. General officer commanding 9 (I) Division, realizing that a breakthrough along the Central Approach would be costly in lives and time-consuming, decided to swing the full weight of his attack towards the Northern Approach. He moved 32 Brigade to Bayra, leaving one battalion to guard the Bangaon - Jhingergacha Axis. The plan was to punch a hole around Durgabarkati with 42 Brigade so that a fresh brigade with the support of maximum available armour could be launched through the gap to capture Jessore. 42 Brigade was ordered to clear a passage at Durgabarkati by a day-attack so that air support to soften defensive positions could be used to the maximum. 32 Brigade was poised behind 42 Brigade to go through the gap at Durgabarkati to capture Jessore.⁹⁵ 42 Brigade (2 Sikh Light Infantry) attacked Durgabarkati on morning of 6 December and cleared it for 32 Brigade to pass through by 1200 hours.

⁹⁰ 21 Punjab Regiment, *War Diary*, 46.

⁹¹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 384.

⁹² Kamal Matinuddin has portrayed the battle of Helsa as some main encounter, which is incorrect. As enemy's main effort remained confined to the central and northern approaches.

⁹³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 138.

⁹⁴ Ibid.

⁹⁵ Ibid., 139.

- i. On 7 December, 32 Brigade advanced towards Jessore. 6 Punjab before withdrawing mined Afra area, which impeded Indian advance. The Indians used the locals for mine clearance of axis. During withdrawal, 107 Brigade lost contact with 6 Punjab. After an exaggerated estimate of the enemy's armour moving towards Jessore was received by the brigade commander, he made a quick assessment and concluded that his troops would not be able to reach Jessore before the enemy did so.⁹⁶ And even if he managed to do so he would not be able to organize a proper defence around Jessore in the face of an impending attack.⁹⁷ He, therefore, decided to fall back to Khulna in the south.⁹⁸
- j. Jessore fell without resistance the same day after troops there vacated it in a great hurry.⁹⁹ The bulk of 107 Brigade, when the break-through occurred, was south of Jessore extending as far as 100 kilometres from the town. It could not have reached Jessore in time.^{100, 101}
- k. At this stage 9 (I) Division decided to open the main axis for the move forward of guns for the battle of Jessore. While 14 Punjab of 32 Brigade, which it had left at Bayra was pushed along the main road to Jessore. 350 Brigade, earlier held up at Burinda (Central Approach), was also ordered to press on to Jessore along Jhingergacha Axis.¹⁰²
- l. No sooner did 107 Brigade, on 6 December, receive the news of the break-through at Durgabarkati, it ordered the withdrawal of its brigade to Khulna. 22 FF which was in Jhingergacha area was ordered to fall back to Ramnagar on Jessore – Khulna road in the afternoon of 6 December. The rest of the Brigade withdrew before midnight 6/7 December. Own troops

⁹⁶ According to the Indian accounts, "the routes from Jessore to Jhenida and Magura were open to 107 Brigade throughout 6 and 7 December as 4 Division had captured Jhenida and Magura on 7 and 8 December respectively." Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 141.

⁹⁷ 15 FF, which was not facing any threat, could have been withdrawn to Jessore. But the policy of no withdrawal from forward positions made the defences rigid and left Jessore an easy prey.

⁹⁸ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 387.

⁹⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 141.

¹⁰⁰ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 389.

¹⁰¹ General Niazi visited 107 Brigade on 29 November. Commander 107 Brigade recommended to him that some troops should be pulled back to Jessore as the threat to the city was developing and the town itself had no fighting elements in it. Niazi is reported to have said, "No! No Shera! you do not understand. If you vacate any more territory the Mukti will declare independence. Ibid., 385-7.

¹⁰² Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 140.

made no effort to destroy the vast dumps of ammunition and other stores in Jessore.¹⁰³

- m. According to General Niazi, Brigadier Hayat sought his permission to withdraw from Line Afra – Jhingergacha as his communications with his Divisional Commander were disrupted. He suggested the withdrawal towards Khulna, luring bulk of Indian 2 Corps.¹⁰⁴
- n. 107 Brigade's move toward Khulna irretrievably split the division into two with a yawning gap in the centre. The route to Dacca lay open with only a weak adhoc task force comprising elements of 38 FF and 50 Punjab with one artillery battery in support. At this stage a great opportunity offered itself to Indian 2 Corps along the front of both its divisions for a drive towards Goalundo Ghat enroute to Dacca, but that was not seized.¹⁰⁵
- o. 107 Brigade's withdrawal towards Khulna was initially uncoordinated. Each battalion rushed back without knowing whether any position enroute to Khulna was to be occupied. Brigadier Hayat, however, managed to stop the rearward movement and re-established a delaying position at Nawapara, about 12 kilometres southeast of Jessore on the road to Khulna.¹⁰⁶
- p. 9 (I) Division pushed towards Khulna with 32 Brigade and one squadron of 45 Cavalry while concentrating the rest of the division around Jessore. 32 Brigade resumed its advance at 1400 hours on 7 December and cleared Ramnagar without any opposition by 1300 hours next day. From Ramnagar to Khulna, the road ran on the west bank of Bhairab between the river and the railway line.¹⁰⁷
- q. Own troops made good use of the difficult terrain restricting the speed of the advancing Indians. The area was marshy. However, the Indians cleared Phultala on 12 December.¹⁰⁸
- r. 107 Brigade organized a proper brigade defensive position astride Daulatpur about eight kilometres outside Khulna. It put two battalions up and a third battalion in depth. 15 FF was deployed on the left of the road

¹⁰³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 141.

¹⁰⁴ Niazi, *Betrayal of East Pakistan*, 146-47.

¹⁰⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 141.

¹⁰⁶ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 389.

¹⁰⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 142.

¹⁰⁸ *Ibid.*, 143.

and 6 Punjab was on right, 22 FF was in depth. 12 Punjab was guarding the Kesabpur approach. A company each of R&S battalion was given to forward battalions. The defences kept the two Indian brigades at bay from 12-16 December outside Khulna.¹⁰⁹

- s. On 12 December, 9 (I) Division moved for the impending battle. Salients of the plan were:-¹¹⁰
 - (1) 32 Brigade to hold a firm base astride the main road.
 - (2) 350 Brigade to attack from the north and overrun the main defensive position in conjunction with 42 Brigade.
 - (3) 42 Brigade to secure Syamganj ferry and cross the River Bhairab with brigade less a battalion and half a squadron of tanks. The brigade to advance south along the eastern bank of the river, re-cross it between Daulatpur and Khulna and capture Khulna in conjunction with 350 Brigade.
- t. 42 Brigade secured the Syamganj ferry site by the afternoon of 13 December. However, own troops continued to dominate the site with fire. Likewise, 32 Brigade also tried to clear defensive positions at Siramani held by 15 FF on the night 12/ 13 December but made little progress inspite of heavy losses.¹¹¹
- u. The Indians then decided to cross the Bhairab River from another place. Though 42 Brigade did manage to cross the river but got bogged down and could not reach the point from where it had to re-cross the Bhairab south of Daulatpur according to the visualised plan. On 14 December, 350 Brigade without waiting for 42 Brigade launched the attack. By first light the brigade suffered heavy casualties (1 JAK and 4 Sikh both had more than 70 killed each) in capturing Siramani. At this stage, 13 Dogra was asked to capture the remaining portion of Siramani; they did so also after considerable losses.¹¹² 15 FF withdrew to Khulna.
- v. On 16 December, when finally a general call for surrender was announced, 9 (I) Division was still about six kilometres from Khulna.

¹⁰⁹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 390.

¹¹⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 144.

¹¹¹ Ibid.

¹¹² Ibid., 144-145.

Brigadier Hayat surrendered with nearly 3700 Pakistanis to Major General Dalbir Singh on 17 December at the circuit house in Khulna.¹¹³

137. Kushtia Sub-sector (57 Brigade)/ Map – 6

- a. During the first week of November, Indian 1 Nagaland Battalion¹¹⁴ infiltrated and occupied Dharmada Enclave, unnoticed. The enclave probably served as a base to coordinate and support operations of the Muktis into the area. Once known, 57 Brigade decided to eject the enemy from there. Operation against the ingress was launched on 9 November with a company of 21 Punjab and 29 Baloch each. 21 Punjab company had to attack the location, whereas, company of 29 Baloch established a blocking position. The attack succeeded and the Indians were flushed out of occupied area.¹¹⁵
- b. 57 Brigade had two infantry battalions as against the standard three. It was covering a frontage of 80 kilometres. 29 Baloch was on the right covering axis to Hardinge Bridge, the only vital link to 16 Division across the Ganges. 18 Punjab was deployed on the left to guard the approach to Jhenida, which had been prepared as a fortress for a prolonged defence. A company was detached from 18 Punjab to man an outpost at Darsana right on the border and at the inter-brigade boundary. It was covering the shortest approach to Jhenida. 38 FF was immediately on its left.¹¹⁶
- c. 57 Brigade was later reinforced with a squadron of tanks from 29 Cavalry for the defence of the Hardinge Bridge and with 50 Punjab Regiment, which reached the formation on 29 November and was hurriedly sent southwards to prevent a breakthrough to Jhenida.¹¹⁷
- d. 4 Division had planned to advance on the Uthali – Suadih – Kot Chandpur Axis with 41 Brigade and on the Jiban Nagar – Kaliganj Axis with 62 Brigade. After the capture of Kot Chandpur, 41 Brigade was to approach Jhenida through a cross country advance along the Talsar track while 62 Brigade would advance along the Kaliganj Axis.¹¹⁸

¹¹³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 145.

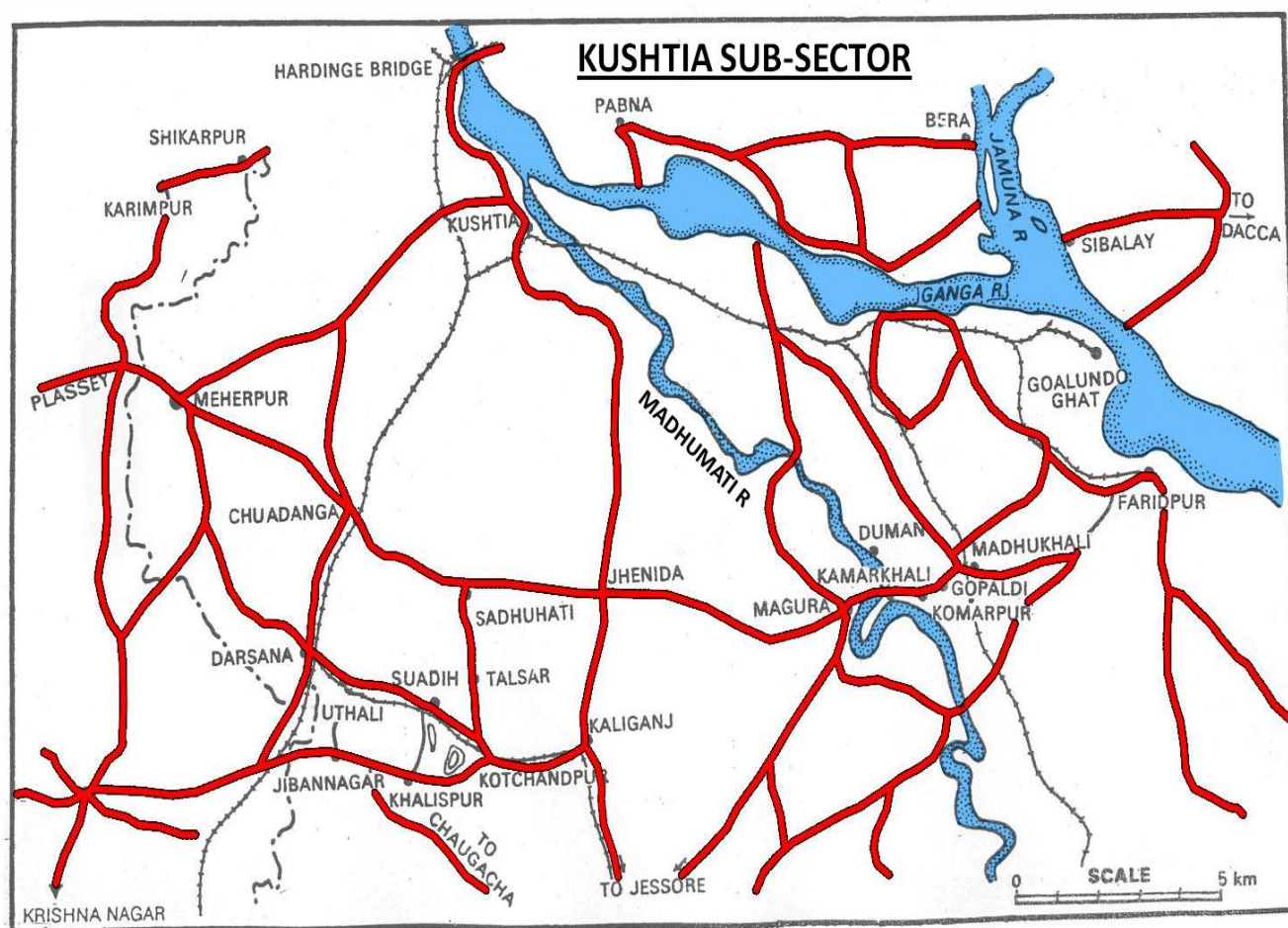
¹¹⁴ 1 Nagaland Battalion was of 7 Brigade, which was placed as reserve of 2 Corps. Ibid., 126.

¹¹⁵ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 394.

¹¹⁶ Ibid., 392.

¹¹⁷ Ibid., 393.

¹¹⁸ Singh, *Victory of Bangladesh*, 118.



MAP – 6

- e. 4 Division had secured the general area of Jiban Nagar and Uthali by the beginning of December.¹¹⁹ The Indians felt that Darsana could interfere with their axis of maintenance and rear area and therefore were keen to remove this threat. The division therefore ordered 41 Brigade to capture Darsana by 4 December.¹²⁰
- f. Darsana and Uthalai both were defended by a company each of 18 Punjab.¹²¹ 41 Brigade attacked Darsana frontally with two battalions.¹²² A road block to isolate it from Chuadanga was also planned under divisional arrangements. 22 Rajputs with a squadron less a troop advance from Uthali and were held up by Pakistani troops astride the railway embankment about 1000 metres southeast of Darsana. Indians suffered

¹¹⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 118.

¹²⁰ Ibid.

¹²¹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 395.

¹²² Indians attacked Darsana on 28 November. Darsana fell after 6 days fighting on 4 December. Ibid., 395.

heavy casualties. 22 Rajputs had to launch another attack and capture railway embankment. 18 Punjab troops stopped the further advance of Indian troops. 41 Brigade had to launch the second battalion, 5/1 GR, which cleared Darsana by 1100 hours on 4 December.¹²³

- g. From Darsana 18 Punjab with a troop of tanks from 29 Cavalry¹²⁴ fell back to Chuadanga¹²⁵ and defended it against the expected Indian advance.
- h. Indian 4 Division, however, had planned differently. On 4 December, after leaving 22 Rajputs in the Darsana area, 41 Brigade was concentrated in Uthali by last light for operations towards Kot Chandpur and Jhenida.¹²⁶
- i. While 41 Brigade was busy in the Darsana area, 62 Brigade probed forward towards Kalispur. Finding it strongly held and the bridge on the River Bhairab blown up, 4 Division decided to switch 62 Brigade to the Suadih Axis to advance along a subsidiary route which was not likely to be held in strength. This route was a dirt track.¹²⁷
- j. 62 Brigade's attack along the inter-brigade boundary between 57 and 107 Brigades, surprised 38 FF and it could not withhold the position. The Indian attack split the battalion, some elements fell back to their brigade area while the bulk of the unit withdrew towards Jhenida into 57 Brigade area reaching there on 30 November.¹²⁸
- k. 62 Brigade left one battalion in the Khalispur area and advanced toward Kot Chandpur with 9 Dogra from 41 Brigade, which was already in the Uthali area.¹²⁹ The Brigade attacked Kot Chandpur with two battalions, 5 MLI and 9 Dogra, capturing it by 1400 hours after minor opposition.¹³⁰
- l. Sensing the situation, on 4/5 December, Brigadier Manzoor requested permission to move 18 Punjab to Jhenida which was to be defended as a fortress. His request was not initially granted and when it was finally given on the night between 5 and 6 December, it was too late. Kot Chandpur

¹²³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 119.

¹²⁴ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 395.

¹²⁵ Chuadanga was hometown of Governor Malik. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 120.

¹²⁶ Ibid., 120.

¹²⁷ Ibid.

¹²⁸ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 396.

¹²⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 121.

¹³⁰ Ibid.

south of Jhenida had fallen and the enemy had by then blocked the routes of withdrawal to Jhenida.¹³¹

- m. While moving towards Jhenida 18 Punjab was fired at by the enemy from Uttar Narayanpur, a small village, a few kilometres west of Jhenida, on the road Chaudanga – Jhenida. The commanding officer of 18 Punjab, thinking the adversary to be Mukti, tried to clear the way by attacking first with one company and then by two, supported by the couple of tanks he had with him. The attack failed as regular Indian troops were opposing him. The battalion rather than going to Jhenida retreated towards Chuadanga.¹³²
- n. The stage was thus set by 5 December for the crucial battle to capture Jhenida. 41 Brigade was concentrated west of Suadih; whereas, 62 Brigade was at Kot Chandpur. The Indians planned to attack as under:-¹³³
 - (1) 41 Brigade was to capture Jhenida by advancing along the difficult track via Talsar. The Indians felt that we would vacate Chuadanga and concentrate the forces for the defence of Jhenida as soon as a threat toward Jhenida looked imminent.
 - (2) 62 Brigade was to advance towards Kaliganj along the main road and capture it as soon as possible.
 - (3) To deny Pakistani troops any opportunity to withdraw to Jhenida, the division tasked 5 Guard alongwith a squadron of tanks to block all approaches between Chuadanga and Jhenida. This was done on 5 December.¹³⁴
- o. On 6 December, 41 Brigade moved from Kot Chandpur on foot along Talsar track. They contacted “the remnants of 38 FF which had fallen back to Jhendia on 30 November”¹³⁵ by 0900 hours on 7 December. The same day, 41 Brigade launched a quick attack and captured Jhenida¹³⁶ about 1300 hours without much resistance.¹³⁷

¹³¹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 396.

¹³² Ibid.

¹³³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 121-122.

¹³⁴ Ibid., 122.

¹³⁵ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 396.

¹³⁶ Own troops had abandoned Jhenida in a great hurry without demolishing the huge dump of ammunition or bridges over River Banaganga (not mentioned in maps). Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 123.

¹³⁷ Ibid.

- p. 6 and 7 December were crucial days for Pakistani troops in the South-western Sector. 107 Brigade had decided to give up the theatre fortress of Jessore without fight and had withdrawn toward Khulna. Whereas, 57 Brigade had been cut off from the theatre fortress of Jhenida by the road block in the Sadhuhati area.¹³⁸
- q. By 7 December, 9 (P) Division was at Magura. Unable to manage an organised withdrawal of her forward brigades, the division instructed Colonel Afridi, Division Colonel Staff, to collect elements of 38 FF and 50 Punjab, which had been separated from their brigades, and organize a task force to check the advance toward Kaliganj and Jhenida. A battery of guns already deployed along the Kaliganj Axis was grouped with his force.¹³⁹
- r. The same day, 9 (P) Division moved its headquarters to Faridpur across Madhumati River and ordered Colonel Afridi to deny the ferry sites across the Madhumati after delaying the advance but without risking his force.¹⁴⁰
- s. While these operations around Jhenida were progressing, 62 Brigade resumed its advance towards Kaliganj at last light on 5 December. The Indians captured Kaliganj by morning of 7 December. 62 Brigade was then ordered to link up with 41 Brigade at Jhenida and advance to Magura to capture it at the earliest.¹⁴¹
- t. At this stage, 41 Brigade was already in Jhenida but had not linked up with its essential administrative vehicles. An air drop was carried out at Jhenida at 1500 hours on 7 December to replenish essential supplies.¹⁴²
- u. 62 Brigade captured Magura at 1600 hours on 8 December after some firing from stray parties.¹⁴³ The main bridge over River Madhumati at Magura was captured intact.¹⁴⁴
- v. Now a word about own troops that got stranded in the north. 57 Brigade asked 18 Punjab to try and reach Kushtia which was connected to Chuadanga by train. But the Mukti Bahinis had blown the railway bridge

¹³⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 123.

¹³⁹ Ibid., 124.

¹⁴⁰ Ibid.

¹⁴¹ Ibid.

¹⁴² Ibid.

¹⁴³ 2 Corps launched elements of 50 Parachute Brigade to help 4 Division in the capture of Magura from the Jessore side. But Magura fell without opposition. Ibid., 125.

¹⁴⁴ Ibid.

and movement by train was no longer possible. The rebels had also destroyed the bridges on the road from Meherpur to Kushtia thus cutting off 29 Baloch from the rest of the brigade. 57 Brigade, however, managed to concentrate 18 Punjab and 29 Baloch around Kushtia by 8 December.¹⁴⁵

- w. At this stage the original design to capture Chalna and Hardinge Bridge seemed to be guiding the Indians and no serious effort was made to reach the ferries on the Ganga enroute to Dacca.¹⁴⁶
- x. Around 8 December, 7 Brigade was released to 4 Division, which had been kept as a corps reserve, so that it could quickly clear Kushtia and Hardinge Bridge. 7 Brigade was tasked to advance on the Jhenida – Kushtia Axis to capture Kushtia and Hardinge Bridge.¹⁴⁷
- y. The general assessment of Indians on 8 December was that the bulk of the Pakistanis had withdrawn in the direction of Faridpur to delay their progress toward ferries along Ganga with the ultimate intention of falling back on Dacca.¹⁴⁸
- z. 57 Brigade, on the contrary, had a surprise for the Indians. It, having lost all hopes of reaching Jhenida,¹⁴⁹ began to re-organise itself at Kushtia. 29 Baloch was to guard the approach from Jhenida and 18 Punjab was to prevent the enemy from reaching Hardinge Bridge.¹⁵⁰
- aa. On 9 December at 1400 hours, 22 Rajput reached the outskirts of Kushtia where they were all of a sudden fired upon by different weapons. The leading troops and tanks had walked into an ambush¹⁵¹ laid by squadron of 29 Cavalry. The Indian tank crops historians state that the first shot from a Chafee (29 Cavalry) split open the fifth tank down the line. Only one out of six tanks escaped the ambush.¹⁵²
- bb. As a reaction, the Indians tasked the entire 4 Division to capture Kushtia and clear the area up to Hardinge Bridge. Indians decision to divert the

¹⁴⁵ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 396.

¹⁴⁶ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 125.

¹⁴⁷ Ibid., 126.

¹⁴⁸ Ibid.

¹⁴⁹ 57 Brigade moved to Kushtia on the night of 7/8 December with a view to rejoining 9 Division by using Kushtia – Faridpur rail link. But the rail bridge on the line had been destroyed by the Mukti Bahinis. Ibid., 126-27.

¹⁵⁰ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 397.

¹⁵¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 128.

¹⁵² Major Agha Humayun Amin, "Tank Ambush at Kushtia", *Defense Journal*, August 2010.

main effort towards Kushtia shifted the centre of gravity of operations of 2 Corps away from Dacca.¹⁵³

- cc. 4 Division got concentrated south of Kushtia on the night of 9/10 December. One battalion was left behind to maintain a show of force against Colonel Afridi task force across River Madhumati. After careful preparations, 4 Division undertook to clear Kushtia with 41 and 7 Brigades at 1200 hours on 11 December. They met no resistance as the last parties of the 57 Brigade had pulled out earlier. Kushtia was cleared by 1700 hours. 41 Brigade undertook the advance toward Hardinge Bridge¹⁵⁴ on 12 December and secured the south bank by late afternoon the same day.¹⁵⁵
- dd. With no replacements, no reinforcements, no rest and a feeling of complete isolation, 57 Brigade had lost its will to continue the struggle. It had decided to make a clean break and moved across the Ganges in the hope of getting some respite. 57 Brigade was not given any task by 16 Division and it remained out of the war thereafter.¹⁵⁶
- ee. As soon as 41 Brigade had secured the area around Hardinge Bridge on 12 December, 4 Division less 41 Brigade was ordered to move back to the Magura area.¹⁵⁷ On 13 December, 62 Brigade and most of the artillery had concentrated east of Magura. 7 Brigade also arrived by midday on 14 December.¹⁵⁸
- ff. 4 Division attempted river crossing on the night of 14/15 December. By 15 December, 1100 hours, both of the Indian brigades crossed over the river.¹⁵⁹ On 16 December, most of 4 Division was around Madhukhali, still 60 kilometres west of Faridpur, where remnants of 9 (P) Division had

¹⁵³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 129.

¹⁵⁴ The defences around Hardinge Bridge were formidable and built around a system of canals, anti-tanks ditches and railway line embankments. Concrete bunkers had been constructed to cover various approaches. Hardinge Bridge was blown on 11 December while a large number of vehicles and a variety of arms, equipment and ammunition were left behind by fleeing groups on the southern bank. Ibid., 129.

¹⁵⁵ Ibid.

¹⁵⁶ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 397.

¹⁵⁷ Elements of 38 FF and 50 Punjab organized as an adhoc brigade was holding that position. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 130.

¹⁵⁸ Ibid.

¹⁵⁹ Ibid., 131.

established themselves. About midday on 16 December, Pakistani troops fighting in this sub-sector surrendered.¹⁶⁰

138. Khulna Sub-sector (314-A Brigade)

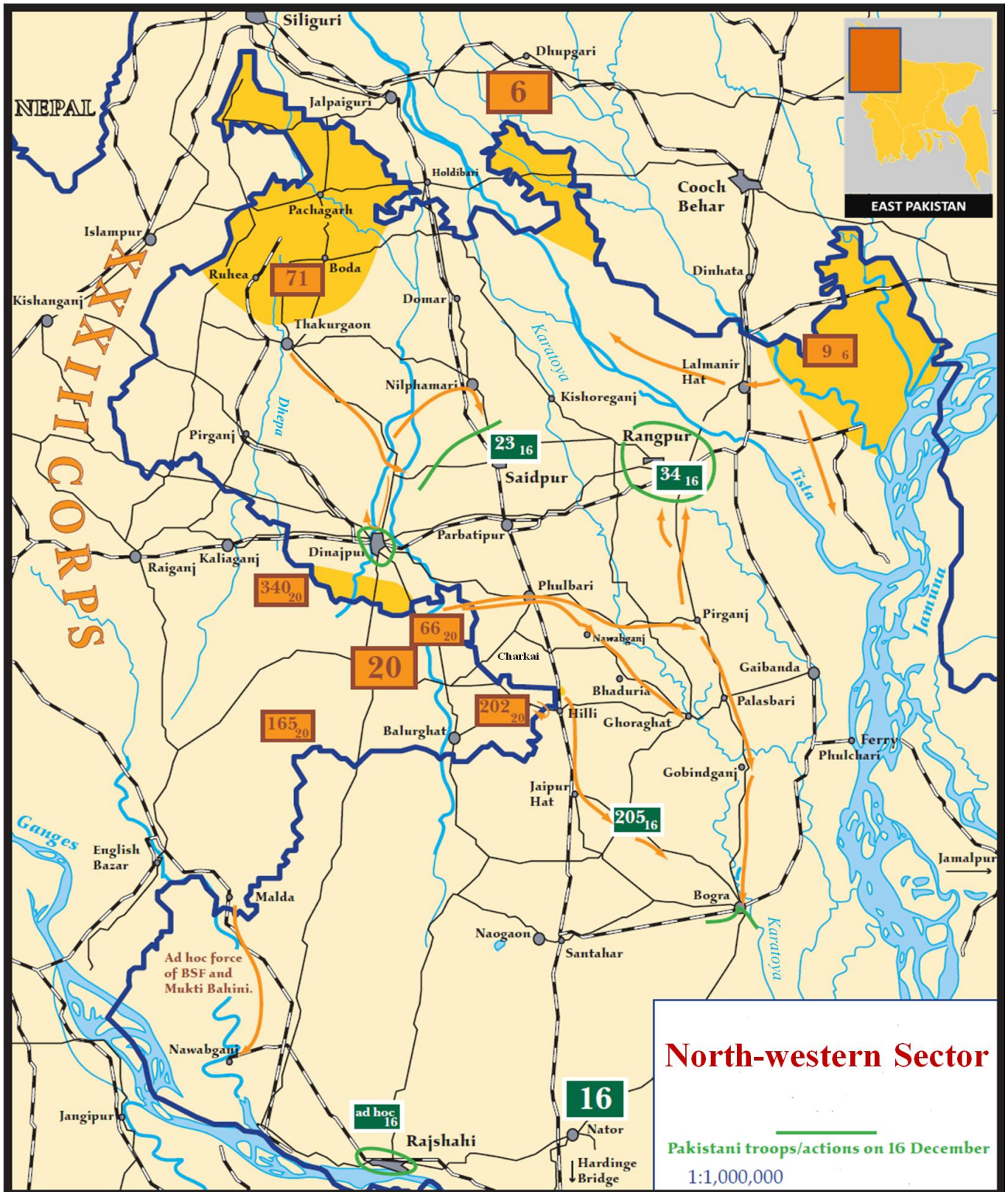
- a. At Barisal, which was under the control of Lieutenant Colonel MS Bhatti with only civil armed forces, the position got untenable after 3 December when Mukti Bahini activities increased suddenly. At that moment, 314-A Brigade was told to move to Barisal. The brigade left Khulna for Barisal by a steamer but enroute changed its mind and came on to Dacca.¹⁶¹ Thereupon, Lieutenant Colonel Bhatti also decided, on 8 December, to leave Barisal. He too managed to reach Dacca after suffering considerable casualties by the river route, moving in launches.¹⁶²
- b. Similarly, immediately after the fall of Jessore, the naval commander, in charge of the Chalna Port, also boarded a civilian ship and got out of East Pakistan.¹⁶³

¹⁶⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 132.

¹⁶¹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 436.

¹⁶² Ibid.

¹⁶³ Ibid.



MAP - 7

NORTH-WESTERN SECTOR

The Area of Operation¹⁶⁴

139. General

- a. The North-western Sector was surrounded by the Siliguri Corridor in the north; the Brahmaputra (Jamuna) in the east; the Ganga (Padma) in the south; and the international border with India in the west. In size, it was roughly one-third of the whole of East Pakistan (Map - 7).
- b. It had swept-back wings, with a narrow torso in the centre keeping the wings together. The tips of the wings were at Thakurgaon in the north and Nator in the south.
- c. This sector was isolated from the rest of East Pakistan except through the Hardinge Bridge over Ganga which connected Jessore with Ishurdi on the Pabna – Rajshahi road. There were ferries across Brahmaputra River from the direction of Dacca.
- d. Rainfall in this area was very heavy and the countryside, especially in the Rajshahi – Naogaon and Pabna areas, had suffered heavy floods during September and October 1971. The water table was very high and while the upper crust of the ground after the winter harvest appeared firm, it could not stand up to the movement of medium tanks.
- e. The Area of Operation in this sector could further be divided into three sub-sectors: Rangpur Sub-sector; Bogra Sub-sector; and Nator Sub-sector.

140. Rivers

- a. The rivers ran from north to south dividing this sector into number of smaller compartments. Any advance from the west was against the grain of the country and necessitated constructing a large number of bridges over rivers and nullahs to carry heavier military equipment.
- b. The area had following important rivers:-
 - (1) *River Brahmaputra/ Jamuna*. It was a major river skirting North-western Sector from east. At places it's width was more than 4 kilometres.
 - (2) *River Ganga*. Also called Padma, cupped the sector from south.

¹⁶⁴ Most of details about the Area of Operation have been taken from following books: (a) Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 7, 167-170 & 213-231, Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 21-23 & 407-411.

- (3) *River Dhepa*. It originated west of Pachagarh Salient inside East Pakistan, flowed down east of road Pachagarh – Dinajpur south of Boda and again curled and skirted Dinajpur from the west.
- (4) *River Tista*. Entered East Pakistan east of Haldibari, moved diagonally southeast and joined River Brahmaputra north of Gaibanda.
- (5) *River Karatoya*. It was an offshoot of River Tista that flowed east, parallel to Haldibari – Hilli – Nator railway line. It moved west of Pirganj and Palasbari. North of Gobindganj, it bifurcated into two: one rejoined Tista north of Gaibanda; while the other, flowed south coiling around road Rajpur – Palasbari – Bogra.

141. Important Towns

- a. Northern portion of this sector had Dinajpur, Saidpur¹⁶⁵ and Rangpur as important towns and communication centres. Rangpur was also an important cantonment. Bogra was a vital nodal point where all roads met in this sector.
- b. Pabna and Rajshahi were old towns in the southern portion of this sector. Rajshahi was a big town with a university and a police training school. It had a small airstrip. Pabna had a big railway colony, an airfield and a small atomic research centre near the Hardinge Bridge. The most important military objective in the area was Bogra. It was an important communication centre as it controlled the network from the east and south.

142. Communication Infrastructure

- a. North-western Sector had two major roads running from north to south: road Titaliah (Pachagarh Salient) – Thakurgaon – Dinajpur; and road Rangpur – Pirganj – Bogra – Behra. The former was connected to Samija (India) in the south, offering a tactical advantage to the Indians in their operations along the waistline to bypass Hilli. While the later was connected, across the border, with Cooch Behar.

¹⁶⁵ Saidpur was named Bihar Sharif by us after the crackdown in order to appease the Bihari population in the area. Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 6.

- b. There were number of laterals, roads and tracks, which connected the above mentioned two major communication trunk roads. Important ones from north to south were:-
- (1) *Dinajpur – Saidpur – Rangpur*. It was a tarmac one-way road capable of bearing heavy traffic.
 - (2) *Dinajpur – Phulbari*. It was a concrete road.
 - (3) *Charkai – Nawabganj – Pirganj – Gaibanda*. Charkai to Nawabganj was a track; rest was a concrete road.
 - (4) *Charkai – Bhaduria – Palasbari/ Goraghat – Gaibanda*. Till Palasbari/ Goraghat it was a track.
 - (5) *Hilli – Palasbari/ Goraghat*. Was a dirt track.
 - (6) *Bogra – Singra – Nator*. A brick-paved road was under construction.
 - (7) *Nawabganj – Rajshahi – Bera*. It was a tarmac road.
- c. The main broad-gauge railway line ran north to south from Hardinge Bridge via Ishurdi, Nator, Hilli, Parbatipur, Saidpur to Haldibari. The meter-gauge network connected Dinajpur, Rangpur and Lal Munir Hat.
- d. There were no bridges on the River Brahmaputra connecting it with the Dacca bowl.
- e. Thakurgaon had a small airfield for light aircrafts.

143. **Military Significance**

- a. The first and most significant was the Siliguri Corridor, a narrow belt in the plains flanked by the mountain ranges of Sikkim and Nepal in the north. The north-western tip of East Pakistan near Titaliah jutted out like a knife and provided a base for sabotage of vital communications in the corridor.
- b. The Indians also feared that if we chose to undertake operations in collusion with the Chinese, this sector could act as an anvil for a hammer blow from the Chinese based on the nearby Chumbi Valley to the north. The widening of the corridor would provide India added security; thus, India had a compulsive attraction to strengthen the security of this critical and sensitive area.
- c. Another significant aspect of this sector was its narrow waistline linking Hilli and Gaibanda. Any operation in this waistline threatened the

north – south road linking Rangpur with Bogra, with serious consequence to the defending forces in the northern half.

- d. This sector provided the longest approach to Dacca and involved crossing of several rivers, including the mighty Brahmaputra.
- e. The sector was isolated from the rest of East Pakistan by the Brahmaputra and Ganga rivers except for Hardinge Bridge. The Ganga and Brahmaputra are navigable throughout their courses along the boundaries of this sector and had many ferries which transported men, cattle and vehicles. Ferries across the Brahmaputra at Phulchari, Sirajganj and Bera permitted movement to the Central Sector in the areas opposite Jamalpur, Tangail and Dacca respectively.
- f. Another area of tactical value lay further south in the Malda area. The Farakka Barrage in India was nearly complete and could be threatened by Pakistani raiders with a serious impact on the Indian national scene.
- g. Two key objectives in this sector were Rangpur and Bogra. Rangpur was a major cantonment and communication centre in the northern portion while Bogra was a very important tactical objective as it controlled communications towards Dacca.
- h. Another peculiar aspect of this sector was the large Bihari population. More than 70% of the total Biharis in East Pakistan were living in this area. They were mainly concentrated in the areas of Dinajpur, Saidpur, Naogaon, Nator and Ishurdi. The Biharis spoke Urdu and were generally in favour of Pakistan.¹⁶⁶
- i. Most of the villages, five kilometres along the border, had no civil population.

¹⁶⁶ There were also rumours to divide East Pakistan into two provinces of Bihar Sharif and Bengal. The Bengalis feared carving out a Bihar Sharif state based on NW Sector, thus creating a state with pro-Pakistan and Urdu bias, which could perhaps counter balance the anti-Pakistan feelings of the Bengalis. Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 6.

Opposing Forces

144. **Pakistani Forces.** 16 Division was defending this area. Division headquarters was initially located at Bogra, later on it shifted to Nator. It was commanded by Major General Nazar Hussain.¹⁶⁷ It consisted of following troops:-¹⁶⁸

- a. **23 Brigade (Brigadier Akhtar Ansari/ Brigadier Muhammad Shaffi)**
 - (1) 8 Punjab.
 - (2) 25 Punjab.
 - (3) 48 Punjab.
 - (4) 26 FF.
 - (5) Squadron ex 29 Cavalry.¹⁶⁹
 - (6) Company ex 34 Punjab (R&S).¹⁷⁰
 - (7) 48 Field Regiment Artillery.¹⁷¹
- b. **205 Brigade (Brigadier Tajammul Hussain Malik)**
 - (1) 8 Baloch.
 - (2) 4 FF.
 - (3) 13 FF.
 - (4) Two squadrons ex 29 Cavalry.
- c. **34 Brigade (Brigadier Mir Abdul Naeem)**
 - (1) 32 Punjab.
 - (2) 32 Baloch.
 - (3) 12 Punjab (went under command 9 Division with effect from 21 November 1971).
 - (4) Squadron ex 29 Cavalry.
- d. **Five wings of EPCAF.**¹⁷²

¹⁶⁷ Riza, *The Pakistan Army* 143.

¹⁶⁸ Ibid., 143-144.

¹⁶⁹ 29 Cavalry had M-124 Chaffe tanks.

¹⁷⁰ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 373.

¹⁷¹ Ibid.

¹⁷² *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 199.

145. **Indian Forces**¹⁷³a. **20 Mountain Division**¹⁷⁴

- (1) 66 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) 165 Mountain Brigade.
- (3) 202 Mountain Brigade.
- (4) 340 (Independent) Mountain Brigade.
- (5) 71 Brigade (ex 8 Mountain Division).¹⁷⁵
- (6) 3 Armoured Brigade
 - (a) 63 Cavalry.
 - (b) 69 Cavalry.
- (7) 471 Engineer Brigade with three engineer regiments.
- (8) Five BSF Battalions.

b. **6 Mountain Division**

- (1) 9 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) Four BSF Battalions.

Opposing Plans146. **Pakistani Plans**

- a. Major General Nazar Hussain Shah had appreciated that the Indians would concentrate their major effort against the waistline and the Rangpur area. Gist of 16 Division's assessment of enemy operation is as under:-¹⁷⁶
 - (1) Two brigades along Domar – Saidpur Axis to Rangpur. This axis had no water obstacles and as such could be an attractive approach for the capture of Rangpur.
 - (2) At least one brigade to advance along the Pachagarh – Thakurgaon and Dinajpur Axis. Dinajpur was also expected to be attacked from the southwest in conjunction with this advance. The advance along this axis would give added security to the Siliguri Corridor.

¹⁷³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 198-199.

¹⁷⁴ Had two loose independent brigade groups of which 71 Mountain Brigade Group was moved from Nagaland and 340 Mountain Brigade Group from Southern Command. In addition, it had a brigade ex 6 Mountain Division, which was concentrated in the Siliguri Corridor for limited tasks from which it could be extricated within 24-48 hours for tasks against the Chinese, if required. Major General Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh* (New Delhi: Lancer Publishers, 1980), 162-163.

¹⁷⁵ This Brigade operated directly under the command of 33 Corps. Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 51.

¹⁷⁶ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 84.

- (3) A major thrust by one division would be launched along Hilli – Goraghat Axis to spilt 16 Division forces in two.
 - (4) No threat was envisaged to Bogra via Nawabganj because of the poor approach routes from Balurghat and Malda.
- b. The division divided its area of responsibility into three sub-sectors and assigned one to each of its brigades. 23 Brigade, which was the strongest with five infantry battalions and an armoured squadron, was deployed in the north to defend the Dinajpur and Rangpur. The Bogra Sub-sector was made the responsibility of 205 Brigade consisting of three infantry battalions and a squadron of tanks. Hilli was developed as a strong point, whereas, Bogra was to be a fortress. The third brigade, 34 Brigade, was to defend Nator Sub-sector but at the same time, it was expected to act as divisional reserves.¹⁷⁷
 - c. The deployment of 23 and 205 Brigades, in accordance with the policy of the Eastern Command, was in forward positions close to the border outposts along with the EPCAF elements. All likely approaches were held by different battalion groups. There was, as such, no brigade defensive position.¹⁷⁸

147. Indian Plans

- a. The main offensive in 33 Corps was to be launched by 20 Mountain Division. The division planned to utilize one brigade for the advance to Dinajpur and for the subsequent capture of Rangpur as a secondary effort. Whereas, the main thrust was to be launched by two brigades to cut the waistline at Gaibanda along Hilli – Goraghat – Palasbari Axis. The Corps and Divisional commanders expressed reservations on the plan. They felt, the Hilli approach was obvious and involved a direct attack on the strong defence of Hilli. In addition, the axes of advance of the brigades were widely separated precluding mutual support. In view of the difference on the concept of the plan, the divisional commander was summoned by Aurora to Calcutta in August where the divisional commander suggested that an advance through the waistline need not take the strongly held

¹⁷⁷ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 437.

¹⁷⁸ It was admitted by both Lieutenant General Niazi and Major General Nazar Hussain in their evidence during the Hamoodur Rehman Commission Inquiry. *Ibid.*, 437.

Hilli – Goraghat Axis and the task could be carried out better by an advance along Samjia – Phulbari – Charkai – Pirganj Axis.¹⁷⁹

- b. Tasks for each brigade, on D Day basis, were laid down in detail by the Eastern Command:-

(1) *Main Effort*

(a) 202 Mountain Brigade to capture Hilli and then advance to capture Palasbari along the Goraghat Axis in conjunction with 66 Mountain Brigade advancing from Charkai to Pirganj.

(b) 66 Mountain Brigade to advance from Samjia to Charkai via Phulbari and Capture Pirganj and Gaibanda.

(2) *Secondary Effort.* 71 Mountain Brigade to advance along the Pachagarh – Thakurgaon Axis to exploit up to Kanti Nagar Bridge and capture Dinajpur, if possible.¹⁸⁰

(3) 340 Mountain Brigade to contain Dinajpur and be available as a reserve.

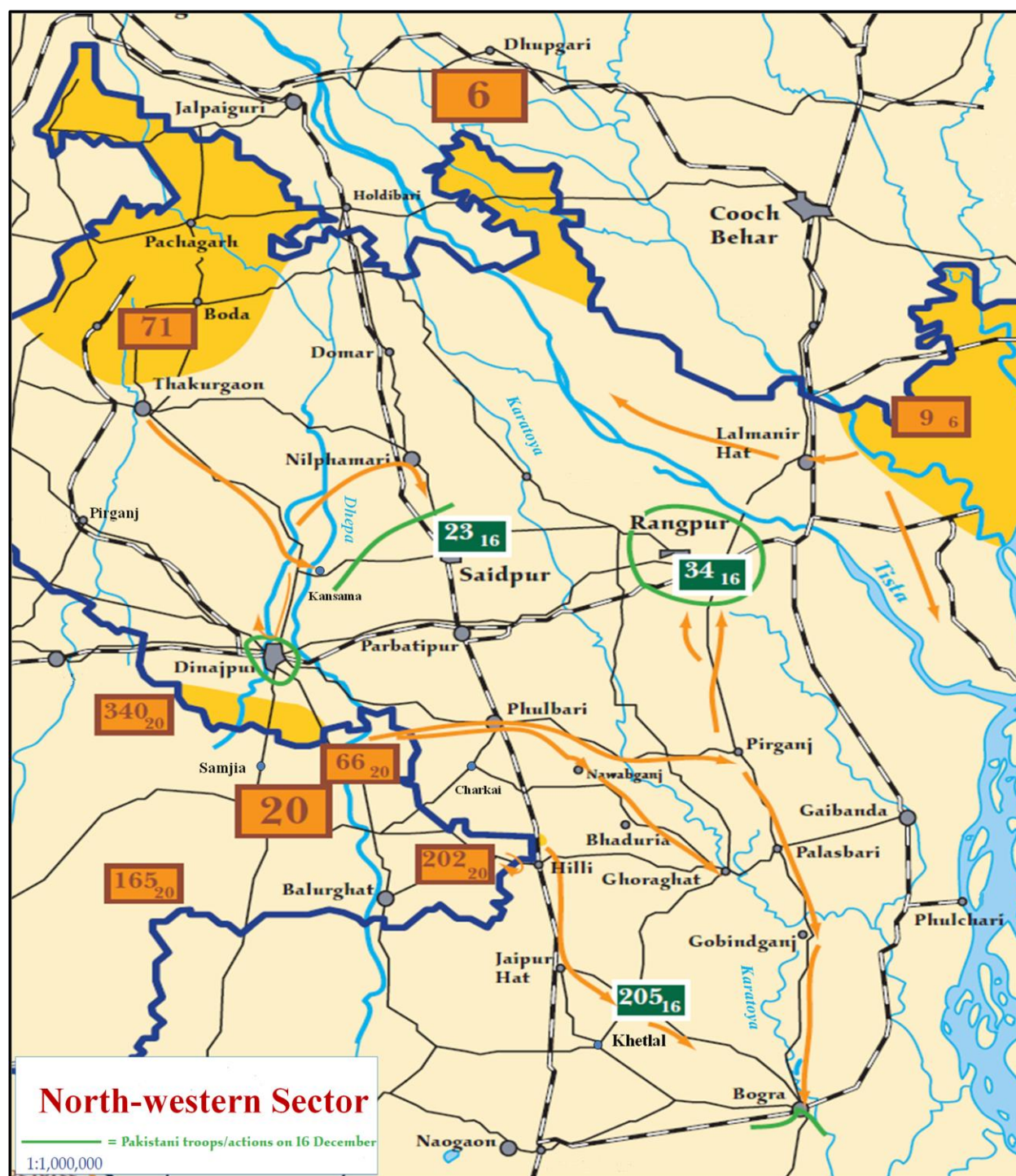
(4) 165 Mountain Brigade to establish a firm base in the Balurghat Bulge to defend the Balurghat and Malda areas.

- c. The subsequent development of operation toward Rangpur or Bogra was to be decided according to situation prevailing in the sector.¹⁸¹

¹⁷⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 86.

¹⁸⁰ The time frame for capture of Thakurgaon, Dinajpur, the bridge on Palasbari was five days from the start of hostilities. Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 163.

¹⁸¹ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 163.



MAP – 8

Conduct/ Battle Accounts/ Map - 8

148. Rangpur Sub-sector (23 Brigade)

- a. By 1 November, 33 Corps was able to concentrate its forces around the periphery of the North-western Sector, with 6 Mountain Division in the

north in Cooch Behar District, 71 Mountain Brigade in the northwest in the Siliguri area, and 20 Mountain Division in occupation of the Balurghat Bulge.¹⁸²

- b. Meanwhile, during the first week of November, the Indians attacked our positions east of River Tista. Bhurungamati was attacked and captured on 14 November. Efforts to retake this position under the orders of Eastern Command failed and resulted in considerable losses to 25 Punjab.¹⁸³ On night 20/21 November, enemy 4 Rajputs also crossed the border and attacked Nageshwari. The place was defended by a company of 8 Punjab and two companies of 25 Punjab. Enemy attack was repulsed. On night 29/30 November enemy attacked the position for the second time. Own troops withheld the Indians that night but, withdrew from Nageshwari on 30 November. Company of 8 Punjab joined 34 Punjab (R&S) elements at Thakurgaon; whereas, companies ex 25 Punjab withdrew to Saidpur.¹⁸⁴ At the same time, Kurigram, Alipur and Lal Munir Hat also came under intense pressure and the area across River Tista became untenable. Around 30 November, troops east of Tista were pulled back destroying all bridges on the river.¹⁸⁵
- c. West of Tista, to secure Siliguri Corridor, the Indian 71 Mountain Brigade started operations in late November to capture Pachagarh,¹⁸⁶ using three battalions i.e. 21 Rajputs, 7 Maratha Light Infantry (7 MLI) and 12 Grenadiers. The intention was to surround the company of 8 Punjab supported by a battery of 48 Field at Pachagarh¹⁸⁷ and slowly close in on them from three sides.¹⁸⁸ It was anticipated that the Pakistanis would be forced to counter attack to keep their routes of withdrawal open and thus suffer greater casualties at the hands of Indian troops, who would be

¹⁸² Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 164.

¹⁸³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 423.

¹⁸⁴ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 144-145.

¹⁸⁵ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 423.

¹⁸⁶ Pachagarh Salient was 25 kilometres long and 5 kilometres wide, and surrounded on three sides by India; it was an easy target for the enemy. A metalled cut across its base connecting the Indian towns of Jalpaiguri on the east to Titulya. Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 374.

¹⁸⁷ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 145.

¹⁸⁸ Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 61.

fighting from dug-in and prepared positions.¹⁸⁹ However, own troops withdrew from defences without fighting.¹⁹⁰

- d. On the afternoon of 4th day,¹⁹¹ 7 MLI captured Pachagarh Bridge and the whole township was captured soon afterwards.¹⁹² Our troops had pulled out their guns and vehicles on the first night, while the infantry company had slipped out on the third night on foot.¹⁹³
- e. Having obtained a launching pad 71 Mountain Brigade was given the task to capture Dinajpur as soon as possible. Besides its four infantry battalions, the brigade had support of some 2000-3000 Mukti Bahinis. They carried the Indians' heavy loads on rickshaws, bicycles and even on their own shoulders.¹⁹⁴ According to Palit, the Mukti Bahinis "would melt away at night and return next morning with details of enemy strong points and gun positions."¹⁹⁵
- f. After withdrawing from Pachagarh, own troops left behind a company size delaying position at Boda, occupied by platoon each of 34 Punjab, 25 Punjab and EPCAF.¹⁹⁶ By 27 November, 71 Mountain Brigade resumed its advance toward south with 12 Rajputana Rifles (12 Raj Rif) and a squadron of 69 Cavalry securing Boda, halfway between Pachagarh and Thakurgaon. On 1 December, 21 Rajputs who were now in the lead got held up north of Thakurgaon by a demolished bridge over the Bhuli Nadi.¹⁹⁷
- g. The Indians put across a bridge and contacted the Thakurgaon defences by 1600 hours on 1 December. A plan was made for a quick attack on Thakurgaon with 21 Rajputs from the north. A company of 34 Punjab assisted by a company of 8 Punjab withstood three enemy battalion attacks from 1-3 December in front of Thakurgaon before withdrawing to

¹⁸⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 88.

¹⁹⁰ Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 61.

¹⁹¹ According to Kamal Matinuddin, Pachagarh Salient fell to Indians on night 31 October/ 1 November 1971. Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 374. Whereas, as per Shaukat Riza, Pakistani troops withdrew on night 27/ 28 November. Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 145.

¹⁹² 71 Indian Mountain Brigade supported by the Mukti Bahini occupied the Pachagarh Salient on night 31 October/ 1 November as it was virtually undefended. Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 374.

¹⁹³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 88.

¹⁹⁴ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 374.

¹⁹⁵ Major General D.K. Palit, *The Lightning Campaign* (Salisbury: Camptan Press, 1972), 70.

¹⁹⁶ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 145.

¹⁹⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 89.

Pirganj, north of Dinajpur.¹⁹⁸ A company of 7 MLI though established a road block south of Thakurgaon, nevertheless, elements of 8 and 34 Punjab managed to escape the Indian trap, once again.¹⁹⁹ 34 Punjab, after withdrawing from Thakurgaon organised a delaying position at Pirganj.

- h. 23 Brigade could not defend Thakurgaon. Commander of the brigade was changed from Brigadier Ansari to Brigadier Shaffi.²⁰⁰
- i. Meanwhile, 16 Division sensing the threat, ordered 34 Brigade to move from Nator to Rangpur to conduct defensive operations in the Rangpur area.²⁰¹
- j. On 3 December, 71 Mountain Brigade was placed under 6 Mountain Division. On 6 December, at 2100 hours, the Indian 7 MLI tried to take Pirganj, but failed. A second attack came at 0800 hours on 9 December. Our troops destroyed four enemy tanks and forced the enemy to withdraw. 7 MLI suffered heavy casualties.²⁰² 34 Punjab remained in possession of Pirganj.²⁰³
- k. Unable to take Pirganj, 7 MLI bypassed it and contacted Kanti Nagar Bridge on Dhepa River by approximately 2100 hours on 6 December. Here again Indians were greeted with a very heavy volume of fire. The bridge at Kanti Nagar had already been destroyed by own withdrawing troops. During the night, 7 MLI tried to get across the river, but failed due to strong opposition by elements of 34 Punjab.²⁰⁴
- l. At this moment the Indians opened up another axis. To facilitate the advance of 71 Mountain Brigade, Indian 340 Mountain Brigade attacked Dinajpur from west. Attack by 4 Madras of 340 Mountain Brigade failed at Ramsagar,²⁰⁵ on the outskirts of Dinajpur, on 5 December against a

¹⁹⁸ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 375.

¹⁹⁹ Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 62.

²⁰⁰ Ibid.

²⁰¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 89.

²⁰² 7 MLI battalion commander, adjutant and FOO, with 70 other ranks were killed at Pirganj. Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 146.

²⁰³ Ibid.

²⁰⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 89.

²⁰⁵ Major General Hakeem Arshad Qureshi, *The 1971 Indo-Pak War: A Soldier's Narrative* (Karachi: Oxford Press, 2002), 149.

company of 26 FF. Attacks on the companies of 26 FF at Birol in the west of Dinajpur and Bantora in the south were also repulsed.²⁰⁶

- m. In the meanwhile, 71 Mountain Brigade held up at Dhepa River got information through Mukti Bahinis that Pakistanis had vacated Dinajpur. So on 9 December, two companies of 12 Raj Rif were dispatched to occupy Dinajpur. The companies crossed the Dhepa River a few kilometres southwest of Kanti Nagar after last light on 9 December without interference and advanced into Dinajpur town after first light. Soon after, the Pakistani tanks, which had established themselves in the northern part of this town, fired at the Indian troops. Against this strong opposition the Indians withdrew and re-crossed the river in small parties.²⁰⁷ On 10 December, the Indians decided to abandon the plan to capture Dinajpur.
- n. Unable to proceed toward Dinajpur, 6 Mountain Division redirected its advance. It planned then to cross the River Dhepa near Khansama to move toward Saidpur. Nevertheless, an unexplained delay of nine days, after capturing Thakurgaon, took place before the Indians advance resumed. This gave the defenders time to regroup around Saidpur, an important road and railway communication centre.
- o. 71 Mountain Brigade moved to Khansama, where leading elements were held up by the company of 48 Punjab.²⁰⁸ The Brigade ordered 21 Rajputs to carryout a daylight attack on Khansama on 13 December from a flank with full support of armour and artillery rather than to wait for night. The Pakistanis had prepared strong positions in Khansama, but they withdrew when their rear was threatened by an outflanking tank and infantry manoeuvre.²⁰⁹
- p. On 14 December, Brigadier Shaffi ordered 26 FF from Dinajpur and elements of 48 Punjab to push back the Indian troops across Dhepa River. This force while moving towards Khansama came under intense aerial strafing and shelling by medium guns.²¹⁰ The counter attack fizzled out before reaching the target area.

²⁰⁶ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 375.

²⁰⁷ Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 63-64.

²⁰⁸ Qureshi, *The 1971 Indo-Pak War*, 166.

²⁰⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 90.

²¹⁰ Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 65.

- q. At this stage, 5 Grenadiers were given to 71 Mountain Brigade to advance along with 12 Raj Rif. The intention was to exploit up to the road and cut off our troops at Nilphamari from falling back on Saidpur. Once again, the Indian troops earmarked to establish the road block were not in time and our troops managed to slip through from Nilphamari to Saidpur during night.²¹¹
- r. On 16 December, when the ceasefire was announced, 71 Mountain Brigade was 5 kilometres short of Nilphamari.²¹² The garrison at Saidpur which had been beefed up by the remnants of 23 Brigade held out till the very end.²¹³
- s. Dinajpur, Saidpur and Rangpur the only three major towns in 23 Brigade sector remained in Pakistani hands till ordered by Eastern Command to ceasefire on 16 December. The Indian Army in spite of its superiority in land and in the air could not humble the defenders in these cities.²¹⁴

149. Bogra Sub-sector (205 Brigade)

- a. To ensure a quick victory 20 Mountain Division's plan was to attack along the narrowest portion of the sector, though that was the toughest. 202 Mountain Brigade was to work its way eastward capturing Hilli, Palasbari and Goraghat thus linking itself with the downward thrust of 71 Brigade of 6 Mountain Division.²¹⁵
- b. 202 Mountain Brigade's attack on Hilli was launched on 23 November by 8 Guards supported by a squadron of 63 Cavalry. 5 Garhwal Rifles were earmarked as reserve and made available to 202 Mountain Brigade in Hilli. Naopara, defended by a 4 FF platoon, fell without much resistance but Morapara, a 4 FF company location, could not be captured in the first attack in spite of heavy casualties.²¹⁶
- c. Just before the dawn, 202 Mountain Brigade inducted the second battalion, 5 Garhwals, to capture Basudeopur BOP which it captured before first light on 24 November. While the 8 Guards captured Morapara

²¹¹ Singh, *Indian Sword Strikes in East Pakistan*, 65.

²¹² Ibid., 53.

²¹³ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 377.

²¹⁴ Ibid.

²¹⁵ Ibid., 365-366.

²¹⁶ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 92.

on the morning of 25 November.²¹⁷ Nevertheless, 4 FF took heavy toll of the enemy.

- d. After 25 November, the Indians launched no further attack. Own troops did launch a quick counter attack on 25 November at 2100 hours, but this was easily beaten back by the Indians with the help of artillery and tanks. After this, a stalemate set in around Hilli in which both sides carried out daily shelling, but no major operations took place²¹⁸ in this sector till 3 December.²¹⁹
- e. As a result of the bitter struggle and heavy casualties in Hilli, the Indians revised their plans. It was decided that Hilli should not be captured and the thrust should be re-directed northward to Charkai.²²⁰
- f. The plan visualised this advance by two brigades, 66 and 202 Mountain Brigades. 165 Mountain Brigade was already deployed west of Hilli for the security of the Balurghat Bulge, and 340 Mountain Brigade, having shed two battalions, one each to 66 and 202 Mountain Brigades, was investing Dinajpur from the southerly direction.²²¹
- g. 66 Mountain Brigade Group, advanced rapidly along the Samjia – Bajai – Phulbari Axis and covering about 20 kilometres, contacted Phulbari in the afternoon of 4 December. It was held by a Mujahid Battalion and a company of 26 FF.²²² The town was cleared by the Indians an hour later. Own troop had earlier withdrawn to Prabatipur.²²³
- h. As the advance progressed in depth, the problems of following it up with administrative echelons increased for the Indians. Indian intelligence reported the Phulbari – Charkai road as brick-paved, but it turned out to be only a wet track which even tanks found difficult to negotiate.²²⁴ The Indian Engineer Brigade with the help of locals converted the railway embankment into a higher classification road in two days.²²⁵ The Indian

²¹⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 92.

²¹⁸ Indian decided to maintain pressure on the Hilli Complex in the hope of misleading the Pakistani commanders regarding the change in plans. Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 169.

²¹⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 92.

²²⁰ Ibid.

²²¹ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 168.

²²² Riza, *The Pakistan Army (1966-71)*, 147.

²²³ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 170.

²²⁴ 20 MLI was a motorized battalion. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 93.

²²⁵ The Indians had full support of Mukti Bahinis who were asked to collect as many villagers as possible to undertake this task. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 94.

advance continued, Charkai was secured by the evening of 4 December after traversing some 10 kilometres from Phulbari against minimal opposition.²²⁶

- i. After capturing Charkai, 66 Mountain Brigade tried to capture Hilli from the northern direction and link up with 22 Mountain Brigade. Elements of 4 FF and 13 FF fought heroically. Enemy attacks were dealt with unexpected stubbornness.²²⁷ The Indians left Hilli as a bad job – a task too tough for their soldiers to accomplish.
- j. 32 Baloch less a company and a Razakar Unit was tasked to watch for enemy crossing over Karatoya River. Bravo Company of 32 Baloch was detached further east to defend Pirganj.²²⁸
- k. Unable to capture Hilli, 66 Mountain Brigade started a build-up for crossing Karatoya River. While it was in progress, 6 Guards, a follow up battalion, had on its own initiative moved further north, and finding Nawabganj empty occupied it on 5 December evening. Pushing ahead at night, they also secured the ferry site at Kanchdaha and established a foothold across the river by midday 6 December.²²⁹
- l. Capture of Kanchdaha ferry site, on Karatoya near Nawabganj, opened the way to Pirganj,²³⁰ but 66 Mountain Brigade had overstretched itself and was in no position to exploit the unexpected success. 20 Mountain Division had earlier planned a linkup between 66 and 202 Mountain Brigades north of Hilli, hoping that this would make 202 Mountain Brigade available to resume the advance from the Karatoya River. Efforts were, therefore, made to build up pressure from the north and south with both brigades but this plan yielded no meaningful progress.²³¹
- m. On the other hand, 202 Mountain Brigade that had to resume the advance from River Karatoya suffered heavy casualties at Hilli and showed its helplessness to collect its troops for quite sometime.²³² Left with no option, the division turned to 340 Mountain Brigade, to execute the plan.

²²⁶ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 170.

²²⁷ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 149.

²²⁸ Ibid., 147.

²²⁹ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 170.

²³⁰ Pirganj was on the main road from Rangpur to Bogra. Its capture cut 16 Division into two.

²³¹ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 171.

²³² It was decided to hold Hilli Complex with three battalions under 202 Mountain Brigade and 5 Garhwals were moved out to Nawabganj area after last light on 6 December. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 96.

The plan visualised the advance of the brigade toward Pirganj, capture the town and establishing road block to sever Rangpur from Bogra and Nator.²³³

- n. At this moment 340 Mountain Brigade was scattered all over the divisional sector. One battalion was allotted to 202 Mountain Brigade, another investing Dinajpur from the south, and the third spearheaded 66 Mountain Brigade's advance. The regrouping and the movement of the allotted armour and artillery took some 36 hours to complete, an inexcusable delay in mobile operations.²³⁴
- o. 340 Mountain Brigade commenced the advance after midday on 7 December from the secured crossing over the Karatoya River with one combat group of 2/5 Gorkha Rifles and 69 Armoured Regiment, less one squadron, along the Nawabganj – Pirganj Axis. The combat group pushed ahead speedily and captured Pirganj by afternoon without much fight.²³⁵
- p. The Indians ordered establishment of roadblocks along the Rangpur – Bogra highway. The roadblocks were in process of occupation when a Pakistani jeep column travelling from Rangpur toward Pirganj hit one of these roadblocks and was fired upon by the Indian tanks there. One jeep blew up, but the rest managed to escape in the darkness prevailing at that time. Next morning two jeeps, including one belonging to Major General Nazar Hussain,²³⁶ some marked maps and other valuable documents fell into Indian's hands.²³⁷
- q. On hearing of roadblocks, own troops at Rangpur and Bogra reacted sharply.²³⁸ Two companies of 32 Baloch led by their commanding officer rushed from Bogra and hit the 2/5 Gorkha Rifles roadblock a little past midnight. In the ensuing exchange of fire, the commanding officer was

²³³ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 171.

²³⁴ Ibid.

²³⁵ Ibid., 172.

²³⁶ Major General Hussain had held a conference at Rangpur on morning 7 December. At 1645 hours, when he and Brigadier Tajammal were returning to Bogra, they were intercepted by enemy tanks north of Pirganj. Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 147.

²³⁷ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 172.

²³⁸ On the night of 7/8 December the Pakistanis launched two feeble and disjointed attacks from the north and south against Pirganj. In the dawn attack from the south, CO 32 Baloch and 7 of his men were killed in a close engagement with 2/5 Gorkha. They had been instructed by Brigadier Tajjamal Hussain to throw out Indians raiding party from Pirganj. Till then the Pakistanis felt that the Indians had captured Pirganj with only a raiding column. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 98.

killed; his body was found by Indians the next morning. The rest of the force withdrew before dawn. It transpired later that they were advance elements of 32 Baloch ordered to occupy the Pirganj defences before the Indian thrust reached this place.

- r. At the same time, two companies of 8 Punjab, accompanied by tanks, came from Rangpur and attacked the roadblock in a spirited charge.²³⁹ But by then, two companies of 5/11 Gorkha Rifles had also arrived and adequately strengthened the block. The Pakistani assault was soon broken by concentrated fire from Indian tanks, artillery and mortars. Unable to make much headway, the force withdrew. This perhaps constituted the search party for the General, and he went back to Rangpur with it.²⁴⁰
- s. Having cut the 16 Division forces in two through capturing Pirganj, the Indians reviewed their plan and decided to launch a three-pronged attack from the north, against our rear and flank, all along the waistline from Hilli to Gobindganj. The main features of the plan were:-
 - (1) 202 Mountain Brigade to capture Hilli and advance eastward to link up with 66 Brigade in the Goraghat area and then advance to Bogra via Khetlal and capture it.
 - (2) 66 Mountain Brigade to advance from Nawabganj to capture Bhaduria and advance to Goraghat and Gobindganj to link up with 340 Mountain Brigade.
 - (3) 340 Mountain Brigade to advance from Pirganj to capture Gobindganj and then advance along the main road to Bogra and capture it.²⁴¹
- t. On 10 December, the Indians were informed by Mukti Bahinis that the Pakistani garrisons in the Rangpur – Saidpur area were planning to withdraw across the Jamuna towards Dacca. To thwart such an eventuality, 340 Mountain Brigade ordered a roadblock to be set up in the area of Gaibanda. The town was occupied at 1600 hours on 10 December. Its troops moved the same day across to the Phulchari ferry, where they destroyed the jetties and uprooted the rail track serving it. With

²³⁹ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 173.

²⁴⁰ Ibid.

²⁴¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 98-99.

the occupation of Gaibanda and the ferry, the Pakistani troops were denied an escape route.²⁴²

- u. As regards the 66 Mountain Brigade, held up at River Karatoya, it turned south and advanced towards Bhaduria on 9 December. The Brigade captured Bhaduria, a defended locality held by a company of 8 Baloch and 13 FF strength, on 11 December at considerable cost.^{243, 244}

150. Nator Sub-sector (34 Brigade)

- a. 34 Brigade was responsible for defending Rajshahi – Pabna – Nawabganj. Around 3 December, 34 Brigade was moved from Nator to Rangpur. So the brigade, essentially 32 Punjab and 32 Baloch, fought the Indians as they broke out after crossing Karatoya River. Around 10 December, when our troops at their own withdrew from Hilli, elements of 205 Brigade (remnants of 8 Baloch, 4 FF, 13 FF) which could not move toward Rangpur due to enemy presence around it, withdrew toward Bogra.²⁴⁵
- b. After denying 16 Division troops any exit toward Dacca by capturing Pulchari ferry by 10 December, the Indian's attention turned toward the main task of capturing Bogra. The immediate objective was Gobindganj, a small town lying along the Rangpur – Bogra highway south of the Karatoya. After leaving strong firm-bases in the general area of Pirganj to meet any threat from the Rangpur side, 340 Mountain Brigade moved towards Gobindganj.²⁴⁶
- c. In view of enemy advance, 16 Division shifted its headquarters from Bogra to Nator on 11 December. To contest enemy advance, the division formed a task force of remnants of 34 Brigade to fight ahead of Bogra. As part of this task force, 32 Baloch was defending Gobindganj.²⁴⁷ Whereas,

²⁴² Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 173.

²⁴³ 17 Kumaon suffered two officers, three JCOs and 67 other ranks wounded in that action without achieving any tactical advantage. It was claimed that 82 bodies, including one unit major and one artillery officer were counted in all. Ibid., 171.

²⁴⁴ Lieutenant General Jagjit Singh Aurora, confessed that one of the bloodiest battle in East Pakistan was fought at Bhaduria. Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Error*, 369.

²⁴⁵ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 149.

²⁴⁶ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 173-174.

²⁴⁷ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 439.

leftovers of 205 Brigade under Brigadier Tajjamal organised defence of Bogra.²⁴⁸

- d. Own troops at Gobindganj put up a determined resistance. Night fell and the fighting continued throughout it. By the first light of 12 December, Gobindganj was in Indian hands. Large cache of Pakistani arms, ammunition, and equipment was also captured.²⁴⁹ The Indian advance resumed at 1130 hours on 13 December by 69 Armoured Regiment and 5/11 Gorkha Rifles along the highway to Bogra. Contact was made with the Pakistani defences holding the Ichhamati River by the same evening. Elements of 32 Baloch were holding the southern portion of Ichhamati River. Due to large gaps in defences, the Indians were able to infiltrate a company behind 32 Baloch defences for a road block.²⁵⁰ The Ichhamati position was cleared by midday on 13 December.²⁵¹
- e. Meanwhile, by the evening of 13 December, 165 Mountain Brigade had also progressed toward the south of Hilli and had occupied area around Jaipurhat unopposed.²⁵²
- f. Bogra was reported to be held by elements of 205 Brigade with some artillery and tanks in support, although the exact dispositions are not known. 340 Mountain Brigade encircled Bogra from all directions on the night of 13/14 December.²⁵³ It approached the city from north and could only clear area upto the railway line by 1300 hours but our defences on the rail embankment stayed intact and active.²⁵⁴
- g. By 14 December, Pakistani resistance in Bogra was still retaining. It was then that the Indians decided to capture Rangpur. Plans were made for a two prong attack on this town by 66 and 202 Mountain Brigades simultaneously. The Indians brigades were short of Rangpur when the ceasefire was announced.²⁵⁵

²⁴⁸ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 439.

²⁴⁹ Sukhwant Singh, *The Liberation of Bangladesh*, 173-174.

²⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, 174-175.

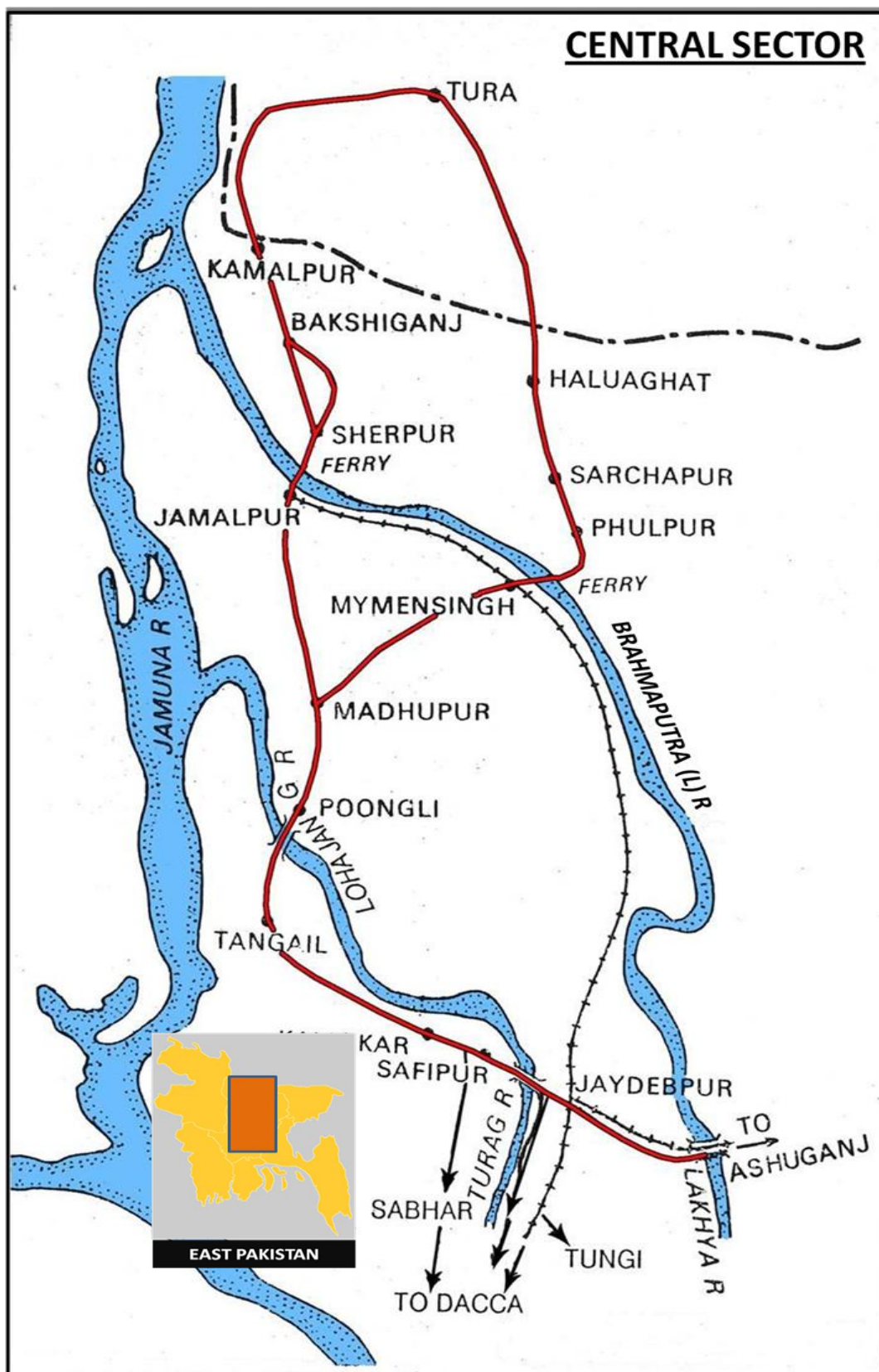
²⁵¹ *Ibid.*, 175.

²⁵² *Ibid.*, 175-176.

²⁵³ *Ibid.*, 176.

²⁵⁴ *Ibid.*

²⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, 177.



MAP – 9

CENTRAL SECTOR

The Area of Operation²⁵⁶

151. General

- a. The Central Sector was south of the Meghalaya and formed a triangle with its broad base in the north along the Indian border, with the Jamuna and Meghna forming its western and eastern sides. Dacca at the southern apex was the capital and political and psychological heart of East Pakistan. The sector comprised four districts: Jamalpur, Mymensingh, Tangail, and Dacca. However, the discussion of operations in this sector will not include area east of Brahmaputra (local) in Mymensingh and Dacca districts (Map - 9).
- b. In the north, on the Indian side there were limited roads in Meghalaya. Tura was the main communication centre from where two roads led to the border at Kamalpur and opposite Haluaghat. These two roads joined south of River Brahmaputra (local) at Madhupur.
- c. The Central Sector was less developed sector than the others. The area around Tangail/ Madhupur, which lay half-way to Dacca, was forested. Dacca, the capital city, lay in this sector. Apart from Dacca, other important towns and communication centres in this sector were Mymensingh, Tangail and Tungi.
- d. The eastern half of this sector was low-lying and had numerous small water obstacles, while the ground in the western half was higher from south of Mymensingh to east of Tangail.

152. Rivers

- a. There were three main rivers in the Central Sector which could affect military operations:-
 - (1) *River Jamuna*. It was the major river marking the western boundary of this sector. Had a span of 3 – 5 kilometres.
 - (2) *River Brahmaputra (Local)*. It was a local river, an old course of River Brahmaputra (Jamuna). It ran northwest to southeast diagonally about 40 kilometres south of international boundary and along the northern fringes of Jamalpur and Mymensingh,

²⁵⁶ Most of details about the Area of Operation have been taken from following books: (a) Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 415-20; (b) Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 5-6 & 80-84.

from where it turns South. East of Jaydebpur till Dacca, it was known among the locals as River Lakhya.

- (3) *River Lohyang*. Again an off-shoot of River Jamuna. It also ran diagonally west of River Brahmaputra, moved between Madhupur and Tangail. East of Kaliakar, it curled southward Dacca, from there on it was called River Turag.

- b. Apart from the River Brahmaputra (L), which was less formidable compared with other major rivers, there were no major obstacle to movement in this sector.

153. Significant Towns/ Villages

- a. There were only small towns north of River Brahmaputra (L). The river was not bridged but could be crossed over the ferries at Jamalpur and Mymensingh.
- b. Jamalpur and Mymensingh were the two villages along the southern bank of the Brahmaputra (L).
- c. Tangail was an important town and communication centre. Was at the junction of all roads leading south to Dacca.

154. Communication Infrastructure

- a. Movement into this sector was possible across the Jamuna at Phulchari, Sirajganj and Bera ferries from the North-western Sector and at Faridpur and Goalundo Ghat from the South-western Sector. In the east, the Meghna could be crossed at Bhairab Bazar, Daudkandi and Chandpur ferries. The railway bridge at Ashuganj provided the only land link between the eastern and central sectors.
- b. As regards the routes leading into the sector from India in the north, these were mainly two:-
- (1) *Tura – Jamalpur – Madhupur – Tangail – Dacca*. This was the most direct route (200 kilometres). From Sherpur there was a ferry connecting it with Jamalpur. The route negotiated flat paddy terrain east of the Jamuna and skirted the western slopes of the high ground of the Madhupur Jungle. A tarmac road ran from Bakshiganj to Jamalpur via Sherpur. There were no major rivers south of Jamalpur and the route was bridged all

the way. The River Lohajang could be crossed at Poongli Bridge, a few kilometres north of Tangail.

(2) *Tura – Haluaghat – Mymensingh – Madhupur – Tangail – Dacca*. A ferry connected Phulpur with Mymensingh.

- c. The two main ferries at Jamalpur and Mymensingh, were connected by a lateral road and rail along the southern bank of the Brahmaputra.
- d. A second railway line linked Dacca with Mymensingh and Jamalpur along the south bank of the Brahmaputra.
- e. The Indians would have had to launch operations from the hilly terrain of Meghalaya, which presented its own problems.

155. **Importance of the Sector**

- a. The terrain was open, plain and suitable for mobile operations.
- b. The area around Tangail/ Madhupur was forested and dominated by guerrillas under Mukti Bahini leader Siddiqui. Their presence in this vital area could be of immense assistance to the advancing troops.
- c. This sector provided the easiest approach to Dacca as few natural obstacles had to be overcome. The western flank of the advancing forces was secured along the River Jamuna, and River Brahmaputra (L)/ Lakhya protected their eastern flank.
- d. Gauhati, north of Tura in India, was a well-developed administrative base located along a railhead. It also had good airfields which could provide logistic and other forms of air support. Logistically, this sector could be better supported by the Indians compared with areas farther east which were more distant from the existing Indian Army depots.

Opposing Forces/ Maps – 9 & 10

156. **Pakistani Forces.** 36 (Adhoc) Division was defending this area. Division headquarters was located at Dacca. It was commanded by Major Muhammad Jamshed. The formation was made up with the remnants in and around Dacca.²⁵⁷ It did not have the formal components of a division. It consisted of following troops:-

- a. **93 (Adhoc) Brigade (Brigadier Fazle Qadir)²⁵⁸**
 - (1) 31 Baloch.
 - (2) 33 Punjab.

²⁵⁷ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 159.

²⁵⁸ *Ibid.*, 159.

- (3) 83 Mortar Battery (12 x 120 mm mortars).
- (4) Three wings of West Pakistan Rangers and five companies of Mujahids.²⁵⁹



MAP – 10

²⁵⁹ The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission, 425.

- b. **53 Brigade (Brigadier Aslam Niazi).** Located at Dacca upto 20 November (later moved to Feni).²⁶⁰

157. **Indian Forces.** 101 Communication Zone Area was commanded by Major General Gurbax Singh Gill. In addition to its normal job for providing logistic support to the formation in the region, 101 Communication Zone Area was also given the responsibility for tactical operations in this sector. It consisted of following troops:-²⁶¹

- a. 95 Mountain Brigade.
- b. FJ Sector (consisting of 6 Bihar, 83 BSF Battalion, and Mukti Bahini).²⁶²
- c. 167 Mountain Brigade (allotted at a later stage).
- d. 2 Para Battalion of 50 Para Brigade.²⁶³
- e. One mountain regiment and two batteries of heavy mortars formed the artillery elements.²⁶⁴
- f. Field company engineers.²⁶⁵

Opposing Plans

158. Pakistani Plans

- a. River Brahmaputra (L) provided the defenders with the advantage of an obstacle and strong defences were developed in Jamalpur and Mymensingh based on this obstacle. Jamalpur and Mymensingh were designated as theatre fortresses and no withdrawal was permitted beyond the line of these. Some troops were deployed forward, along both the axes coming down from Tura, who after imposing the necessary delay and casualties were to fall back into respective fortresses.²⁶⁶
- b. 93-A Brigade headquarters was in Mymensingh. It had only two regular battalions. 31 Baloch had four paramilitary companies to guard the Kamalpur – Jamalpur Axis. Whereas, 33 Punjab, with 61 Wing of Rangers, was to guard the Haluaghat – Mymensingh Axis. To deceive the Indians regarding the strength of their regular forces Rangers had been designated as 57 Baloch.²⁶⁷

²⁶⁰ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 199.

²⁶¹ Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 180-182.

²⁶² Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 150.

²⁶³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 425.

²⁶⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 149.

²⁶⁵ Ibid.

²⁶⁶ Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 180.

²⁶⁷ Ibid.

- c. Eastern Command held this sector weakly as they had anticipated a weak thrust from the Indians. 93-A Brigade had no tanks or engineer elements in this sector and their transport resources were meagre.²⁶⁸

159. Indian Plans

- a. The Indians' intention was to tie down 93-A Brigade along the Haluaghat – Mymensing Axis by a show of force with one battalion and to overwhelm our forces along the Kamalpur – Jamalpur Axis by using a full brigade.²⁶⁹
- b. Salients of Indian operational plan were:-
 - (1) *Main Thrust.* 95 Mountain Brigade was to launch the main thrust along Kamalpur – Jamalpur Axis with a view to capture Jamalpur by D plus 6/7. Thereafter, it had to linkup with FJ Sector and capture Tangail by D plus 8. A para-drop was also planned to secure the bridge on the River Lohaganj north of Tangail and cut the retreat of the withdrawing 93-A Brigade so that they could be crushed by the advancing forces against the anvil of the road-block to be established by the paratroopers.²⁷⁰
 - (2) *Secondary Thrust.* FJ Sector to advance along Haluaghat – Mymensingh Axis, as a subsidiary effort to capture Mymensingh after the capture of Jamalpur. Elements of 83 BSF Battalion were to advance farther east along the Sarchapur – Mymensingh track.²⁷¹
 - (3) An Inland Water Transport Task Force was to move down from River Jamuna to Jamalpur down the River Brahmaputra, to provide logistic support to the forces.²⁷²

Conduct/ Battle Accounts/ Map - 9

160. Jamalpur Approach (31 Baloch)

- a. In late November, 95 Mountain Brigade made number of attempts to capture Kamalpur BOP.²⁷³ On 18 November, Indian troops

²⁶⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 150.

²⁶⁹ Ibid., 151

²⁷⁰ Ibid., 150

²⁷¹ Ibid.

²⁷² Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 182.

²⁷³ It was held by one platoon of regular troops, the rest were Mujahids. Niazi, *The Betrayal of East Paksitan*, 160.

ambushed the 83 Mortar Battery that moved forward of Buskhiganj to provide fire support²⁷⁴ and around 3-4 December, it intensified the air and artillery raids along with ground efforts.²⁷⁵ Troops of 31 Baloch, with no artillery support, fought at Kamalpur till their entire ammunition was spent; they only then were captured by the Indians on 4 December.²⁷⁶

- b. While the battle of Kamalpur was on, 95 Mountain Brigade planned capture of Bakshiganj which lay farther south at the junction of Kamalpur - Jamalpur and Jamalpur - Sherpur roads. 1 Marathas and one battery of artillery and a Rajutana Rifle Battalion with a light mortar battery moved cross-country and contacted the defenders in Bakshiganj before first light of 4 December. Mukti Bahinis were sent to establish roadblocks south of Bakshiganj.²⁷⁷
- c. Throughout the day and night firing went on. Own troops from 31 Baloch slipped out of their defences and withdrew south by first light 5 December. The blocks Mukti Bahini planned south of Bakshiganj had not been properly established and had gaps, especially astride the main road. According to General Lachhman Singh, "The Muktis had not developed confidence to face Pakistani attacks on their roadblocks and chose to let the Pakistanis slip out rather than expose themselves to the dangers of an attack from regular forces."²⁷⁸
- d. In view of loss of Kamalpur and Bakshiganj, the protective elements at far flung border posts out in the Central Sector were also withdrawn.²⁷⁹
- e. Early on the morning of 5 December Major General Gill with commander 95 Mountain Brigade went forward to Bakshiganj to see the position. Their jeep got blown up by an anti-tank mine. While the brigade commander escaped shaken but unhurt, General Gill was seriously wounded and had to be evacuated.²⁸⁰ The same day he was relieved by Major General G C Nagra. Nagra had with him adequate

²⁷⁴ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 159.

²⁷⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 151

²⁷⁶ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 439.

²⁷⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 151

²⁷⁸ *Ibid.*, 152

²⁷⁹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 439.

²⁸⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 152

staff including senior staff officers, his engineer commander with one field company, engineer stores, signal personnel and equipment from his division to facilitate his command and control setup.²⁸¹

- f. The advance was resumed from Bakshiganj at first light on 6 December along the main road and enemy opposition was cleared at a bridge about six kilometres south of the village with the help of air strikes and artillery support. But the withdrawing troops demolished the bridge. A Bailey bridge was however launched by 0600 hours on 7 December and the advancing troops reached the northern bank of the River Brahmaputra (L) by last light the same day.²⁸²
- g. The Indians had planned to block the Jamalpur garrison from the south so that it could not withdraw towards Dacca. They intended to destroy 31 Baloch at Jamalpur so that it could not resist the advancing Indians farther south in their subsequent drive to Dacca.²⁸³
- h. While one battalion was advancing along the main axis, it had been planned to cross the river with 1 Marathas at Shyampur ferry, which is about eight kilometres west of Jamalpur. 13 Guards were to follow 1 Marathas and bullock carts and country boats had been arranged at the ferry site by Mukti Bahini guides.²⁸⁴
- i. 1 Marathas moved across the river on the night of 7/8 December. It was able to establish a road block south of Jamalpur by first light of 9 December. During this entire build-up General Nagra had been controlling the battle from air.²⁸⁵
- j. After last light, 1 Marathas moved off on a wide hook and by first light of 9 December set up a roadblock south of Jamalpur. It was decided that 1 Marathas and 13 Guards should close in on Jamalpur to invest it from all sides, thus leaving no gaps for 31 Baloch to escape. General Nagra also agreed to move one more battalion to the south bank to

²⁸¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 152.

²⁸² Ibid., 153.

²⁸³ Ibid., 153-54.

²⁸⁴ Ibid., 153.

²⁸⁵ Ibid., 154.

provide adequate troops to 95 Mountain Brigade for the capture of Jamalpur.²⁸⁶

- k. Jamalpur had been pounded by air and artillery from 8 December onwards. On 10 December Jamalpur was attacked by napalm and rockets from the air. The Indian build-up continued till 10 December.²⁸⁷
- l. General Officer Commanding 36-A Division ordered Brigadier Qadir on 10 December to vacate Jamalpur and Mymensingh and fall back on Kaliakar. Till then the plan had been to fight till end in Jamalpur and Mymensingh fortresses and there were no plans for withdrawal.²⁸⁸
- m. Qadir hesitated to give up his prepared defences and tried to get these orders cancelled. But he finally issued orders to evacuate the fortresses on the night of 10/11 December.²⁸⁹ As the morning fog lifted, 31 Baloch had slipped out of the Indian cordon, though after suffering heavy casualties.²⁹⁰
- n. 93-A Brigade had no plans for withdrawal and, what was worse, the Indians had established roadblocks south of Jamalpur which 31 Baloch was not fully aware of. As General Nagra had nearly three battalions south of the River, it was too late for them to avert the disastrous consequences of this last-minute change in plans.²⁹¹ About 384 prisoners were rounded up in Jamalpur on the morning of 11 December.²⁹² 31 Baloch had almost lost its fighting potency and the road to Dacca lay open.

161. **Mymensingh Approach (33 Punjab)**

- a. The Pakistanis believed that the main Indian force would advance towards Mymensingh and Brigadier Qadir had positioned his headquarters there to exercise closer control on this axis. He had deployed 33 Punjab and 61 Wing of Rangers to guard it.²⁹³

²⁸⁶ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 155.

²⁸⁷ Ibid., 157.

²⁸⁸ Ibid., 158.

²⁸⁹ Jamalpur had been developed as a fortress and was expected to hold out for 10-15 days. *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 439-440.

²⁹⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 158.

²⁹¹ Ibid.

²⁹² Ibid., 159.

²⁹³ Ibid.

- b. FJ Sector planned to carry out its task as under:-²⁹⁴
- (1) 6 Bihar less two companies to infiltrate and attack Haluaghat from the south.
 - (2) Two companies 6 Bihar to infiltrate and capture Sarchapur.
 - (3) Mukti Bahini to isolate Pakistani defences in Haluaghat and Sarchapur simultaneously with these operations.
 - (4) BSF to advance on the Baghmara - Mymensingh Axis to make a show of force toward Mymensingh.
- c. On of the night of 4/5 December, the 6 Bihar column hit the Pakistani forces about three kilometres southeast of Haluaghat. The Biharis captured the position but came under fire from mortars and jeep-mounted machine guns in Haluaghat. Firing went on the whole day and the Biharis closed in on the Haluaghat defences on the night of 5/6 December. On 6 December Haluaghat was attacked by air; our troops slipped out on the night of 6/7 December.²⁹⁵
- d. After the fall of Haluaghat, 6 Bihar elements advanced to Sarchapur, and threatened Sarchapur from the southeast by last light on 7 December. Meantime the second column of two companies moved south and threatened Phulpur. Own troops abandoned Sarchpur, which the Biharis occupied after first light on 9 December.²⁹⁶
- e. The troops of 33 Punjab were concentrated at Mymensingh, which too had been developed as a fortress but on 10 December, the whole brigade was ordered to withdraw and take up defensive positions on the Goari Hillocks, twenty mile northwest of Dacca. This order was given because by this time, the enemy had pierced through the 39-A Division in east and the Indian 9 Division in the west was heading for Dacca. The efforts of the Eastern Command to get troops from other areas had, in the absence of any pre-planning in that behalf, also failed because of the non-availability of necessary transport facilities across the big rivers. It was, in these circumstances that the 93-A Brigade had been ordered to leave its prepared positions at Jamalpur and Mymensingh.²⁹⁷

²⁹⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 160.

²⁹⁵ Ibid.

²⁹⁶ Ibid.

²⁹⁷ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 440.

- f. The Indians resumed their advance from Phulpur on the morning of 10 December and occupied already vacated Mymensingh Fortress. 6 Bihar concentrated there by the evening of 11 December and captured Madhupur without opposition by 0830 hours on 12 December.²⁹⁸
 - g. On 11 December morning Jamalpur and Mymensingh both fell to the advancing Indian troops. The Indians dropped a para-battalion in the afternoon of 11 December in a hope of capturing withdrawing troops of 93-A Brigade. At 2000 hours, 2 Para Battalion captured Poongli Bridge. At 2230 hours, the rear parties of 33 Punjab and 61 Wing Rangers hit the paratroopers near Poongli Bridge.²⁹⁹
 - h. But the main force of Pakistanis had escaped before the para-drop and only the last of rear parties from Mymensingh were intercepted. Prisoners consisted of two officers of the mortar battery and some jawans of 33 Punjab and Rangers. The paratroopers had barely managed to get hold of the tail of the withdrawing force and pulled out a few hairs.³⁰⁰
162. **Tangail to Dacca (Remnant of 93-A Brigade)**
- a. The situation on the Pakistan side worsened on 11 December. Having withdrawn from Mymensingh, Brigadier Qadir waited for 31 Baloch at Madhupur. He had kept one company of 33 Punjab with him while the rest of the battalion moved to Kaliakar. When 31 Baloch did not fetch up, he moved to Tangail on the morning of 11 December, leaving the rearguard company at Madhupur. A few hours later commanding officer of 31 Baloch, Lieutenant Colonel Sultan Ahmed, also joined him.³⁰¹
 - b. At Tangail, Qadir and Sultan saw the para-drop³⁰² in the afternoon and decided to move out quickly. Elements of company of 33 Punjab at Madhupur were ordered to withdraw but were caught by the Indian paratroopers. They split into two-groups to avoid detection and decided to move cross-country to Kaliakar on foot. Qadir took three days to reach Kaliakar and was taken prisoner by the advancing

²⁹⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 161.

²⁹⁹ Ibid., 161-162.

³⁰⁰ Ibid., 162.

³⁰¹ Ibid.

³⁰² Some of our men mistook them for friendly troops and shouted "Pak-China Dosti Zindabad". Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 161.

Indians who had reached the area before him. While Ahmed linked up with own troops near Tungi,³⁰³ where he fought doggedly in the last two days of the war.³⁰⁴

- c. 95 Mountain Brigade led the advance from Jamalpur with 1 Marathas at 0300 hours on 12 December and joined the paratroopers at 1700 hours the same day. Tangail fell without opposition by last light. From now on it was a race to Dacca.³⁰⁵
- d. The Indians were in high spirits; nevertheless, their administrative limitations were seriously affecting the speed of their advance. To overcome this problem, the Indians discovered a landing ground near Tangail with the help of Mukti Bahinis. From 13 December onward their aircrafts landed supplies there, and eased the Indians' administration considerably.³⁰⁶
- e. On the other hand, our withdrawing troops were short of vehicles, weapons and ammunition and their withdrawal had almost become a rout. The aggressive activities of Mukti Bahinis under Siddiqui³⁰⁷ and the para-drop at Tangail added to their plight.³⁰⁸
- f. Nagra decided to press on with 95 Mountain Brigade to capture Kaliaker.³⁰⁹ There was only one road from Tangail to Kaliakar, but two led from Kaliakar to Dacca.³¹⁰
- g. 6 Sikh Light Infantry (SLI) resumed advance from Tangail at 0600 hours on 13 December with the two leading companies in transport while the rest followed on foot. Kaliakar was captured after a skirmish by 2200 hours. The advance continued at night and the leading troops hit the Pakistani defences along the River Turag at 0800 hours on 14 December. The Pakistanis were holding defences on both sides of the

³⁰³ 31 Baloch reached Dacca without their vehicles and their heavy weapons and completely exhausted after walking a distance of 100 miles or so. Nevertheless, the position was so desperate that on 15th December they were again move back to Tungi to take up defensive positions there. *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 440.

³⁰⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 163.

³⁰⁵ Ibid.

³⁰⁶ Ibid.

³⁰⁷ Most famous Mukti Bahini leader. He organized and fought with an estimated 10,000 strong army of civilians in the Tangail region against the Pakistan Army.

³⁰⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 164.

³⁰⁹ Ibid.

³¹⁰ Ibid.

river. The advancing troops were held up and could not make progress.³¹¹

- h. At this stage two lucky events occurred for the Indians: a patrol of 6 SLI apprehended ten officers including Brigadier Qadir of 93-A Brigade; and Indians discovered a road link which led to Dacca via Sabhar without a water obstacle except at the Mirpur Bridge on the outskirts of Dacca. This road permitted the advancing troops to reach Dacca without crossing the River Turag.³¹²
- i. On our side, 31 Baloch reached Dacca without their vehicles and their heavy weapons and was completely battle exhausted after walking a distance of 100 kilometres or so. Nevertheless, the position was so desperate that on 15 December they were again moved back to Tungi to take up defensive positions there. There they fought till were asked by the Eastern Command to surrender on 16 December.³¹³
- j. The position of Indian forces at midnight on 14 December was that 95 Mountain Brigade had reached the Turag with three battalions, one mountain regiment less battery and one light battery. FJ Sector with two battalions and one mountain battery were in the Safipur area. 2 Para and 167 Brigade with two battalions were still in the Tangail area. None of the B echelon had yet crossed to the south bank of the Brahmaputra.³¹⁴
- k. The battle of Dacca was due to commence.

³¹¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 165.

³¹² Ibid.

³¹³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 440.

³¹⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 166.



MAP – 11

1. Sylhet Sub-sector.
2. Brahmanbaria Sub-sector.

NORTH-EASTERN SECTOR³¹⁵

The Area of Operation³¹⁶/ Maps – 12 & 13

163. General

- a. North-eastern Sector stretched from Sylhet in the north to excluding Comilla in the south – a frontage of more than 320 kilometres. It was sandwiched between River Meghna/ Surma in the west and the international border in the east (Map - 11).
- b. This sector was bounded in the north and east by hills of varying heights. As a result, the grain of the country in the northern portion was from east to west. Rest, the terrain in most of the sector was low-lying plain covered with numerous perennial lakes.
- c. Sylhet and border areas in the southeastern part near Dharmanagar and Kailashahar had tea gardens. The rainfall in the area was very heavy with annual average of approximately 550 centimetres.
- d. The main road communication ran from north to south, that is Shillong – Jaintiapur – Sylhet – Maulvi Bazar – Brahmanbaria. A number of roads connected the border area to this main thoroughfare and then went further to the west on to the sites of ferries on River Meghna.
- e. North-eastern Sector could be further distinguished into two sub-sectors: Sylhet Sub-sector; and Brahmanbaria Sub-sector.

164. Rivers

- a. *River Surma*. Entered the sector at Atgram, flowed south of Sylhet and joined Meghna west of Saidpur. Span was around 100 metres.
- b. *River Kusyara*. It entered the area close to Bhanga (India) further south of River Surma, moved between Magla Bazar and Fenchuganj, south of Saidpur before joining River Meghna. Span was 100-150 metres.

³¹⁵ **Note:** The eastern portion of East Pakistan had varying types of terrain. In the area around Sylhet and to the east of it, it was either undulating or hilly. South of Sylhet right down to Comilla, it was an open plain area. Near Comilla again, there was a low hill range and south of it, it was open. In the south-eastern part of Chittagong hills, it was hilly and forested. Hence, for the convenience of description from the point of view of terrain and deployment to of Pakistan Army troops, the area has been considered under two broad sectors: *North-eastern Sector* to include Sylhet in the north to excluding Comilla in the south; and *Mid & South-eastern Sector* to include Comilla in the north and Cox's Bazar in the south.

³¹⁶ Most of details about the Area of Operation have been taken from following books: (a) Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 399-406; (b) Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 5-6 & 80-84.

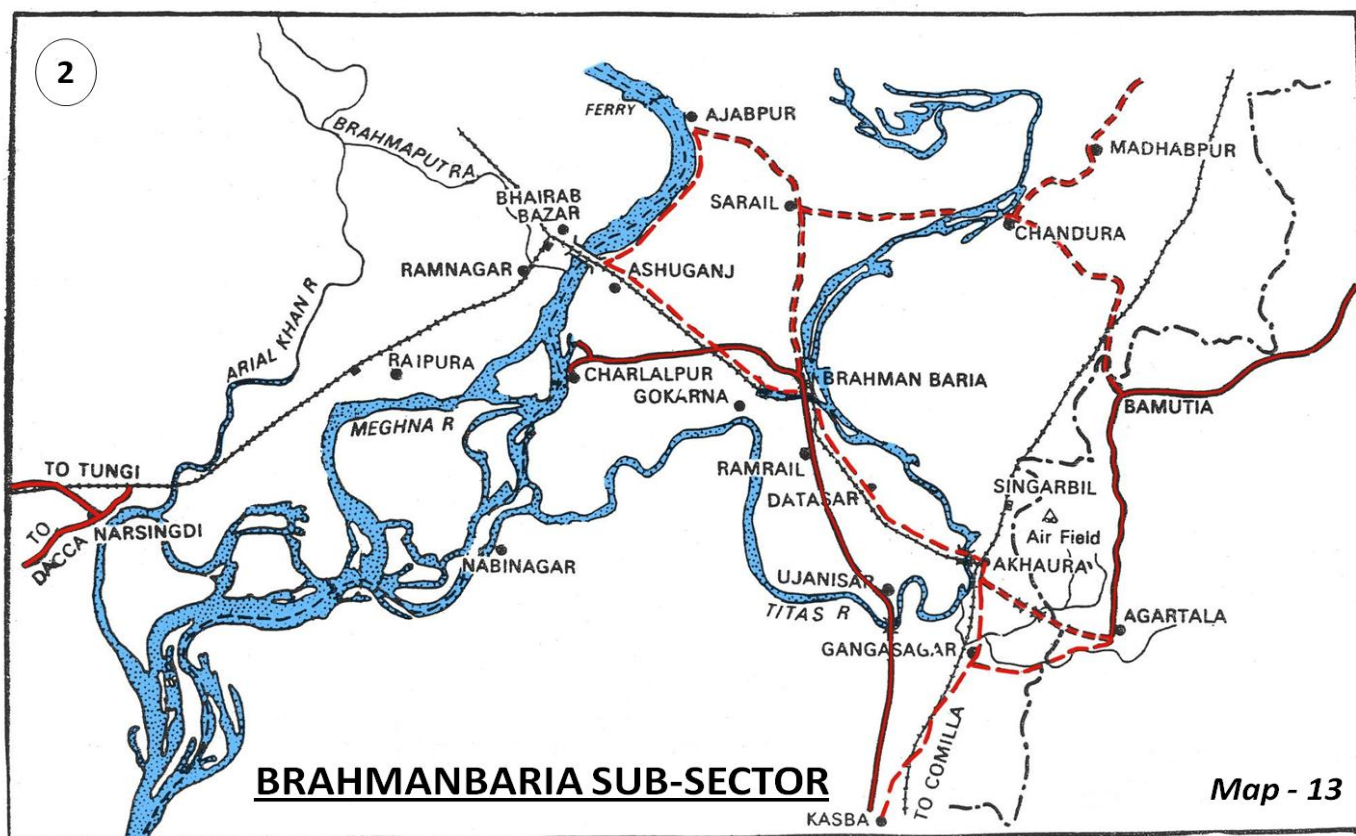
SYLHET SUB-SECTOR

1



Map - 12

2

**BRAHMANBARIA SUB-SECTOR**

Map - 13

- c. *River Meghna*. It shaped up west of Saidpur and then flowed down till Dacca. It was a major river with span as wide as 12-18 kilometres.
- d. *River Titas*. Was mostly in Brahmanbaria Sub-sector. Flowed west of Chandura and Brahmanbaria before making a loop around Ujanisar. From there it again went north-west, touched Gokarna only to move south joining River Meghna near Nabinagar.

165. Important Towns

- a. The main towns and communication centres in this sector were Sylhet, Maulvi Bazar, Brahmanbaria. There were other smaller but important towns such as Fenchuganj, Shamsdernagar and Akhaura.
- b. Sylhet, located on the northern bank of the Surma, was the district headquarters and an important communication centre. It was connected by rail with Kulaura via Fenchuganj in the south. It was also a junction for roads from Jaintiapur, Charkai, Fenchuganj and Maulvi Bazar. It had an all-weather airfield.
- c. Maulvi Bazar was an important communication centre which controlled the road movement from Sadipur and Sherpur ferries south of Sylhet as any such movement from Sylhet to Comilla and Dacca was possible only over the ferries.
- d. Brahmanbaria was an important communication centre, located on the western bank of River Titas. The railway line from Akhaura to Dacca as well as the main road from Comilla to Ashuganj passed through Brahmanbaria. It was also linked to Ajabpur by motorable tracks.
- e. Fenchuganj was an important township on the southern bank of the Kusyara. The railway from Kulaura to Sylhet passed through Fenchuganj, which had no proper road link with Kulaura.
- f. Kulaura was an important town near the border. It was important for controlling movement towards Fenchuganj and Maulvi Bazar from east.
- g. Shamsdernagar had an all-weather airfield and was connected with Sylhet and Comilla by a motorable road.

166. Communication Infrastructure

- a. There were very few all-weather roads in North-eastern Sector. Most of them were on high embankments generally 1-2 meters high

according to the level of inundation in the rainy season. The roads were mostly fit for only one-way traffic. Water channels mostly were without bridges. The main road communication ran from north to south as already indicated above.

b. Important roads in the Sylhet Sub-sector:-

- (1) *Shillong – Cherrapunji or Jaintiapur – Sylhet*. It was a circular connection. The western portion of it was not well developed for military build-up.
- (2) *Karimganj – Sylhet*. A gravelled road that ran from east to west via Charkai. It passed through extensive marshy areas. Road west of Charkai was double-laned.
- (3) *Dharmanagar – Kulaura – Fenchuganj – Sylhet*. A track linked Kulaura with Dharmanagar via Ghazipur; it could take limited traffic. Another track ran from Kulaura to Brahman Bazar and from there to Sylhet via Fenchuganj; it was mostly disused. Brahman Bazar was linked with Maulvi Bazar and Shamsdernagar by road.
- (4) *Kailashahar – Shamsdernagar – Maulvi Bazar – Sylhet*. It was metalled one way road from Shamsdernagar to Sylhet.

c. Important roads in the Bhairab Bazar Sub-sector:-

- (1) *Agartala – Akhaura – Brahmanbaria – Ashuganj – Bhairab Bazar*. Was a fair-weather track which ran parallel to the railway line. Ashuganj Bridge was not decked for vehicular traffic. Beyond Bhairab Bazar, the railway line was connected with Narsingdi, but there was no road to that place.
- (2) *Comilla – Kasba – Brahmanbaria – Charlapur*. Moved west of Akhaura and crossed the River Titas at Ujanisar. The railway from Akhaura to Brahmanbaria crossed the Titas over a bridge not decked for vehicular traffic.

d. The railway line from Chittagong to Sylhet ran along the international boundary up to Kulaura, from where it branched off to Sylhet, while the main line ran parallel to the border up to Latu. A road also ran parallel to the railway line to Latu.

167. **Significance of the Sector**

- a. The presence of Pakistani forces in the Sylhet area, especially opposite Karimganj, posed a serious threat to the vital communications in the rear of 4 Corps, whose area of operations lay farther south in the Agartala area.
- b. There were many obstacles to an advance to Sylhet from Jaintiapur and Karimganj side. Besides, this would be a longest approach to Dacca. But on the other side, Indian advance from the east automatically provided an added security to their sensitive and vital communications system in the Karimganj area.
- c. There were two approaches from the south from the Dharmanagar and Kailashahar areas, and both of them were farther from Sylhet. Any advance from this direction would facilitate the early capture of Maulvi Bazar and Sherpur ferry, which gave the added advantage of completely isolating the Sylhet garrison from the rest of the Pakistani forces in the Province.

Opposing Forces

168. **Pakistani Forces.** 14 Division was defending this area. Division headquarters was initially located at Dacca; in November it moved to Bhairab Bazar. It was commanded by Major General Qazi Abdul Majeed.³¹⁷ It consisted of following troops:-³¹⁸

- a. **27 Brigade (Brigadier Saadullah)**
 - (1) 12 FF.
 - (2) 33 Baloch.
 - (3) Four Chaffee tanks and one PT - 76.
 - (4) Platoon R&S of 34 Punjab.
 - (5) A mixture of guns from 4 (Lahore) Battery, 47 Battery and two mortars from 210 Mortar Battery.
- b. **313 Brigade (Brigadier Iftikhar Rana)**
 - (1) 22 Baloch.
 - (2) 30 FF.
 - (3) Wing FC less two companies.
 - (4) 210 Mortar Battery and three 105 Howitzers of 4 (Lahore) Battery.

³¹⁷ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 150.

³¹⁸ Ibid., 135-137.

c. **202 (Adhoc) Brigade (Brigadier Saleemullah)**

- (1) 31 Punjab.
- (2) 91 Mujahid Battalion.
- (3) Two companies of EPCAF.
- (4) 500 Razakars.
- (5) Two companies of 12 AK Rifles and elements of Khyber Rifles, Thal and Tochi Scouts.³¹⁹
- (6) 23 Battery (31 Field Regiment).

d. **Other Elements**

- (1) 8 Independent Armour Squadron.
- (2) 31 Field Regiment.
- (3) 53 Field Regiment.
- (4) 210 Mortar Battery.

169. **Indian Forces**

a. **8 Mountain Division**³²⁰

- (1) 59 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) 81 Mountain Brigade.
- (3) Echo Sector.
- (4) East Bengal Brigade.

b. **57 Mountain Division**³²¹

- (1) 73 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) 311 Mountain Brigade.

Opposing Plans

170. **Pakistani Plans**

- a. 14 Division was tasked to deny Sylhet and Bhairab Bazar at all cost. To accomplish this mission, the division deployed whole of its brigades in a forward posture with all five battalions placed side by side along the border. It had no depth in Brahmanbaria Sub-sector which was shortest route to Dacca.³²²

³¹⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 179.

³²⁰ Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 184.

³²¹ 61 Mountain Brigade of this Division was to initially operate under 4 Corps. Ibid.

³²² Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 400.

- b. Division was also instructed to keep one battalion of 313 Brigade in area Maulvi Bazar for offensive role against Agartala, Headquarters of Indian 4 Corps.³²³
- c. Brigades were deployed as under:-
 - (1) *202-A Brigade*³²⁴
 - (a) *Riaz Force*. Was guarding Jaintiapur – Sylhet Axis with 31 Punjab less a company.
 - (b) *Akram Force*. Was guarding Atgram – Sylhet Axis with following troops: Company Khyber Rifles; Company Bajaur Rifles; and Company EPCAF.
 - (c) *Brigade Reserves*. Comprising a company of Khyber Rifles and two companies of EPCAF.
 - (d) Had a battery of 31 Field Regiment.
 - (2) *313 Brigade*³²⁵
 - (a) 22 Baloch were responsible for Ghazipur and Kulaura area.
 - (b) 30 FF was deployed in Shamsbernagar and Maulvi Bazar area.
 - (c) Mujahids were holding Fenchuganj and Sherpur ferries.
 - (3) *27 Brigade*³²⁶
 - (a) 12 FF and two companies of EPCAF with a troop of tank were deployed in Akhaura and Gangasagar area.
 - (b) 33 Baloch with one company of EPCAF was deployed south of Gangasagar in general area Kasba.
 - (c) 98 Mujahid Battalion with one company of 21 AK and elements of paramilitary forces were holding area north of Akhaura.
- d. 14 Division tactical headquarters was at Ashuganj. The inter-divisional boundary between 14 and 39 Divisions was along the Nalda Nadi, which ran north of Comilla.³²⁷

³²³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 427.

³²⁴ Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 153-54.

³²⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 179.

³²⁶ *Ibid*, 196-97.

³²⁷ *Ibid.*, 195.

171. Indian Plans

- a. The Indians had appreciated that 14 Division was likely to guard the approaches east and north of Sylhet in strength and the best chance of success was to advance along the unexpected southern direction. An advance towards Maulvi Bazar and its capture would give the added advantage of splitting the 14 Division into two. The intention was to prevent the two brigades in Sylhet area from withdrawing toward Bhairab Bazar to link up with their division so that the enemy forces could be defeated in detail.³²⁸
- b. The tasks allotted to 8 Mountain Division were:-³²⁹
 - (1) Advance along the Maulvi Bazar and Fenchuganj axes with a brigade each: 59 Mountain Brigade to capture Kulaura opposite Dharmanagar and then advance to Sylhet via Fenchuganj; whereas, 81 Mountain Brigade to capture Shamsdernagar and advance to Sylhet via Maulvi Bazar.
 - (2) Echo Sector, under Brigadier Wadke, was ordered to advance along the Jaintiapur Axis to Sylhet.
 - (3) While the BSF and the EBR were instructed to contain the enemy in Charkai area.³³⁰
 - (4) 14 Division was to be deceived about effort's main point of application by giving the impression to the defenders that the operations along Dharmanagar and Kailashahar axes were only subsidiary while the major forces were poised to advance along the Jaintiapur and Charkai Axes.³³¹

³²⁸ Singh *Victory in Bangladesh*, 179.

³²⁹ *Ibid.*, 179-180.

³³⁰ *Ibid.*, 180.

³³¹ *Deception Measures* (*Ibid.*)

(1) The concentration and administrative build-up of 8 Mountain Division in the Dharmanagar – Kailashahar area was dovetailed into an overall deception plan. Considerable activity was shown in Karimganj to confirm this impression.

(2) The advance of 81 Brigade from Kailashahar involved crossing the Manu near the border on the Indian side. The river was 250 feet wide and had no bridge over it. To achieve surprise it was decided to get the Public Works Department to build a bridge to show routine civil development unrelated to army requirements. In addition, only a class 9 bridge was constructed to show it was meant for normal civilian traffic and not heavy military transport. Medium guns were moved after dismantling them. These were subsequently assembled across the river and moved forward to support operations toward Maulvi Bazar.

c. Tasks allotted to 57 Mountain Division were:-³³²

- (1) 311 Mountain Brigade was to advance along Agartala – Akhaura Axis and made a lodgement across the Titas and west of the Akhaura railway bridge. This lodgement was intended to threaten the rear of our 27 Brigade defences as well as its guns, which were supporting the troops in Akhaura area. It was also hoped to block our movement along the Kasba – Brahmanbaria road.
- (2) 73 Mountain Brigade was to advance along Agartala – Gangasagar Axis to capture Gangasagar and then to threaten Akhaura from the south. 73 Mountain Brigade planned the operation in two phases. A battalion of this brigade was also ordered to establish a road block at Kasba – Gangasagar to protect the left flank of Brigade.
- (3) Sierra Force (an adhoc force consisting of one infantry battalion, 2 EBR and Mukti Bahinis) was ordered to dominate the Singarbil jetty and capture Rajapur, located south of it. The force was ordered to simulate a major attack on Akhaura in conjunction with the operations from the south.
- (4) Akhaura was to be captured subsequently by using both brigades attacking from the south.

Conduct/ Battle Accounts

172. Sylhet Sub-sector (313 & 202 Brigades)/ Map – 12

- a. There were many border skirmishes, particularly along the rail track in the area of Karimganj in the last week of November.³³³ On 19 November, Indian regular troops advanced on Mohammadpur and Salda Nadi BOPs and overran them. Then on 21 November, the enemy invaded Atgram and Zakiganj BOPs in Sylhet area. Both these positions were also lost³³⁴ and our troops fell back to Charkai.^{335, 336}

³³² Singh *Victory in Bangladesh*, 198.

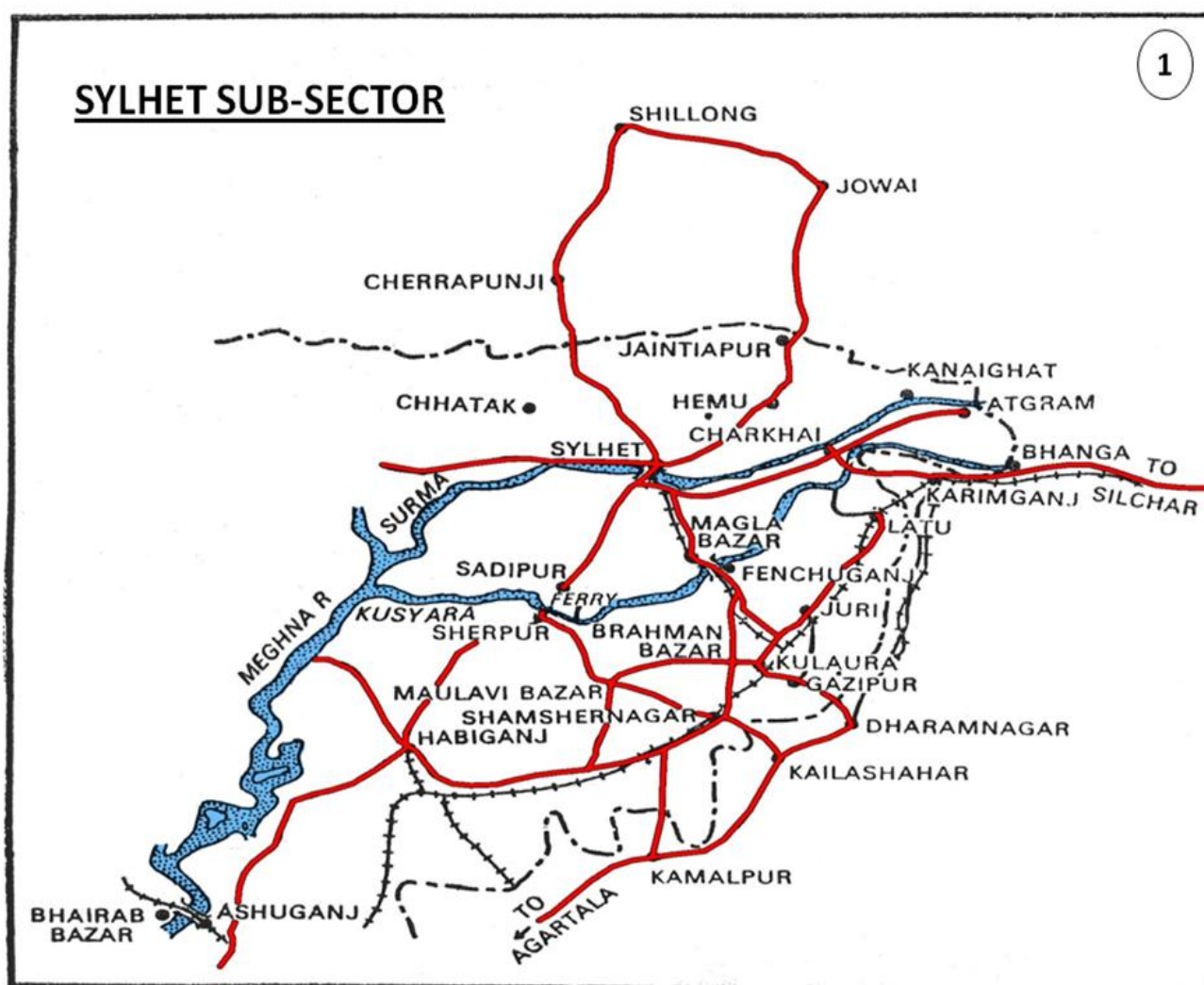
³³³ Ibid., 181.

³³⁴ 31 Punjab did launch a counter attack and threw the enemy back one-and-half miles but could not recapture Atgram. *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 444.

³³⁵ Ibid., 427.

³³⁶ Charkai was reinforced by one company of 12 AK and it managed to hold on there till 11th December; it then fell back to Sylhet, reaching there by 12 December. Ibid., 444.

- b. 81 Mountain Brigade undertook operations from Kailashahar towards Shamsdernagar.³³⁷



MAP – 12

- c. To cut off 30 FF routes of withdrawal, 81 Mountain Brigade ordered one company of 4 Kumaon to establish a roadblock on the Shamsdernagar – Maulvi Bazar road. Indians' move toward the rear was observed by us, so 30 FF engaged the Indian company with artillery and intense small arms fire and counter-attacked before it had time to dig in. The Indians withdrew after suffering casualties.³³⁸ The enemy attacked again and after an overnight struggle, 4 Kumaon with

³³⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 181.

³³⁸ *Ibid.*, 182.

two companies of 3 Punjab, cleared Shamshernagar by midday 2 December.³³⁹

- d. As the enemy moved ahead, it came across a screen position occupied by one company of 30 FF³⁴⁰ with some EPCAF at Munshi Bazar, ahead of Maulvi Bazar. The Indian 3 Punjab of 81 Mountain Brigade attacked Munshi Bazar at first light on 5 December. The position contested the Indian advance, but these positions finally fell to the Indians by last light on 6 December.³⁴¹
- e. On 5th December, 14 Division ordered the 313 Brigade to pull out of Maulvi Bazar and Kulaura and take up defences along River Kusyara at Sherpur ferry and Fenchuganj on the southern approaches to Sylhet.³⁴²
- f. 10 Mahar resumed its advance to Maulvi Bazar on night of 6 December and established a firm base a few kilometres east of this town, located on the southern bank of the Manu on high, broken ground. 30 FF was well dug-in at Maulvi Bazar with some additional troops.³⁴³
- g. After capturing Munshi Bazar, 8 Mountain Division ordered 81 Mountain Brigade to get de-inducted for subsequent employment in Brahmanbaria Sub-sector, where 4 Corps wanted to reinforce 57 Mountain Division's dash toward Ashuganj. But, 81 Mountain Brigade emphasised and explained the importance of advancing toward Maulvi Bazar – its capture would isolate the Pakistanis in Sylhet from the rest of their forces. Consequently, the advance of 59 Mountain Brigade toward Fenchuganj was halted and the BSF was ordered to take over the operational responsibility of the area from 59 Mountain Brigade.³⁴⁴
- h. On the other side, 81 Mountain Brigade had already established contact with the Maulvi Bazar defences on 7 December, and since then their

³³⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 181.

³⁴⁰ It also had a platoon of 22 Baloch and 2 x 120 mm Mortars of 210 Mortar Battery. Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 155.

³⁴¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 184.

³⁴² Ibid.

³⁴³ Ibid.

³⁴⁴ Ibid., 185.

advance had been held up.³⁴⁵ The bitter experience of Munshi Bazar had taught the Indians the efficacy of softening up their target, through air and artillery, before attack. On 8 December, before assault, the Indians plastered our defences with intense artillery and air raids. One of Indian artillery shell hit our ammunition dump, blowing it up in a huge explosion. The noise befuddled own troops who left the defence in confusion. 81 Mountain Brigade occupied the vacated Maulvi Bazar the same day.³⁴⁶

- i. 313 Brigade left Maulvi Bazar on 8 December and reached Sylhet on 12 December.³⁴⁷ They had left behind large stocks of ammunition, POL and supplies.³⁴⁸
- j. On 13 December, 81 Mountain Brigade resumed its advance toward Sylhet, but was held up about three kilometres from the town, at 1400 hours on 13 December. By the evening of 13 December, 3 Punjab managed to overcome the delaying position and linked up with the 59 Mountain Brigade's unit which had been moved cross-country from Magla Bazar to join them. On the night of 13/14 December both leading battalions continued to probe toward Sylhet railway station on the southern bank of the Surma. The leading troops captured the railway station without much resistance as our troops had withdrawn under pressure.³⁴⁹
- k. 59 Mountain Brigade, was also active opposite the Kulaura area since 29 November. After some positions across the border had been cleared, 6 Rajput contacted the Pakistanis in the Ghazipur, a tea garden area, on 3 December and attacked them at night from the north. Despite a lot of efforts, Indians could not secure the objective. At this stage, the brigade ordered 4/5 Gorkha Rifles (GR) to capture Ghazipur, which was held by a mixed company of 22 Baloch, Tochi Scouts and EPCAF.³⁵⁰ 4/5 GR launched a silent attack without artillery support after last light on 4 December to surprise our troops, and

³⁴⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 190.

³⁴⁶ Ibid., 190-91.

³⁴⁷ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 445.

³⁴⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 191.

³⁴⁹ Ibid., 191.

³⁵⁰ Ibid., 182.

finally captured the position by midday on 5 December after bitter fighting.³⁵¹

- l. After the capture of Ghazipur, 4/5 GR advanced toward Kulaura and occupied it before midday on 6 December without opposition. Own troops had vacated it in confusion.³⁵²
- m. After the capture of Kulaura, 6 Rajput commenced advance to Brahman Bazar on 6 December and occupied it without opposition. After some skirmishes enroute it pressed on toward Fenchuganj on 7 December. Our opposition along this axis was weak, especially as 22 Baloch was in no fit state to offer serious resistance.³⁵³
- n. Meanwhile 4 Corps stopped operations of 59 Mountain Brigade to Fenchuganj and ordered it to move to Kailashahar for subsequent employment in Brahmanbaria Sub-sector.
- o. On the morning of 7 December, 4 Corps shared intelligence with 8 Mountain Division that there were indications that the 202-A and 313 Brigades were withdrawing from Sylhet town and the Maulvi Bazar area to link up with their forces in the Ashuganj area. Most troops of our 202-A Brigade were spread out along the border north and east of Sylhet. Sylhet itself was reported to have few troops at this stage.³⁵⁴
- p. The Indians felt the situation was ripe for exploitation before we could recover and decide to hold Sylhet town in strength. It was proposed to heli-lift a battalion as near to Sylhet as possible to capture this important town before we could move sufficient forces to defend it.³⁵⁵ Such an operation would also facilitate the advance of Echo Sector force along the Jaintiapur Axis for an early linkup with the heli-lifted force. It was appreciated that the linkup would be possible within 48 hours.³⁵⁶
- q. 8 Mountain Division decided to employ 4/5 GR of 59 Mountain Brigade.³⁵⁷ Mirapara, nearly two kilometres from railway bridge at

³⁵¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 182.

³⁵² Ibid., 183.

³⁵³ Ibid., 184.

³⁵⁴ Ibid., 185.

³⁵⁵ Ibid., 185-6.

³⁵⁶ Ibid., 186.

³⁵⁷ Ibid.

Sylhet, was selected as the landing site. Nine MI-4s were made available for the lift.³⁵⁸ The lift started at 1400 hours on 7 December.³⁵⁹

- r. Brigadier Salimullah, Commander 202-A Brigade saw the helicopters approaching Sylhet. He collected an adhoc force of regulars, Scouts and paramilitary forces in a hurry and ordered them to engage the helicopters with small arms fire from close range to check a smooth and uninterrupted build-up.
- s. Nevertheless, by last light 9 December, the Indians were able to heli-lift 4/5 GR, a platoon of Guards, with mountain guns and an ACT tentacle for close air support in Mirapara.³⁶⁰
- t. When the decision to heli-lift 4/5 GR was taken it was anticipated that Echo Sector would be able to link up with it from the Jaintiapur Axis within 48 hours.³⁶¹ The Indians advance along Jaintiapur Axis, however, was very slow due to strong resistance by 31 Punjab.
- u. Overall by 9 December, 81 Mountain Brigade had cleared Maulvi Bazar and 59 Mountain Brigade less 4/5 GR was still at Kailashahar. Echo Sector troops were edging forward slowly around Hemu and 4/5 GR base was under harassment from 202-A Brigade. On the 10 December morning 8 Mountain Division proposed to the Corps Headquarters that 59 Mountain Brigade should advance on the Fenchuganj Axis to Sylhet to effect an early link up with 4/5 GR.³⁶² The Division felt that 81 Mountain Brigade or Echo Sector column would not be able to reach Sylhet speedily. 4 Corps agreed, and 59 Mountain Brigade was ordered to advance to Sylhet via Fenchuganj to effect an early linkup with 4/5 GR.³⁶³
- v. 59 Mountain Brigade, which was at Kailashahar, started their move in MT at 1000 hours on 10 December and proceeded on foot beyond Brahman Bazar. They secured the southern bank of the railway bridge

³⁵⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 186.

³⁵⁹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 445.

³⁶⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 186-87.

³⁶¹ *Ibid.*, 188.

³⁶² *Ibid.*

³⁶³ *Ibid.*, 189.

at Fenchuganj by first light of 11 December. Own troops pulled out to the northern bank of the Kussyara without blowing up the bridge.³⁶⁴

- w. The same day, 59 Mountain Brigade crossed over River Kussyara, it cleared Magla Bazar without much opposition and linked up with 81 Mountain Brigade, which was advancing along Maulvi Bazar Axis, on 13 December. Own troops were pushed onto the northern bank of River Surma and into Sylhet town. The same day these Indian troops also finally linked up with the beleaguered 4/5 GR.
- x. While these operations were proceeding 4 Corps issued orders on 13 December for immediate transfer of a mountain brigade group to Agartala to act as corps reserve for operations around Dacca.³⁶⁵
- y. 8 Division decided then to move 81 Mountain Brigade less 3 Punjab to Agartala and 3 Punjab was placed under 59 Mountain Brigade, which continued operations for the capture of Sylhet from 13 December. As Echo Sector troops approached Sylhet they were also placed under the command of 59 Mountain Brigade to ensure better coordination.³⁶⁶
- z. Sylhet was closely surrounded by the Indian troops from all directions by 14 December. Yet they failed to capture it till formal ceasefire was announced on 16 December. 107 officers, including three brigadiers and about 6,500 soldiers surrendered to General Krishna Rao at 1500 hours on 17 December.³⁶⁷

173. Brahmanbaria Sub-sector (27 Brigade)/ Map – 11

- a. Akhaura was held with two companies of 12 FF, and two other companies of this battalion were deployed farther south in the Gangasagar area. In addition, a number of paramilitary companies were deployed to cover the approaches to Akhaura from the north, south and east. 14 Division had anticipated an attack on Akhaura from the north for following reasons:-
 - (1) Would provide early security to Agartala airfield.

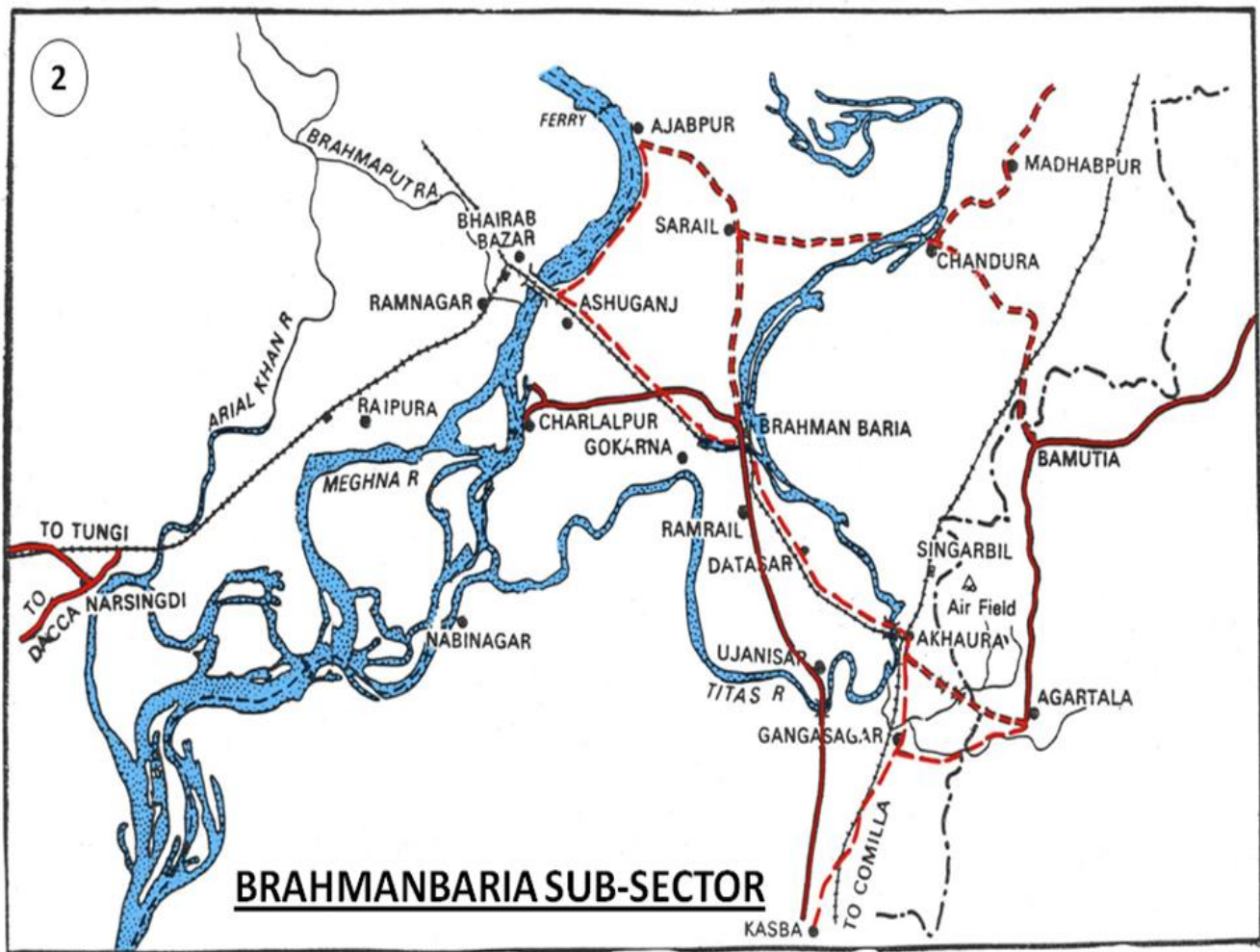
³⁶⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 189.

³⁶⁵ Ibid., 192.

³⁶⁶ Ibid., 193.

³⁶⁷ Ibid.

- (2) Such an approach would also take the Indians to Singarbil ferry from where the rear of the Pakistani defences in Akhaura and Kasba area could be threatened.
- (3) It would also enable the Indians to cut the rail and road communications in the Titas loop west of Akhaura, thus posing a threat to Brahmanbaria before Pakistani troops in Akhaura – Kasba could fall back.
- b. Consequently, defences against approaches from north and east were further strengthened by developing an anti-tank-ditch here.³⁶⁸ Akhaura had thus been developed into a formidable fortress.³⁶⁹



MAP – 13

³⁶⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 197.

³⁶⁹ *Ibid.*, 197.

- c. At 1800 hours on 1 December, 10 Bihar of 311 Mountain Brigade started its advance towards Akhaura. At the same time, 14 Guards of 73 Mountain Brigade moved cross-country and secured area a kilometre south of Gangasagar. 2 EBR of Sierra Force secured the area of the Singarbil jetty and captured Rajapur, located south of it.
- d. Early in the morning of 3 December, 14 Guards of 73 Mountain Division attacked Gangasagar and finally cleared after nearly three hours of close fighting and conspicuous gallantry by both sides.³⁷⁰ After the capture of Gangasagar, 311 Mountain Brigade linked up with 73 Brigade successfully and the stage was set for the final capture of Akhaura.³⁷¹
- e. Own forces resisted fiercely and attacked the Indian position at Gangasagar in the afternoon from the air. PAF attacks did not inflict any casualties even though most of Indians tanks were bogged down in open fields and exposed.³⁷²
- f. On 3 December, 57 Mountain Division, decided to capture Akhaura with only 311 Mountain Brigade. Sierra Force was also placed under the brigade for the final attack. While these operations were progressing, 73 Mountain Brigade was ordered to establish a roadblock north of Kasba to cut the main road between Brahmanbaria and Kasba. 311 Brigade planned a feint attack from the north to give the impression to our troops that the major attack on Akhaura was coming from that direction.³⁷³
- g. Eventually, 57 Mountain Division launched a night attack with 311 Mountain Brigade on 4 December capturing Akhaura by 0800 hours on 5 December.³⁷⁴ 12 FF fell back to Brahmanbaria the same day.³⁷⁵
- h. After capturing Akhaura, it was revealed to Indians as a pleasant surprise that 12 FF had lifted one of the two railway tracks from Akhaura to Brahmanbaria and were using the railway embankment for the movement of vehicles in addition to using the remaining track

³⁷⁰ The only award of Param Vir Chakra (the highest gallantry award) in the Eastern Theatre was won posthumously by Lance Naik Albert Ekka of 14 Guards in this battle. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 200.

³⁷¹ Ibid.

³⁷² Ibid., 199.

³⁷³ Ibid., 200.

³⁷⁴ Ibid.

³⁷⁵ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 401.

for rail traffic. This was an important discovery as it offered a good approach for vehicles from Akhaura to Brahmanbaria and Ashuganj.³⁷⁶

- i. As a result of the battle of Akhaura, 57 Mountain Division assessed that our determination and fighting capability was not as great as believed earlier. Akhaura was the key to our defences in this sector, and yet we had not reacted strongly to its capture. 33 Baloch, a neighbouring battalion, at Kasba had been only a spectator and had withdrawn toward Brahmanbaria and Ashuganj rather than reinforce Akhaura or counter-attack or divert the Indians troops from the main battle. They hardly made any effort to interfere with the Indians' battle plans and had resorted to static defence, thus accepting defeat in detail.³⁷⁷
- j. The Indians appreciated the god-sent advantage which the unexpected availability of the road along the railway embankment offered them. Consequently, 57 Mountain Brigade revised its original plan of capturing Daudkandi (Comilla Sub-sector) and redirected its efforts toward Brahmanbaria. The general aim at this stage was to secure the eastern bank of the Meghna and the capture of Ashuganj. The railway embankment provided the shortest and quickest way to reaching the river line.³⁷⁸ Thus was set, the first vital spark which subsequently led to crossing the Meghna and ultimately the march to Dacca.³⁷⁹
- k. On 5 December, 311 Mountain Brigade was ordered to exploit toward Brahmanbaria. 18 Rajputs advanced along the railway line and secured Datasar about six kilometres west of Akhaura, by last light on 5 December while 4 Guards established a road block northwest of Ujanisar along the main road.³⁸⁰

³⁷⁶ The only bridge across the Meghna was at Ashuganj, and even though it was not decked for road traffic this route provided the shortest approach to crossing the Meghna from the east and for an advance to Dacca. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 201.

³⁷⁷ Ibid.

³⁷⁸ Ibid.

³⁷⁹ Ibid., 202.

³⁸⁰ Ibid.

- l. A track ran north of the Akhaura – Ashuganj railway connecting Bamutia with Chandura, Sarail and the Ajabpur ferry. Sarail was also connected with Brahmanbaria by a track. 57 Mountain Division ordered the Sierra Force to advance along the northern approach and press forward to Ajabpur ferry so as to threaten Brahmanbaria or Ashuganj from the northern flank.³⁸¹
- m. 73 Mountain Brigade commenced advance to Brahmanbaria on manpack basis on 6 December along the road and railway line with two battalions up. It contacted our screen position at Bahadurgarh about 4 kilometres short of Brahmanbaria by last light 6 December. The Brigade continued to exert pressure and reached the eastern bank of the Titas River by midday of 7 December.³⁸²
- n. As the bridge over the Titas at Akhaura had not been decked for vehicular traffic; the build-up of troops west of the river in the Akhaura area was slow. The road from Kasba to Brahmanbaria was also not opened at this stage.³⁸³
- o. 27 Brigade had reasonably strong defences in the narrow loop of the Titas based on Brahmanbaria. The bridge on the Titas near Brahmanbaria was damaged by 12 FF withdrawing troops.³⁸⁴
- p. Appreciating the strength and nature of obstacles around Brahmanbaria, 57 Mountain Division decided on 6 December to reinforce the outflanking move from the north so that it could threaten Brahmanbaria and the Ashuganj Bridge from the rear and flank to capture the bridge intact if possible. He ordered 10 Bihar from 311 Mountain Brigade to join Sierra Force at Chandura so that the enveloping force via Sarail to Ashuganj could be adequately strengthened. At this stage the advance was led by 73 Mountain Brigade, and 311 Mountain Brigade was moving up gradually behind.³⁸⁵
- q. 27 Brigade abandoned their defences at Brahmanbaria on 7/8 December.³⁸⁶ General Niazi, later on, bitterly complained that he was

³⁸¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 202.

³⁸² Ibid., 202-3.

³⁸³ Ibid., 203.

³⁸⁴ Ibid.

³⁸⁵ Ibid.

³⁸⁶ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 442.

badly let down by the divisional commander of 14 Division who abandoned Brahmanbaria, an almost impregnable fortress without a fight.³⁸⁷ On 8 December, 73 Mountain Brigade crossed the river and occupied Brahmanbaria. From there on, 311 Mountain Brigade led the advance. The intention was to press on and reach Meghna in order to capture Ashuganj Bridge intact if possible, before our retreating elements could reorganise.³⁸⁸

- r. At Ashuganj, a large number of 27 Brigade troops were waiting to cross to the western bank of Meghna. There was a requirement to secure the ferry site to permit the troops and equipment to be crossed safely, besides putting the crossing on demolition.³⁸⁹ To ensure this, the brigade deployed strong forces to protect the bridge at Ashuganj to ensure that it did not fall to Indian advancing troops intact.
- s. 18 Rajputs of 311 Mountain Brigade moved into the outskirts of Ashuganj without any expectation of serious resistance. They were surprised when our troops opened up with heavy machine guns, mortars and artillery. Hell broke loose in a matter of seconds and 18 Rajputs were counter-attacked by the “troops of 33 Baloch”³⁹⁰ under the personal command of Brigadier Saadullah.³⁹¹ The sudden attack surprised the Indians, some of whom panicked and ran helter skelter. 311 Mountain Brigade lost seven tanks and 120 men in this sudden and sharp encounter.³⁹²
- t. At this stage, 73 Mountain Brigade was directed to sort out the situation at Ashuganj and also to cross the Meghna by mobilising local resources. During the night of 9/10 December, Pakistani troops crossed over to Bhairab Bazar in local rivercraft. 18 Rajputs captured Ashuganj on 10 December without opposition.³⁹³

³⁸⁷ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 445. The divisional commander ascribes this failure to fulfill his mission to the defensive planning of the Eastern Command itself. According to him, bifurcation of area of his divisional responsibility, as late as 19th November 1971, was in fact a folly. The area should have been left with him as it was. If necessary, the 53 Brigade could have been placed under his command and he could then have planned for an effective brigade battle at Ashuganj and not at Brahmanbaria. Ibid.

³⁸⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 204.

³⁸⁹ Ibid., 206.

³⁹⁰ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 153.

³⁹¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 205.

³⁹² *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 442.

³⁹³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 206.

- u. Chandpur and Daudkandi also fell this day (9 December), thus revealing the total collapse of our troops in the eastern sectors.³⁹⁴
- v. The Indians knew that our troops in Bhairab Bazar area were not in a state to undertake major coordinated operations against them. They had seen our troops abandon the river ports at Chandpur and Daudkandi. Taking stock of the situation, the Indians decided to act boldly and heli-lift their troops across the Meghna³⁹⁵ as crossing the Meghna was inescapable to achieve a decisive victory.
- w. The Indians planned to contain our troops in Bhairab Bazar and effect crossing farther south, where no opposition was expected. There was no road from Bhairab Bazar to Raipura and Narsingdi, so it was difficult for the troops of 27 Brigade to react in strength or in time against Indian troops once they were landing in that area.³⁹⁶
- x. In consultation with 311 Mountain Brigade, 57 Mountain Division selected an area for landing a few kilometres northeast of Narsingdi and southwest of Raipura. The site was outside the range of our artillery in the Bhairab Bazar area.³⁹⁷
- y. 311 Mountain Brigade was instructed to secure the Raipura area by heliborne landing. After landing, this force had to advance along the rail axis and capture Narsingdi roadhead and the riverport.³⁹⁸ Whereas, 73 Mountain Brigade decided to contain Bhairab Bazar with 19 Punjab from the south and southeast. The rest of the brigade was ordered to cross by boats and build-up in the Narsingdi area. Sierra Force was ordered to place 11 EBR under 73 Mountain Brigade, while the rest of the force was ordered to cross the river to Narsingdi.³⁹⁹
- z. There was no road between Ashuganj and Dacca and it was assessed by the Indians that their logistics for support of operations to Dacca would have to be along the Meghna. They had planned to concentrate a strong composite force at Narsingdi for the eventual advance to Dacca, while

³⁹⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 206-207.

³⁹⁵ Ibid., 207.

³⁹⁶ Ibid.

³⁹⁷ Ibid., 208.

³⁹⁸ Ibid., 209.

³⁹⁹ Ibid., 209-210.

minimal essential forces were left at Bhairab Bazar to contain and isolate our troops there.⁴⁰⁰

- aa. On 9 December 4 Guards secured the area west of Raipura by evening. At the same time 73 Mountain Brigade had been ordered to secure the ferry site at Charlalpur, south of Ashuganj, on the night of 9/10 December.⁴⁰¹
- bb. 19 Punjab of 73 Mountain Brigade crossed Meghna in country boats on the night of 9 December and secured Ramnagar railway bridge over the Brahmaputra (local) by 0800 hours on 10 December. A troop of 59 Mountain Regiment was manhandled over a distance of 12 kilometers along with ammunition to the east bank of the Meghna to provide artillery support to 19 Punjab as the track to Charlalpur area was unfit for vehicles. 4 Guards advanced to Narsingdi in the morning of 10 December. The helilift went on till moonset and was resumed at first light of 10 December. 110 sorties were flown in 36 hours from Brahmanbaria stadium.⁴⁰²
- cc. By 11 December, 311 Mountain Brigade had by now two battalions across Meghna. 73 Brigade kept on ferrying troops across the river in country-boats at night and had two battalions west of Meghna by 12 December. Sierra Force had also started crossing on 11 December.⁴⁰³
- dd. By 0800 hours on 12 December 4 Guards captured the Narsingdi area by chasing out a platoon of EPCAF. Narsingdi area was secured as a base of operations against Dacca and the road from Narsingdi to Dacca lay open for a dash into the heart of East Pakistan at Dacca. The rail and road bridges across the Brahmaputra (local) west of Narsingdi were captured intact.⁴⁰⁴
- ee. While this all was happening 27 Brigade along with elements of division tactical headquarters chose to confine themselves to the static defence of Bhairab Bazar.⁴⁰⁵ The stage was set for the final collapse.

⁴⁰⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 210.

⁴⁰¹ Ibid.

⁴⁰² Ibid., 211.

⁴⁰³ Ibid.

⁴⁰⁴ Ibid., 212.

⁴⁰⁵ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 444.



MAP – 14

1. Comilla Sub-sector.
2. Feni Sub-sector.
3. Chittagong Sub-sector.

MID & SOUTH-EASTERN SECTOR

The Area of Operation⁴⁰⁶

174. General

- a. Mid & South-eastern Sector was a strange mix of hilly terrain, dense forests, protruding salients, tidal basins and flat open country. It was bounded in the north by Comilla⁴⁰⁷ and Daudkandi, east by the international border with India (75 kilometres stretch in Chittagong had a border with Burma), west by Meghna and south by the Bay of Bengal (Map – 12).
- b. Chittagong, a larger part of this sector, was connected with the mainland by a narrow neck of territory barely 16 kilometres around Feni. To the south were numerous inlets of water channels intertwined to form the combined delta of the Ganges and the Meghna.
- c. The Area of Operation, being a large landmass, could be divided into three sub-sectors: Comilla Sub-sector; Feni Sub-sector; and Chittagong Sub-sector. Indians developed their offensive only in Comilla Sub-sector, rest of the two sub-sectors saw minor/ insignificant war skirmishes and are therefore not discussed below in detail.

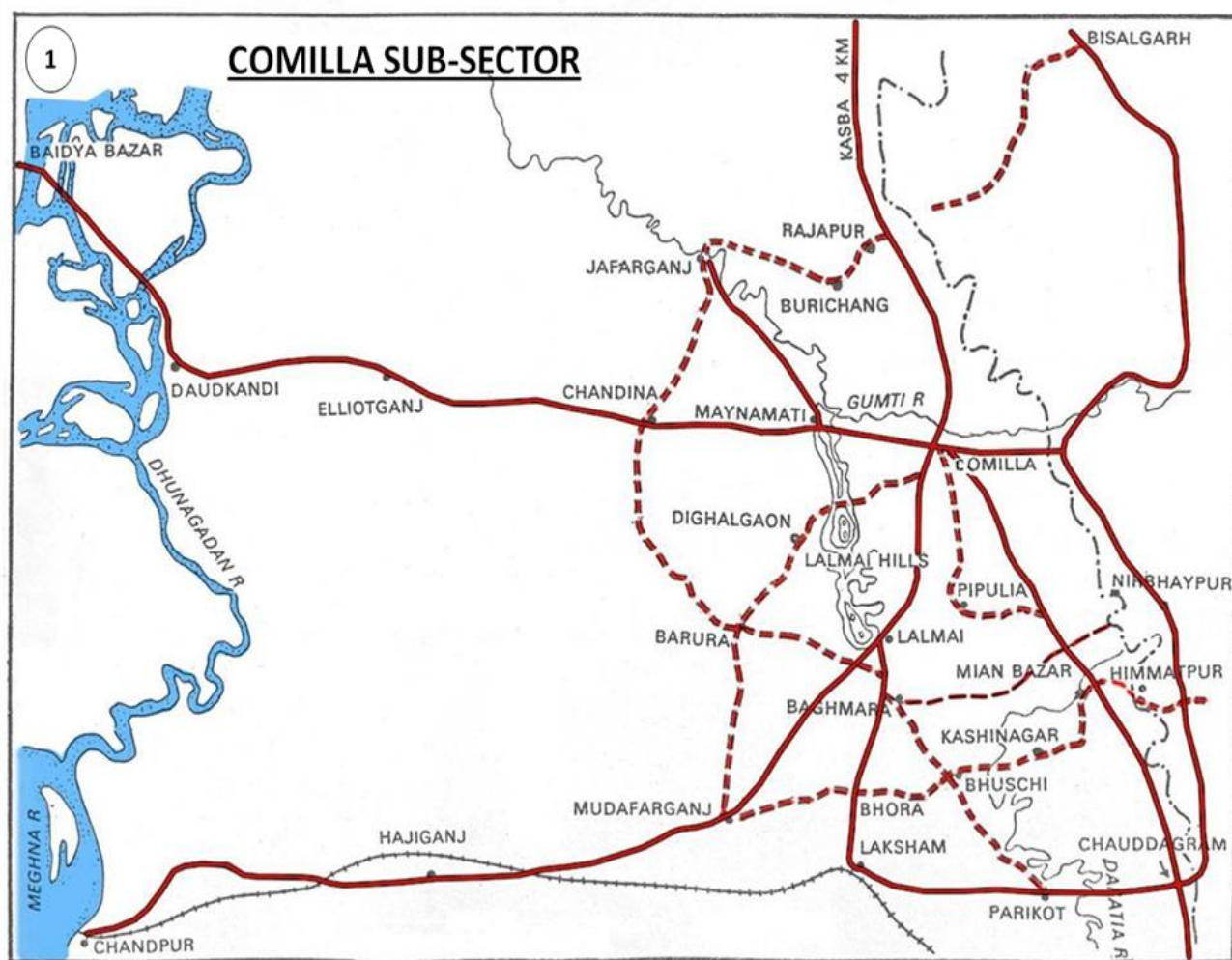
175. Comilla Sub-sector/ Map – 15

a. Rivers

- (1) Except Meghna, which skirted its boundaries from west, there was no major river in this sub-sector. It had a span of nearly 18 kilometres and was a formidable obstacle.
- (2) Salda Nadi was a small nullah that flowed down north of Jafarganj, Maynamati and Comilla before entering India.

⁴⁰⁶ Most of details about the Area of Operation have been taken from following books: (a) Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 7, 167-170 & 213-231; Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 21-23 & 407-411.

⁴⁰⁷ The actual divisional boundary of 39 (Adhoc) Division ran north of Comilla. Salda Nadi was inclusive to this Division. Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 404.

**MAP – 15**

b. Significant Towns

- (1) Comilla, Maynamati and Daudkandi (river port) were significant places in the northern half of this sub-sector. Besides these towns, Lalmai Hills dominated the northern part from Maynamati in the north to Lalmai Village in the south; it could block major approaches from the east to Daudkandi and Chandpur.
- (2) Laksham, Mudafarganj and Chandpur (river port) assumed importance during the 1971 War in the southern half of Comilla Sub-sector.

c. Communication Infrastructure

- (1) Main communication artery, Sylhet – Cattagong, ran through this sub-sector. Along this, Comilla and Laksham were two important

centre of communication from where a large number of roads and tracks ran north, west and south.

- (2) Comilla was connected with Daudkandi by an east-west road. It passed through a saddle near the northern tip of the Lalmai Hills in the Maynamati area. Towards east, this road was linked with Sonamura in India. A number of tracks converged on Comilla from the west, linking it with the lateral connecting Mudafarganj with Chandia via Barura. A track connected Chandina with Rajapur, near the border, via Jafarganj ferry but had a gap of a few kilometres from the Indian roadhead coming to the border from Bisalgarh (India).
- (3) Laksham was another important rail and road nodal point along the southern portion of this sub-sector. It was connected with the Indian Broder by a motorable track up to Chauddagran. It was linked with Noakhali in the south. There was no east-west road linking Laksham to Chandpur even though Laksham was linked with Chandpur by an east-west rail line. The Laksham – Chandpur road followed the alignment via Lalmai – Mudafarganj and then due west to Chandpur.

d. **Military Significance**

- (1) It provided the shortest route to the capital. Dacca being only 80 kilometres from the eastern border.
- (2) Comilla was an important army garrison town having an all-weather airfield.
- (3) Lalmai Village (closer to the southern tip of Lalmai Hills) assumed greater significance as all road/ tracks from Comilla, Laksham, Chandpur and Barura met there.
- (4) Likely approaches into this sub-sector were:-
 - (a) *Northern Approach*. It ran astride a track from Himmatpur on the Indian border to Kashinagar, from where it turned southwest to Bhuschi and then west to Bhora on the main road from Comilla to Laksham. This track crossed the Dakatia Nullah near Kashinagar. The track continued from Bhora to Mudafarganj. It could be improved for large-scale

vehicular traffic with engineer effort. Another track ran a few kilometres north and nearly parallel to it up to Baghmara.

- (b) *Southern Approach*. Moved along a motorable track ran from Radhanagar on the border to Chauddagam and Laksham. It crossed the Dakatia Nullah at Parikot over a bridge and was capable of large-scale vehicle movement.

176. **Feni Sub-sector**

- a. **Rivers**. Feni had one major river known as Feni River. It originated north of Comilla moved along the international border and dropped down in the Bay of Bengal. It was bridged having a span of 300 metres.
- b. **Significant Towns**. Feni was the only significant town besides Belonia which was a small village.
- c. **Communication Infrastructure**. Had number of dirt tracks connecting different villages.
- d. **Military Significance**
 - (1) Belonia Salient was surrounded on three sides by India and posed a serious problem for the defenders.
 - (2) The most vulnerable neck of land in East Pakistan was Feni which was only a stone's throw away from India. An advance of only a few kilometres could sever Chittagong Port and a large tract of East Pakistan, without any major effort, from the rest of the Province.

177. **Chittagong Sub-sector/ Map – 15**

- a. **Rivers**
 - (1) There were many small rivers running through, waterfalls and lakes.
 - (2) Karnapuli River was one major river. It originated from Kaptai Lake in northeastern Chittagong which fell south of Chittagong Port.
- b. **Significant Towns**. Chittagong, Cox's Bazar, Rangamati and Ramgarh were towns of significance; former two were the major sea ports.
- c. **Communication Infrastructure**
 - (1) Road Feni – Chittagong – Cox's Bazar was the main road. After Cox's Bazar, this road entered Burma. Eastward this road branched to Ramgarh, Rangamati and Bandarban.

- (2) Chittagong had a rail-link with the mainland.
- d. **Military Significance**
 - (1) The Chittagong Hill Tracts, in the east rising to heights of 650 meters, forested and mountainous, was ideal for guerrilla actions.
 - (2) The ports of Chittagong and Cox's Bazar were the main outlet for trade in East Pakistan.

Opposing Forces

178. **Pakistani Forces.** 39 (Adhoc) Division⁴⁰⁸ was defending this area. Division headquarters was established at Chandpur. It was commanded by Major General Rahim Khan.⁴⁰⁹ The division consisted of following troops:-⁴¹⁰

- a. **117 Brigade (Brigadier Atif)**
 - (1) 30 Punjab.
 - (2) 25 FF.
 - (3) 23 Punjab.
 - (4) The brigade had 13 guns of 53 Field Regiment for artillery support.
 - (5) Troop of old M-124 light tanks.⁴¹¹
- b. **53 Brigade (Brigadier Aslam Niazi)**
 - (1) 15 Baloch.
 - (2) 39 Baloch.
 - (3) 21 AK.⁴¹²
 - (4) Artillery support was provided by battery of 53 Field (5 x guns).
- c. **91 (Adhoc) Brigade (Brigadier Taskeen-ud-din)**
 - (1) Two companies of 24 FF.
 - (2) One wing of EPCAF.
 - (3) One wing of Rangers.
 - (4) One Mujahid Battalion.
 - (5) 171 Mortar Battery less a troop.

⁴⁰⁸ Raised on 18 October 1971. Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 155.

⁴⁰⁹ Ibid.

⁴¹⁰ Ibid., 156-57.

⁴¹¹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 200.

⁴¹² This battalion landed in Dacca in the middle of November. The battalion headquarters was moved to Karir Hat to act as a brigade headquarters for 91-A Brigade. Two companies were detached to 117 Brigade and one company was moved to Chandpur as Division Reserves. Only one company was with 53 Brigade. Riza, *The Pakistan Army*, 156.

d. **97 (Adhoc) Brigade (Brigadier Atta Malik)**

- (1) 48 Baloch.
- (2) 24 FF less two companies.
- (3) 2 Commandos less a company.
- (4) One wing EPCAF.
- (5) Marine battalion.
- (6) Troop of 171 Mortar Battery.

179. **Indian Forces**

a. **23 Mountain Division**

- (1) 301 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) 83 Mountain Brigade.
- (3) 181 Mountain Brigade.
- (4) 61 Mountain Brigade of 57 Division.

b. **Kilo Sector.**⁴¹³

Opposing Plans/ Map – 15 & 17

180. **Pakistani Plans**

- a. Troops allocated for the defence of these sub-sectors, as already indicated, were: 53 Brigade at Feni; 117 Brigade at Comilla, 91-A Brigade in the Chittagong Hill Tracts; and 97-A Brigade in Chittagong.
- b. The task given to this division was to: defend its area of responsibility; develop Comilla, Laksham, Feni, Chittagong, Daudkandi and Chandpur as fortresses and further to develop Ramgarh, Rangamati, Kaptai, Sitakund and Karir Hat as strong points. The main task, however, was obviously to deny the approaches to the enemy from Tripura to Meghna in order to deny the vital region of Dacca to the enemy from the east and to deny all the land approaches to Chittagong.⁴¹⁴
- c. After Major General Rahim took over as General Officer Commanding (GOC) of this division, he made certain re-grouping within the division itself by moving units from one place to another which had an adverse effect and materially affected their operational readiness. It is for this

⁴¹³ Details regarding its composition is not known. It is expected to comprise one regular battalion with East Bengal Regiment and Mukti Bahinis.

⁴¹⁴ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 446.

reason that these changes are being mentioned below for detailed analysis at a later stage:-⁴¹⁵

- (1) Moved 25 FF, which was originally a part of the 53 Brigade at Dacca to defend Lalmai Hills – Mian Bazar area under command 117 Brigade.
- (2) 15 Baloch, which had prepared the Comilla fortress defence, was moved to Feni under 53 Brigade. Similarly, 39 Baloch, which had prepared the defences at Laksham and Mudafarganj was also moved to Feni.
- (3) 23 Punjab was moved from Narayanganj to take up the defence of area Chauddagam – Laksham in place of 39 Baloch.
- (4) 91-A Brigade was split up into two parts, one deployed at Karir Hat under a new brigade commander and the second was given to 97-A Brigade with its headquarters at Chittagong.
- (5) 21 AK, immediately on arrival from west Pakistan on 25 November, was distributed by companies within 39-A Division. It would be recalled that the divisional headquarters was staffed by officers, personnel and equipment taken from Martial Law Headquarters, and were therefore themselves, a source of weakness in this all important sector.

d. *117 Brigade*

- (1) 30 Punjab was deployed in Comilla and Maynamati. Two companies of 25 FF were under its command defending the Lalmai Hills.
- (2) Mian Bazar and Kashinagar area was guarded by 25 FF less two companies.
- (3) 23 Punjab was defending Chauddagam – Laksham Axis.
- (4) Paramilitary forces were mixed with regulars to guard various approaches near the border and east of the Dakatia Nullah, especially in the central area east of Lalmai and Laksham.

e. *53 Brigade*

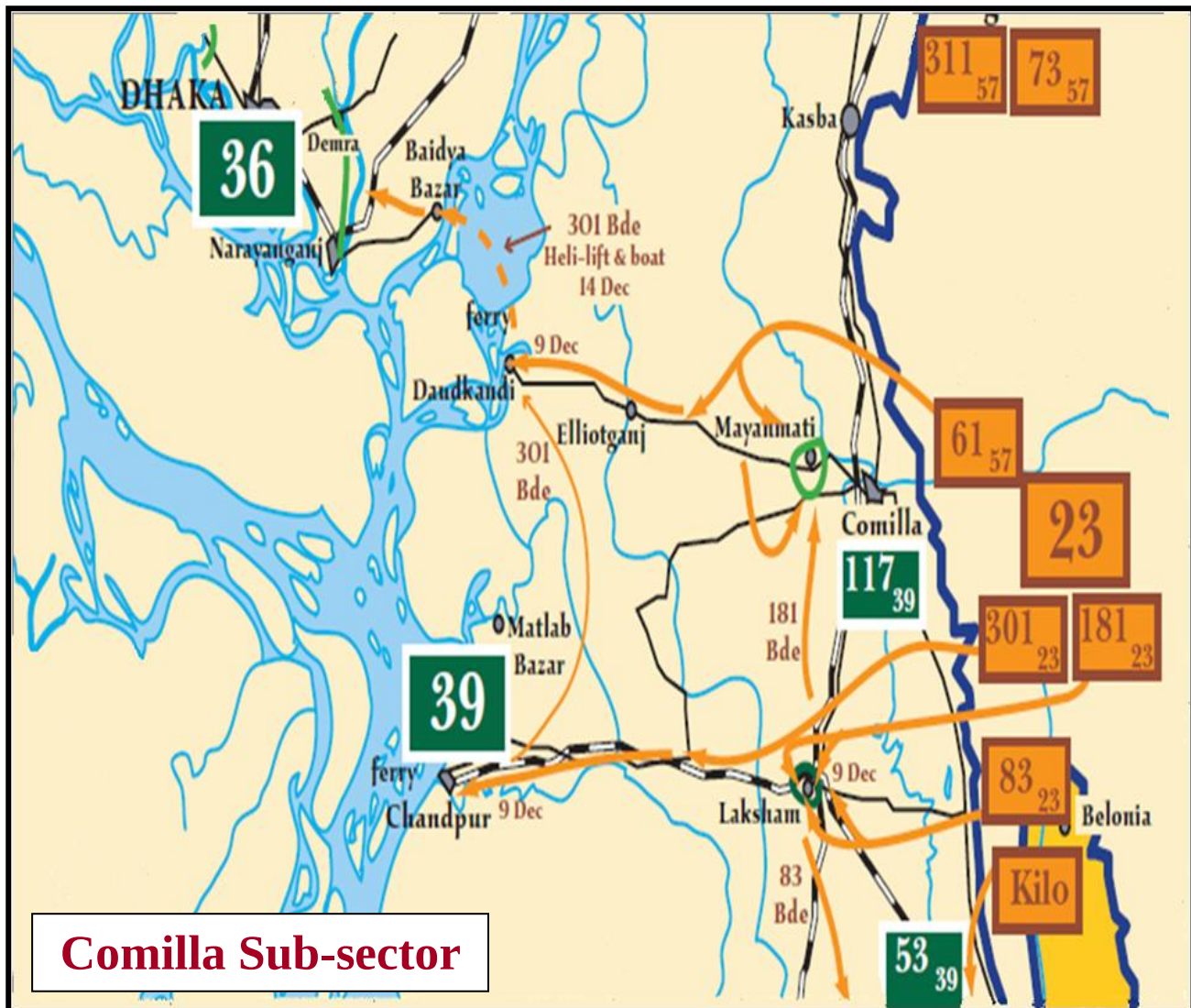
- (1) 15 Baloch was defending Belonia Salient.
- (2) 39 Baloch was guarding area between Laksham and Feni.

⁴¹⁵ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 446.

- f. *91-A & 97-A Brigades*
 - (1) 24 FF, 48 Baloch and a wing EPCAF in Chittagong.
 - (2) 2 Commando less a company in Rangamati.
 - (3) One wing of Rangers in Ramgarh.
181. **Indian Plans/ Maps – 15 & 16**
- a. 23 Mountain Division had been tasked to secure the southern part of the hills and then to capture Chandpur. It was planned to contain the Pakistani forces in Lalmai and Maynamati areas and advance through the central gap over tracks between Lalmai and Laksham with a division less a brigade while one brigade advanced along the Chaudagram – Laksham road.⁴¹⁶
 - b. According to the finalized plan:-⁴¹⁷
 - (1) 301 Mountain Brigade was to infiltrate along the Northern Approach with 1 Independent Armoured Squadron and break the crust of our defences in 117 Brigade area. 181 Mountain Brigade was to follow on the same axis and advance to Laksham and isolate it from the north and the west.
 - (2) 83 Mountain Brigade was ordered to advance along the Southern Approach and isolate Laksham from the south.
 - (3) 61 Mountain Brigade was initially to secure the northern flank of 23 Mountain Division by advancing to Pipulia, immediately north of the main axis.
 - (4) Subsequently, 181 and 83 Brigades were to capture Laksham.
 - (5) Finally, 301 Brigade was to advance to and capture Chandpur.

⁴¹⁶ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 218.

⁴¹⁷ Rao, *Prepare or Perish*, 191-92.



MAP – 16

Conduct/ Battle Accounts

182. Comilla Sub-sector (117 Brigade)/ Maps – 15 & 16

- a. On 30 November, 61 Mountain Brigade's task was altered. Earlier on, it had been ordered to cut Daudkandi road and lean on the Maynamati defence from the northwest direction without getting involved in Maynamati defence. The new task envisaged fixing our troops at Maynamati and Lalmai Hills from the south and east.⁴¹⁸

⁴¹⁸Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 219.

- b. 61 Mountain Brigade moved from Bisalgarh to the concentration area on the night of 1/2 December. Its troops were new to the area due to last minute task change. Nevertheless, 7 Raj Rif of 61 Brigade was guided toward Pipulia by Mukti Bahini guides. Elements of 30 Punjab and para-military troops defending the area fell back to Comilla after a brief skirmish. At Pipulia, the Indians posed a threat to our defences in the Lalmai Hills and toward Comilla airfield.⁴¹⁹
- c. On 5 December, 61 Mountain Brigade was ordered to undertake operations in Maynamati area, while it was operating south of Comilla. The brigade handed over its responsibility to 9 EBR and moved to the northern side of Comilla in its original role.⁴²⁰ It ordered 12 Kumaon that was in the Maynamati area to capture Rajapur on 5/6 December. 7 Raj Rif and brigade tactical headquarters reached Rajapur about 2200 hours on 6 December, just as it was captured; Burichang was secured the same night by 0100 hours without any opposition. The Indians exploited the situation and moved the whole brigade, including a troop of PT -76 tanks, south of the Nalda Nadi in the Jafarganj area by first light 7 December.⁴²¹
- d. On 7 December, the brigade captured Chandina. 117 Brigade, assuming it to be a strong patrol, sent out a company in vehicles from Maynamati to eliminate the Indian incursion. The company, on seeing a brigade size force, rather than attacking the Indian troops, returned to Maynamati and reported to Brigadier Atif about a massive Indian build-up north and west of Maynamati.
- e. As 12 Kumaon advanced westward toward Chandina, 7 Raj Rif had moved towards Maynamati to exert pressure from the west.⁴²²
- f. As a result of these operations, Atif became seriously concerned about the defence of Maynamati itself, which was held by only 30 Punjab less a company at this stage. Most of his troops were still deployed in Comilla and the Lalmai Hills. Resultantly, he started pulling up his troops into Maynamati defences around this time.⁴²³

⁴¹⁹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 218.

⁴²⁰ Ibid., 219.

⁴²¹ Ibid., 227.

⁴²² Ibid.

⁴²³ Ibid., 227-228.

- g. Along Comilla – Daudkandi Axis, 61 Mountain Brigade commenced advance from Chandina at last light and was held up at midnight at Elliotganj. Own troops had blown up the bridge over a big nullah. After some fighting at Elliotganj the Indians secured it by 2200 hours on 8 December.⁴²⁴
- h. The administrative resources behind 61 Mountain Brigade were badly stretched at this time. Therefore, the Indians decided to build-up the logistic needs on 8 December and carryout re-fitment before making a final dash to Daudkandi. 12 Kumaon resumed its advance at first light on 9 December from Elliotganj and captured Daudkandi before last light after minor resistance from Razakars.⁴²⁵
- i. On 9 December, Commander 4 Crops visited 61 Mountain Brigade near Elliotganj and instructed it to capture Maynamati. The brigade attacked Maynamati at 0100 hours, the next night, from the direction of Dighalgaon. The surprise was complete and our troops mistook the Indians for their own patrol. 7 Raj Rif had accidentally gone through the gaps that we had left in our minefields for the use of own patrols. 30 Punjab troops started talking to the leading troops of 7 Raj Rif in Punjabi, when they opened fire on them.⁴²⁶
- j. With a sudden assault, 7 Raj Rif established a foothold on high ground, which they retained till end.⁴²⁷
- k. During the next two days, 117 Brigade launched a number of attacks, but 7 Raj Rif held onto its foothold on the ridge. It suffered 38 killed and over 100 wounded, including all the company commanders.⁴²⁸ During the struggle on the ridge, a large column of 39 Baloch stragglers attacked 61 Mountain Brigade rear at 0100 hours on 10 December in the Dighalgaon area; they hit into the brigade B echelon. Both sides suffered heavy casualties.⁴²⁹
- l. Elements of 39 Baloch, which had attacked the Indians, were troops that had withdrawn from Laksham and were in search of a route into

⁴²⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 228.

⁴²⁵ Ibid.

⁴²⁶ Ibid.

⁴²⁷ Ibid., 228-229.

⁴²⁸ Ibid., 229.

⁴²⁹ Ibid.

Maynamati. After a number of unsuccessful skirmishes commanding officer of 39 Baloch with about 1500 men were surrounded and captured by the Indians by midday of 12 December.⁴³⁰

- m. On the Indian side, there was a pressure on 4 Corps to capture Maynamati. On 12 December, 4 Corps ordered 23 Mountain Division to move 181 Mountain Brigade to Maynamati and capture it with both 61 and 181 Mountain Brigades.⁴³¹ From 13 December onwards, both the brigades attacked Maynamati number of times but failed to capture it.
- n. Maynamati garrison only laid down their weapons after 16 December. Brigadier Atif and Aslam surrendered with nearly 5000 Pakistani troops to Indian 23 Mountain Division at Maynamati. Atif, who had captained our national hockey team in the Olympics, told commander 61 Mountain Brigade, "In all my hockey career, this is the third time that I lose to India."⁴³²

183. Laksham Sub-sector (117/ 53 Brigades⁴³³)/ Maps – 15 & 16

- a. 14 Jats and 1/11 GR of 301 Mountain Brigade infiltrated about two kilometres across the border in Mian Bazar area on 3 December. It was held by 25 FF less two companies. The Indian established a block near Kashinagar on the west and asked the armoured squadron to clear this locality soon after daybreak. The squadron assaulted the position at midday but faced tough resistance; it suffered four tank casualties, three from anti-tank mines and one from anti-tank weapon fire.⁴³⁴
- b. 117 Brigade ordered 25 FF to fall back and occupy a prepared position in the rear at Kashinagar. But 1/11 GR patrols had located and occupied these positions before they could reach the defences. A large number of unsuspecting Pakistanis fell into the hands of the Gorkhas. Battalion headquarters of 25 FF, including their commanding officer and 114 officers, JCOs and other ranks were taken prisoner and some vehicles

⁴³⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 229.

⁴³¹ Ibid.

⁴³² Ibid., 230.

⁴³³ 53 Brigade was deployed in Feni Sub-sector, but it withdrawn from Feni on 4 December for the defense of Laksham and Comilla. Matiuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 412.

⁴³⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 219.

captured. This resulted in creating a wide gap between Laksham and the rest of the Brigade in the Lalmai Hills.⁴³⁵

- c. The sudden collapse of 23 Punjab (guarding Southern Approach) and the 25 FF put the whole divisional defensive plan in jeopardy. The GOC held a conference at Laksham on 4 December and decided to pull back the 53 Brigade from Feni and put it in command of Laksham area. He also placed 23 Punjab under 53 Brigade. The brigade was directed to immediately occupy Mudafarganj since it covered the main approach to Chandpur.⁴³⁶
- d. After this action, 301 Mountain Brigade was concentrated at Bhuschi while 181 Mountain Brigade led the advance to Laksham on the night of 4/ 5 December. They cut the Lalmai – Laksham road in the area of Bhora by first light on 5 December and established roadblocks to the north and west of Laksham.⁴³⁷ The same night, 301 Mountain Brigade followed 81 Mountain Brigade to reach Mudafarganj and secured it after last light on 5 December.⁴³⁸
- e. On 5/ 6 December, 117 Brigade tried to counter attack the Indians who were pouring in from the direction of Mian Bazar towards Laksham but could not stem the advance. Upto this time, no one was aware that an Indian brigade had occupied Mudafarganj. On 5 December our brigade directed the elements of 23 Punjab, which were deployed ahead of Laksham, to occupy defensive positions at Mudafarganj. 23 Punjab had already been attacked at Chaudagram and was neither in a fit state to fight nor was it familiar with the area, which was known to 39 Baloch as it had prepared the defences of Laksham and Mudafarganj.⁴³⁹
- f. Indians presence in Mudafarganj also came to our knowledge only when the GOC 39-A Division was fired upon there while trying to come to Laksham from Chandpur. He returned to Chandpur and ordered the 53 Brigade to clear Mudafarganj. The brigade commander, without any preparation, decided to launch 15 Baloch and 23 Punjab along with a company of 21 AK, a task force. However, at the last moment this counter

⁴³⁵ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 219.

⁴³⁶ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 447.

⁴³⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 219.

⁴³⁸ *Ibid.*, 220.

⁴³⁹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 447.

attack was called off.⁴⁴⁰ Brigadier Aslam called 15 Baloch back to Laksham and ordered 23 Punjab and element of 21 AK to move toward Hajiganj.⁴⁴¹

- g. At this stage, 14 Jats who were at Mian Bazar were ordered by 301 Mountain Brigade to clear Comilla town and capture the airfield from the south. This was achieved without much difficulty as 30 Punjab had fallen back to Maynamati. After capturing Comilla and the southern tip of Lalmai Hills the vital route to Chandpur via Lalmai was open to Indians for logistic build-up.⁴⁴²
- h. A word about Indian 83 Mountain Brigade, which developed attack along the Southern Approach. Chaudagram was guarded by 23 Punjab less one company, which was drawn out and placed in depth position at Parikot behind Dakatia Nullah.⁴⁴³ 83 Mountain Brigade cleared Chaudagram by 2200 hours on 5 December after stiff fighting.⁴⁴⁴ Own troops in Chaudagram and Parikot areas were trapped by roadblocks behind them and made a number of efforts to break out. They suffered many casualties in these attempts. 23 Punjab, however, managed to withdraw to Laksham along cross-country tracks, leaving behind most of their support weapons and transport.⁴⁴⁵ It nevertheless, blew up the bridge over the Dakatia near Parikot, which delayed the advance of 83 Mountain Brigade. The Indians established blocks south and Southeast of Laksham by first light on 7 December.⁴⁴⁶
- i. By 7 December Laksham had been surrounded by 23 Mountain Division on all sides and 301 Mountain Brigade had captured Mudafarganj. 39-A Division was in a desperate plight. They had been invested in the two fortresses of Maynamati in the north and Laksham in the south while the Indians were pushing in their troops to Chandpur through the gap in the middle.⁴⁴⁷

⁴⁴⁰ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 448.

⁴⁴¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 222-23.

⁴⁴² *Ibid.*, 220-21.

⁴⁴³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 447.

⁴⁴⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 221.

⁴⁴⁵ *Ibid.*

⁴⁴⁶ *Ibid.*

⁴⁴⁷ *Ibid.*, 221-22.

- j. Back in Laksham, the situation was grim. After his unsuccessful attempts to break out of the encirclement Brigadier Aslam Niazi decided to exfiltrate from the fortress in small parties on the night of 8/9 December. He left the wounded and sick with a doctor and some nursing staff and slipped out in small parties. Lieutenant Colonel Naeem decided to move out in a bigger column with his 39 Baloch. Our troops left behind their heavy weapons and vehicles and moved on manpack basis.⁴⁴⁸ After the main force exfiltrated, Laksham fell on 9 December without any resistance.
- k. The bulk of the garrison from Laksham were taken prisoner by the Indians in small parties while a party of nearly 200 men under Brigadier Aslam managed to join 117 Brigade in Maynamati. The main column under Naeem, as already narrated attacked, 61 Mountain Brigade near Maynamati, but finally was caught by the Indians on 12 December near Chandina.⁴⁴⁹
- l. In the evening of 7 December, 301 Mountain Brigade was ordered to advance to Chandpur. It resumed advance from Mudafarganj and cleared Hajiganj after minor opposition.⁴⁵⁰ The brigade pressed on beyond Hijiganj and secured Chandpur 2300 hours on 9 December without opposition.⁴⁵¹ GOC 39-A Division had located his headquarters at Chandpur, and when advancing troops were reported at Mudafaganj, he realised the seriousness of situation. He had no reserves to influence the battle and his own headquarters was exposed to the approaching Indians. He asked for orders for himself from Dacca on 8 December and General Niazi instructed him to report back to Dacca to avoid being taken prisoner. A gunboat was sent to Chandpur on the night of 8/9 December and the GOC, along with his headquarters and a few remnants, left Chandpur on night 9/10 December. His gunboat was spotted and hit about 0700 hours by an Indian aircraft. A number of men were killed, but the GOC managed to reach Dacca.⁴⁵²

⁴⁴⁸ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 223.

⁴⁴⁹ Ibid.

⁴⁵⁰ Ibid., 223-24.

⁴⁵¹ Ibid., 224.

⁴⁵² Ibid.

- m. On the capture of Chandpur, 23 Mountain Division was ordered to mobilise all the available river-crafts and crossed the Meghna for advance to Dacca. This was not possible as no river-craft was available at Chandpur. Chandpur was an intermediate port between Chittagong and Dacca and boats were not stationed there permanently.⁴⁵³
 - n. As there was no possibility of arranging boats and other rivercraft to cross the Meghna, it was decided to reduce the Maynamati defences with 181 Mountain Brigade and 61 Mountain Brigade under the command of 23 Mountain Division. 301 Mountain Brigade was ordered to move to Daudkandi and cross Meghna to secure Baidya Bazar for operations against Dacca. The crossing of 301 Brigade was to be under 23 Mountain Division and the brigade was to come under the direct command of 4 Corps once they had crossed to the west bank of Meghna.⁴⁵⁴ The brigade was allotted 25 vehicles at Chandpur and it started moving to Daudkandi on 12 December,⁴⁵⁵ completing its move on 14 December.
 - o. To expedite crossing, 4 Corps arranged 12 helicopters on 14 December. It was decided to move the brigade in boats and helicopters. The brigade had captured two passenger steamers at Daudkandi with a capacity of 150 passengers each and a tug which could take six vehicles at a time. In addition, a number of country-crafts were also available.⁴⁵⁶
 - p. Troops of 301 Mountain Brigade started crossing Meghna and joined the Battle of Dacca.⁴⁵⁷
184. **Chittagong Sub-sector (97-A & 91-A Brigades)/ Map - 17**
- a. After the capture of Laksham, 83 Mountain Brigade was regrouped and joined by Kilo Force for operations in the Kumira/ Karir Hat area. The area was defended by 91-A Brigade.⁴⁵⁸
 - b. Not much action happened in this sub-sector. 83 Mountain Brigade was pushed cross-country towards Chittagong. Before they could cut off 91-A Brigade from Chittagong City, the surrender was announced.

⁴⁵³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 225.

⁴⁵⁴ Ibid.

⁴⁵⁵ Ibid., 226.

⁴⁵⁶ Ibid.

⁴⁵⁷ Ibid., 226-27.

⁴⁵⁸ Ibid., 230.



- c. As regards 97-A Brigade, on 29 November, the enemy helilanded a battalion size strength north of Rangamati but our troops of 2 Commando Battalion succeeded in stabilizing the situation there until 6 December 1971, when they were ordered to withdraw to Chittagong fortress. Our troops surrendered there after formal orders to lay down arms on 17 December, 1971.⁴⁵⁹
- d. While the above operations were going on, Indian Army Headquarters ventured to capture Cox's Bazar, an important sea port, through an amphibious operation on 11 December. An adhoc force consisting of Headquarters 2 Corps Artillery Brigade, a Gorkha battalion and elements of a Bihar battalion, with artillery and administrative units, was assembled quickly under Brigadier SS Rai for this task. INS Vikrant was to provide air support.⁴⁶⁰
- e. The Indians had planned to transport the force on a cargo ship and then transfer it to two landing ship tanks (LSTs) at a convenient place for a landing near Cox's Bazar. Indians embarked on the night of 11/12 December at Calcutta,⁴⁶¹ but after one of their ship hit the mines placed outside the harbour, they aborted their mission. Instead, amphibious landing craft ferried their infantry battalions to Cox's Bazar on 14 December.⁴⁶² By this time the war was over and the force was taken to Chittagong in local transport.⁴⁶³

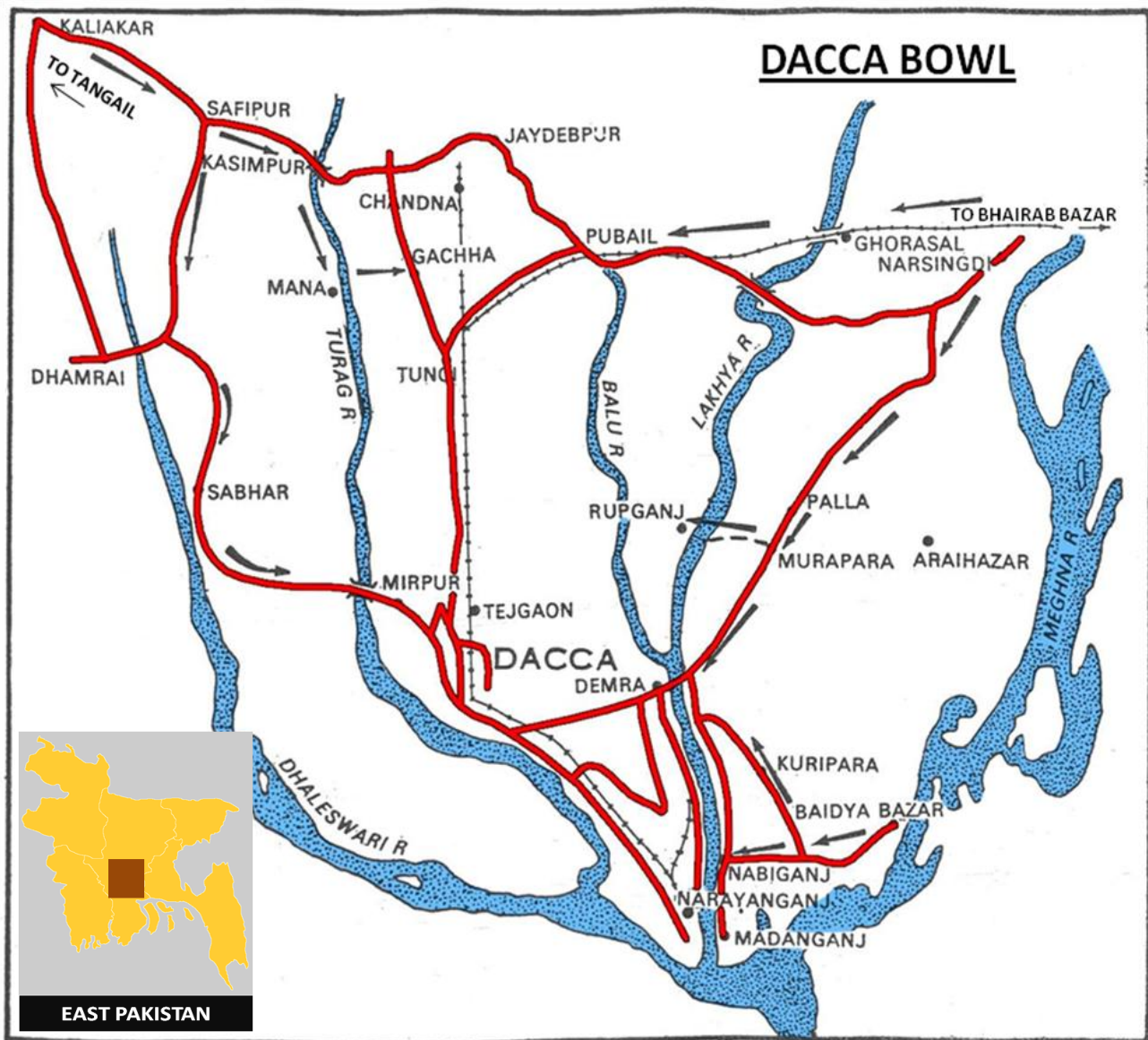
⁴⁵⁹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 451.

⁴⁶⁰ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 230.

⁴⁶¹ *Ibid.*, 231.

⁴⁶² *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 451.

⁴⁶³ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 231.



MAP - 18

DACCA BOWL

The Area of Operation⁴⁶⁴/ Maps – 18 & 19

185. General

- a. The area around Dacca was shaped more or less like the letter U. The capital was located between the Jamuna, Ganges, and the Brahmaputra. Each of the river was several kilometres wide requiring two hours to negotiate by river transport and that too at designated places. The rivers were unbridgeable even without opposition.
- b. The Dacca triangle or the Dacca bowl, as it was often referred to, was about 160 kilometres wide and around 100 kilometres deep.
- c. The only approach without a major obstacle was from the north between Jamuna and Brahmaputra.

186. Rivers

- a. Dacca bowl was bounded by Meghna in the east, the Jamuna or Brahmaputra (local) in the north and west and Ganges on the southwest. These rivers formed an outer ring around Dacca.
- b. Closer to Dacca, there were smaller rivers which basically were the off-shoots of major rivers mentioned before. These were:-
 - (1) *River Dhaleshwari*. Was an off-shoot of Jamuna. Ran west of River Turag and joined it south of Dacca.
 - (2) *River Turag*. It bifurcated again from Jamuna north of Tangail. Approached Dacca from north-western direction and skirted it from west. It joined River Dhaleshwari before flowing in Meghna.
 - (3) *River Lakhya*. It was a continuation of River Brahmaputra (local) named Lakhya after Jaydebpur. North of Demra it was joined by a minor River Balu.
 - (4) *River Meghna*. Ran in the east. All the above mentioned rivers fell into River Meghna south of Dacca.

⁴⁶⁴ Most of details about the Area of Operation have been taken from following books: (a) Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 419-421; (b) Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 5-6 & 80-84.

187. **Communication Infrastructure**

- a. There were three land routes to Dacca after crossing the outer ring of rivers. These were:-
 - (1) *From Western Sectors. Dhamrai – Sabhar – Mirpur – Dacca.* It crossed two rivers – Dhaleswari and Tugra. Had a bridge over the later.
 - (2) *From Central Sector*
 - (a) *Kaliakar – Safipur – Sabhar – Mirpur – Dacca.* It was the most easy going as it crossed over only River Turag where it was bridged.
 - (b) *Kaliakar – Safipur – Chandna – Tungi – Dacca.* Crossed only River Turag, which was bridged.
 - (3) *From Eastern Sectors*
 - (a) *Narsingdi – Pubail – Tungi – Dacca.* Crossed River Lakhya and Balu.
 - (b) *Narsingdi – Murapara – Demra – Dacca.* Had to cross River Lakhya but was not bridged.
 - (c) *Baidya Bazar – Nabiganj – Narayanganj – Dacca.* Was the shortest route but crossed two major rivers: River Meghna and River Lakhya.
- b. A meter gauge railway also connected Narayanganj via Dacca and Mymensingh. At Tungi, the railway line got bifurcated: one moved to Jamalpur, while the second branched toward Bhairab Bazar in the east.

188. **Significance of Dacca.** Dacca being the capital city of the province, the headquarters of the Eastern Command, the logistic base of the entire East Pakistan garrison and having the only airport where Boeing or other jet aircrafts could land, was the lynch pin both in military and political sense.

Opposing Forces

189. **Pakistani Forces.** 36 (Adhoc) Division, which also responsible for the Central Sector, was defending this area. Division headquarters was located at Dacca. It was commanded by Major General Jamshed.⁴⁶⁵ It consisted of following troops:-⁴⁶⁶

a.	Adhoc squadron of tanks	50
b.	Artillery (6 LAA Regiment, all guns intact with plenty of ammunition, HQ Artillery, reinforcements, etc)	700
c.	Engineers (rear parties of various units, HQ Engineers as one battalion)	500
d.	Singals (3 battalions)	2000
e.	Infantry (31 Baloch, 33 Punjab, Commando Battalion less two coys)	4500
f.	Troops from Magura Sector (North-western Sector)	900
g.	Services	1000
h.	Navy (marines)	500
i.	Air Commandos (PAF)	500
j.	EPCAF	1500
k.	Mujahids	700
l.	West Pakistan Police	2500
m.	Headquarters Eastern Command and Headquarters 36-A Division	9000

30,350⁴⁶⁷

190. According to General Matinuddin, there were no fighting elements in Dacca at all when the Indian's invaded East Pakistan on 21 November nor were there any when an

⁴⁶⁵ He had to hold this command in addition to his duties as Director General EPCAF. The staff and equipment for this additional headquarters were also to be found from the reserves of the EPCAF. *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 424.

⁴⁶⁶ Niazi, *The Betrayal of East Pakistan*, 207.

⁴⁶⁷ This figure by any standards is a gross over-estimation. Lieutenant General Lachhman Singh, gave a different account of Eastern Command strength in Dacca bowl. He writes, "Anybody in uniform was marshalled for this purpose [defense of Dacca]. They collected about 1000 regular soldiers belonging to the infantry, artillery, engineers, ordnance, the Army Service Corps, clerks and also about 1500 men of EPCAF and 2000 policemen and Razakars. The grand total of this force came to about 5000 and staff officers and any available regimental officers were diverted to command this conglomeration, poorly armed with weapons like 303 rifles and supported by tanks, three-inch mortars and light machine guns from various depots and dumps in Dacca. Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 234.

all-out-war started on 3 December. Efforts were made to move some units to Dacca; but it was too late. Only one battalion less two companies could infiltrate into the town.⁴⁶⁸

191. Indian Forces

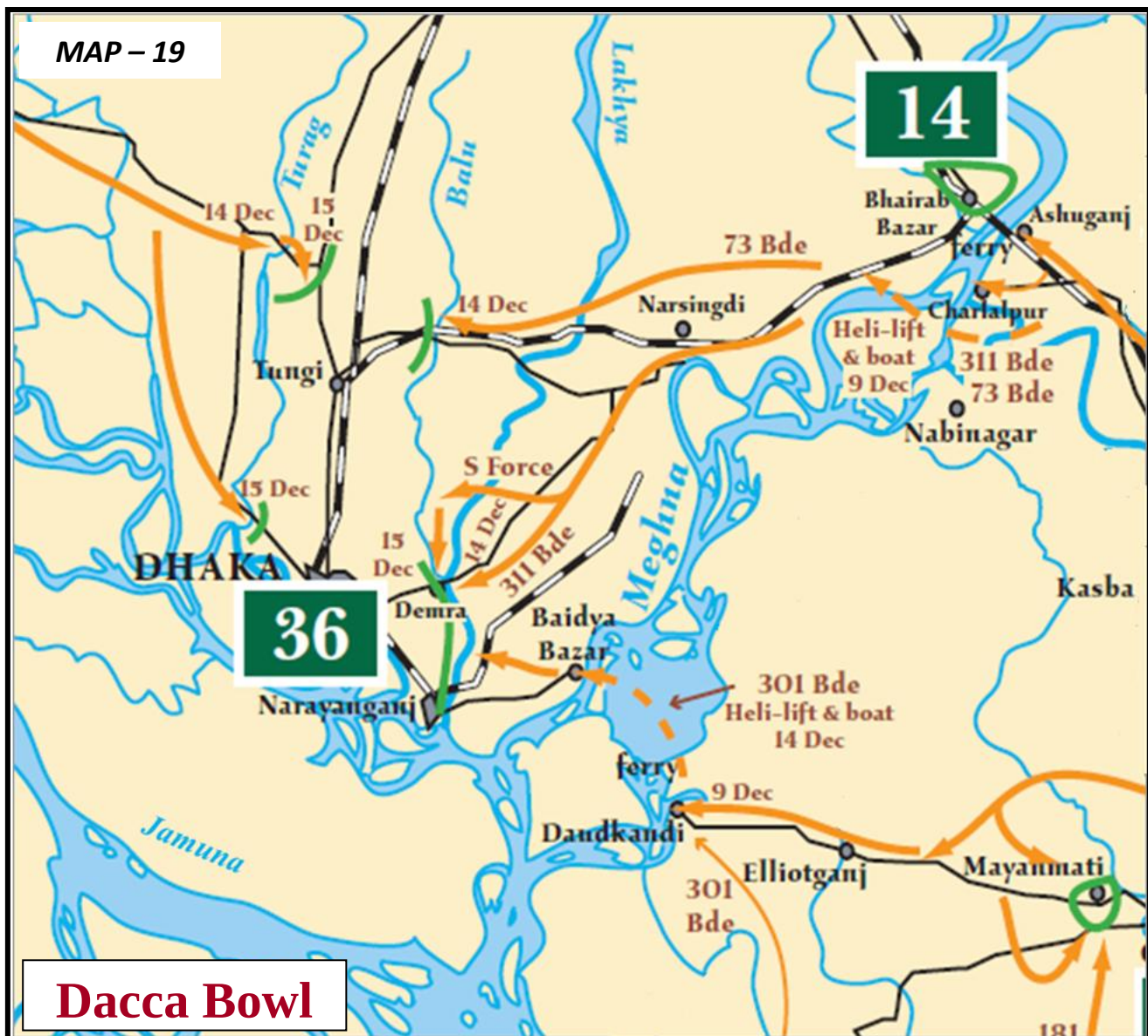
a. 57 Division (North-eastern Sector)

- (1) 311 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) 73 Mountain Brigade.
- (3) Sierra Force.

b. 23 Division (Mid & South-eastern Sector). 301 Mountain Brigade.

c. 101 Communication Zone Area (Central Sector)

- (1) 95 Mountain Brigade.
- (2) FJ Sector.



Opposing Plans/ Maps – 18 & 19

192. Pakistani Plans

- a. Four lines of defences were planned. The outer line of defence between 60-80 kilometres away from Dacca joined Mymensingh – Bhairab Bazar – Daudkandi – Chandpur – Fairdpur – Pabna and Tangail. The inner line of defence was at a distance of 20-30 kilometres connecting Dhamrai – Kasimpur – Ghorasal – Baidya Bazar. The third line of defence was just outside the city and the fourth line comprised the fortresses and strong points in the built-up areas itself. But this plan, of course, could only be implemented if adequate troops were earmarked and emplaced before the start of hostilities.⁴⁶⁹
- b. As seen from the conduct of operations, none of the troops fell back, thus the inner defences could not be allotted troops to man these areas.

193. Indian Plans

- a. Indians had not worked out plans to capture Dacca. In fact, they never planned to advance that far. On 13 December, all Indian Corps operating in East Pakistan received a signal from General Manekshaw ordering them to immediately capture all the towns in East Pakistan that they had bypassed; all towns were named with the exception of Dacca.^{470,471}
- b. Break through in the Central, North-eastern, and Mid & South-eastern sectors sparked the Indian desire to capture Dacca. Thereafter, it was a mad rush to enter Dacca first.

Conduct/ Battle Accounts

194. Indian 57 Mountain Division

- a. Immediately after heli-landing troops across Meghna, on 10 December, 4 Corps had concentrated its energies on building up sufficient forces there. Two battalions of 311 Mountain Brigade had crossed over to Bhairab Bazar. 4 Guards had advanced to Narsingdi on the morning of 10 December from Raipura and 19 Punjab had cut off the troops from 27

⁴⁶⁹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 421.

⁴⁷⁰ Lieutenant General JFR Jacob, *Surrender at Dacca: Birth of Nation* (New Delhi: Manohar Publishers, 1997), 129.

⁴⁷¹ This order was given in backdrop of likely UN ceasefire. A ceasefire at this stage would have been a catastrophe. Except for the occupation of Jessore and Comilla, the Indians held no other town. *Ibid.*, 130.

Brigade and headquarters 14 Division in Bhairab Bazar from the south and west.⁴⁷²

- b. On 11 December, 10 Bihar, part of Sierra Force, was heli-lifted with an artillery regiment to the Narsingdi area. No vehicles were taken across initially and the troops had to rely on whatever civilian transport was available across Meghna.⁴⁷³
- c. By evening of 12 December, 4 Guards had reached Barpa, about five kilometres from the Demra ferry. Five infantry battalions, two artillery regiments and the tactical headquarters of 57 Division were across Meghna. 5 Independent Armoured Squadron, despite efforts, had not crossed Meghna. 10 Bihar secured Arai Hazar airstrip, about ten kilometres northeast of Demra, so that the rate of build-up could be increased, but the Indians found it unsuitable for air-landing.⁴⁷⁴
- d. On 13 December, the leading elements of 4 Guards contacted Demra ferry, approximately nine kilometres from Dacca. It had made contact with our troops across River Lakhya, the last obstacle east of Dacca. By now, 73 Mountain Brigade, the second brigade of this division, had also assembled in Narsingdi area. At this stage 57 Mountain Division received a report that the crossings over Lakhya near Ghorasal were not held by us. The division decided to develop a double thrust towards Dacca: 311 Mountain Brigade was to advance from Narsingdi to Demra and 73 Mountain Brigade had to move toward Tungi. Sierra Force was given Demra Axis till Murapara and then it had to cross over to Rupganj.⁴⁷⁵
- e. 73 Mountain Brigade advanced from Narsingdi and captured the rail bridge at Ghorasil on 14 December. 19 Rajput Rifle advanced from Ghorasal, but were held up by own elements along the River Balu east of Pubail. Those troops, mostly Razakars, could not hold the enemy for a longer duration and withdrew towards Tungi.⁴⁷⁶
- f. On Demra Axis, 2 EBR of Sierra Force reached Murapara, on the east bank of the Lakhya opposite Rupganj, about seven kilometres north of Demra. As our troops in Dacca were known to have tanks, 57 Division

⁴⁷² Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 236.

⁴⁷³ Ibid.

⁴⁷⁴ Ibid.

⁴⁷⁵ Ibid., 237.

⁴⁷⁶ Ibid., 237-38.

was determined to get its affiliated squadron across Meghna, which was about three kilometres wide at that point. Till 12 December, despite of great efforts, the Indian tanks could not cross the river.⁴⁷⁷

- g. 14 December was an eventful day for the Indians. There was an all-round improvement in the state of the attackers. Mukti Bahinis told the advancing Indian forces that the area between the Lakhya and Balu rivers was without Eastern Command troops. So Sierra Force, consisting of 2 EBR and 10 Bihar, crossed Lakhya, secured Rugganj area and advanced south to threaten our positions in the Demra area.⁴⁷⁸ Then at 0500 hours on 14 December, 5 Independent Armour Squadron got across and reached Narsingdi by 1600 hours. It was instructed to report to 4 Guards in the Demra area at once.⁴⁷⁹ And lastly, the Indians dismantled one gun of 65 Mountain Regiment and carried it forward on a manpack basis to bombard targets in Dacca.⁴⁸⁰
- h. On 15 December, when General Aurora placed 101 Communication Zone troops under the command of 4 Corps, so that the operations around Dacca could be coordinated properly,⁴⁸¹ troops of 57 Mountain Division were still west of Lakhya at Demra ferry area and 73 Mountain Division was held up by our troops around Tungi. The fighting around Tungi stopped about 1600 hours on 16 December when a message about the surrender was finally conveyed to our troops there.⁴⁸²

195. **Indian 23 Mountain Division**

- a. 301 Mountain Brigade got across from Daudkandi to Baidya Bazar on 14 December. 14 Jats and a battery of guns left in rivercraft and helicopters after first light and secured Baidya Bazar without opposition by 0900 hours. By evening, 301 Mountain Brigade had nearly half its brigade across along with one artillery regiment, a field company and its brigade headquarters. The brigade pushed our troops across River Lakhya from Kuripara area, halfway between Demra and Narayanganj, by last light.⁴⁸³

⁴⁷⁷ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 238.

⁴⁷⁸ Ibid.

⁴⁷⁹ Ibid., 238-39.

⁴⁸⁰ Ibid., 241.

⁴⁸¹ Ibid., 243.

⁴⁸² Ibid., 247.

⁴⁸³ Ibid., 239.

- b. 301 Mountain Brigade was ordered to link up with 57 Mountain Division in the Demra area⁴⁸⁴ and to secure the area east of Lakhya till Demra ferry. The area could only be cleared after stiff fighting by first light on 16 December.⁴⁸⁵
- c. On night 15/16 December, the brigade tried to move across River Lakhya near Nabiganj. However, the Mukti Bahini guides and boats, to enable it to cross were not there. So it was decided to cross the Lakhya next night.⁴⁸⁶
- d. 1/11 GR of 301 Mountain Brigade crossed the River north of Narayanganj in Nabiganj area only when our troops had pulled out after first light of 16 December.⁴⁸⁷

196. **Central Sector**

- a. On 11 December, the Indians carried out a para-drop with 2 Para at Tangail.⁴⁸⁸ But, the troops of 101 Communication Zone could not progress ahead of Kasimpur till 14 December. The Central Sector was the only sector where our troops were able to slip out of Indian noose to fight them again north of Dacca. Commanding Officer 31 Baloch, Lieutenant Colonel Sultan Ahmed had reached Dacca after his escape from Jamalpur and was given the responsibility of checking the Indian along the Tungi Axis. He had about 100 men of his battalion with a few hundred others and some paramilitary troops. The Indian attack against 31 Baloch roadblock near Chandna was beaten back with the support of artillery fire.⁴⁸⁹
- b. From 14 December onwards, the spotlight shifted from 4 Corps to 101 Communication Zone operations. As 95 Mountain Brigade's efforts to cross the Turag at Kasimpur did not succeed on 14 December, the division revised its plans. It instructed 95 and 167 Mountain Brigades to continue operations against us along River Turag and asked 63 Mountain Brigade to push south toward Dhamrai ferry crossing.⁴⁹⁰ The same day, the Indians came to know about a newly constructed road running south

⁴⁸⁴ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 240.

⁴⁸⁵ Ibid., 241.

⁴⁸⁶ Ibid., 241-42.

⁴⁸⁷ Ibid., 244.

⁴⁸⁸ Ibid., 237.

⁴⁸⁹ Ibid., 246-47.

⁴⁹⁰ Ibid., 242.

from Safipur area to Sabhar along the eastern bank of the River Dhaleswari. It had no river crossing.⁴⁹¹

- c. 63 Mountain Brigade, on the other hand, instead of moving toward Dhamrai, advanced to Mirpur along Sabhar Axis. It secured the road junction east of the Dhamrai ferry by 1600 hours on 15 December after a minor skirmish.⁴⁹²
- d. Early on 15 December two companies of 6 SLI of 95 Mountain Brigade crossed River Turag in country-boats well away on our flank in Kasimpur area. Sensing a threat in rear, own troops withdrew from the area after blowing up the bridge. 6 SLI secured the area on the eastern bank by 1500 hours, but our troops again held the Indians up around Chandna crossroad area.⁴⁹³
- e. At Sabhar, 63 Mountain Brigade came under attack. Eastern Command had moved about 200 Razakars into Sabhar on 14/15 December night. Due to our surprise attack the Indians suffered 16 casualties, but Sabhar was captured by last light.⁴⁹⁴
- f. Our next delaying position, comprising a couple of hundred troops, mainly from EPCAF and some from the regulars,⁴⁹⁵ along this axis was at Mirpur Bridge. The 63 Mountain Brigade advanced to capture the Mirpur bridge after the fall of Sabhar without loss of time, but failed to capture it till formal announcement of surrender.
- g. On the midnight of 15/16 December, Islamabad had instructed Dacca to surrender to the advancing Indian troops. Dacca in turn conveyed this order its troops before first light on 16 December. However, fighting did not end till about 1600 hours on 16 December.⁴⁹⁶

⁴⁹¹ Singh, *Victory in Bangladesh*, 242.

⁴⁹² Ibid., 242-43.

⁴⁹³ Ibid., 243.

⁴⁹⁴ Ibid.

⁴⁹⁵ Ibid.

⁴⁹⁶ Ibid., 246.

CONCLUSION

197. When the battle of Dacca started, all divisions of the Eastern Command had already been seriously unbalanced and had lost cohesion:-

- a. 9 (P) Division had been split in three with the major portion of 107 Brigade fighting its war toward Khulna. 57 Brigade designated fortress had fallen to Indian 4 Division and it had crossed over the Ganga into 16 Division. Major General Ansari, with a weak adhoc force (Colonel Afridi's force), was anxiously awaiting future developments at Faridpur.
- b. Whereas, the 16 Pakistani Division had been cut in two with no hope of a linkup. The divisional commander had been separated from his main headquarters as a result of the roadblocks established by 20 Mountain Division at Pirganj. He was heli-lifted into Bogra on the night of 9/10 December.
- c. As regards the 14 Division, the divisional headquarters and remnants took shelter in Bhairab Bazar behind the Meghna and awaited reinforcement by the fleeing troops from across the river at Ashuganj and from their brigades at Maulvi Bazar and Sylhet. This division took no further part in the operations and stayed as mere spectator in Bhairab Bazar.
- d. The 39 – A Division under Major General Rahim had ceased to exist, 4 Corps had captured Chandpur and Daudkandi and the GOC was evacuated to Dacca. Most of his forces were taking shelter in the strongly prepared defences in Maynamati while a considerable portion of his troops was wandering about in the Laksham - Chandpur area, where they surrendered in small parties in the next few days.
- e. 36 – A Division was still holding on positions south of Tangail. Though, its troops were battle exhausted and fatigued.

198. In next 3 – 4 days the Indians closed in toward Dacca from north and east. The defences around Dacca were without troops. The feeling of impending defeat and insecurity pervaded Dacca. The UN had arranged an airlift to evacuate foreign nationals on 8 December and requested India to guarantee safe air evacuation from Dacca. The same day Indian increased their propaganda; Manekshaw beamed a special message to the Pakistani forces to surrender, telling them their condition was utterly hopeless.

199. Thousands of leaflets were dropped over Pakistani garrisons, asking them to surrender. On 9 December, Governor Malik sent his second message to Yahya Khan to

consider an immediate ceasefire and political settlement. The same day Niazi informed Islamabad about the critical military situation in the province. Yahya Khan sent a telegram to Malik on 9 December delegating him the authority to take necessary decisions on the proposals he had sent to Islamabad for a political settlement. The same day Malik decided to approach Mr Henry, Assistant Secretary General of the UN located in Dacca, to arrange a ceasefire. The proposal was leaked out by the Indians and it was soon broadcast by a number of foreign radio stations, and this further affected the morale of the Pakistani troops.

200. Major General Jamshed, who was responsible for defence of Dacca, had no resources to organise the defence of this last Pakistani citadel. Consequently, Major General Nagra of Indian 101 Communication Zone contacted General Niazi and moved into Dacca without much resistance.

PART – III

ANALYSIS

STRATEGIC & OPERATIONAL ASPECTS⁴⁹⁷**National Security Environment**

201. **Spectrum of Threat.** Threat occupies a pivotal position in defining national security. The objectives of national security are meaningful only when viewed in context of threat. A full spectrum of threat developed against security of Pakistan which included the indirect as well as the direct threat. The indirect threat developed to the security, solidarity and integrity of Pakistan from within which finally took the shape of a rebellion. It was motivated by Bengali nationalism which in turn had been caused by socio-economic, political and psychological factors. This indirect threat was essentially aimed at the ideological basis. It continued over a period of years at the lower end of the conflict spectrum, wherein, political, economic, psychological and sociological elements were orchestrated by the Indians to attain objectives of causing disunity and creating suitable conditions for employment of direct threat using military element of national power.

202. **Failure to Identify Transition in Threat.** The nature of threat kept changing constantly as it transitioned from indirect to direct threat. Our inability to comprehend the transitory nature of threat and apply it to our national security concepts resulted in lack of developing an appropriate response. We did not fully comprehend the potential of the systemic threat resulting from Indians playing up the refugee problem or from the Indo-Soviet friendship. Thus, the quickly changing threat environment soon overtook our response.

203. **Incorrect Assessment of Strategic Threat.** The immediate threat was indicated by concentration of Indian forces and development of logistic and communication infrastructure against East Pakistan. This was not correctly assessed for its potential by us. Given the historical experience of our conflicts with India, there should have been

⁴⁹⁷ Analyses details (strategic & operational aspects only) have been borrowed from following documents/papers: (a) *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission Report*; (b) *Aftab Commission Report, 1974*; (c) Lieutenant Colonel Ashfaq Parvez Kayani, *Indo-Pak War 1971*, Military History Presentation, National Defence College, AFWC 1992, 70-86; (d) Lieutenant Colonel Aziz & et al, "Indo Pak War 1971," National Defence College, AFWC 2006; (e) Lieutenant Colonel Nadir & et al, "Pakistan – India War 1971," National Defence College, AFWC 2009.

no doubts as to the true intentions of India. We misread it as being limited to capture of only a chunk of East Pakistan.

204. **Emphasizing Intention over Capability.** We not only misread the intentions at the political level but also applied these incorrectly at the operational level where it was more pertinent to go by her capability. Once the Indians had acquired the capability and created conducive conditions for its application, intentions should have no longer been important at the operational level. Planning on the basis of Indian intention rather than her capability was perhaps the most crucial strategic mistake.

Defence Policy

205. The Indo-Pak war of 1971 is a good example of two extreme cases: one (India), of an adequate defence policy which catered for coordinated applications of all elements of national power for an achievable end in which the military element had a well defined role; the other, on the contrary (Pakistan), of an inadequate defence policy which neglected to develop a comprehensive response based on all elements of national power and is also a good example of the consequences of ends outstripping the means.

206. India

- a. **Political Aim.** The Indians had an unambiguous aim of dismembering Pakistan and creation of Bangladesh.
- b. **Synchronised Application of all Elements of National Power.** Identifying the germs of discord between the two wings the Indians carefully and deliberately nurtured and exploited it by a coordinated application of elements of national power other than military. A successful external manoeuvre isolated us in the comity of nations while the interior manoeuvre affected the will of the people, the strength of an ideological state, and turned it into a weakness. Only when the conditions were near perfect, the military element was used. The military element was thus not used to the exclusion of other elements but in coordination and support of them.
- c. **Harmony between Political End and Military Means.** The ends sought by the political aim were within the capability of military element. The Indian Army did not succumb to the domestic pressure for a military action in April 1971 when the armed forces were not fully ready. Military element was used only after having developed the military capability to the extent where it promised attainment of the objective.

207. **Pakistan**

- a. **Political Aim.** Was to preserve its integrity as united Pakistan.
- b. **Implications.** The integrity of an ideological state consists of two elements i.e. its ideological as well as territorial frontiers which has following implications:-
 - (1) Ideology was more important as it provided the very reason for the existence of a united Pakistan.
 - (2) The two elements are not mutually exclusive.
 - (3) The selection of means and methods to ensure the security of one should be carefully weighed against its adverse effects on the other. The best available means and methods to ensure territorial integrity of Pakistan which weakened her ideological foundation were, therefore, irrelevant.
- c. **Flaws in conception of Defence Policy.** Given the above implications, flaws of Pakistan's defence policy were:-
 - (1) **Incorrect Interpretation of Political Aim.** Preserving integrity of a united Pakistan was translated and understood in a predominantly physical sense. The resulting defence policy was thus faulty.
 - (2) **Incorrect Perception of National Defence.** We failed to understand national defence as a comprehensive concept which should provide defence against both direct and indirect threat and consequently failed in developing a total response.
 - (3) **Developing Military Element at the Cost of other Elements of National Power.** The development of armed forces alone was not enough as military power could not defeat political ideas. An increase in military capability was not seen in relation to the marginal reduction in overall security in terms of its effects on quality of life, economic stability and more importantly the political acceptability of the ends for which the increased military capability was intended. Disregard of most of these considerations resulted in a situation in which the whole structure was thrown in disequilibrium.
 - (4) **Response Limited to Military Element Alone.** Confronted with the changing internal and external national security environments

we could respond in military terms alone or were constrained from reacting because of our neglect to develop the capability for other alternatives due to an over commitment to the military capability. We have not been able to overcome this fixation even today and tend to respond by military element to emerging crises which have their roots in political or social problems.

- (5) **Misplaced Emphasis on Controlling Effects.** In the relationship of causes and effects, effects received more attention which resulted in neglecting the political nature of the problem and emphasized controlling the effects. The shifting of this emphasis manifested in dealing with the internal security situation using military element alone which, though overtly successful, further contributed to the very causes which had created the crisis.
- (6) **Failure to Reconcile Divergent Threat Perception.** Our ability to defend was further undermined as there was no consensus on the way the people in East and West Pakistan perceived their adversaries. We in West Pakistan perceived Indian military aggression as the main threat to the national security but this perception was not shared by our brethren in East Pakistan. They perceived economic problems as the main threat. Due to lack of consensus on the threat perception, we failed to include economic policies in the core of our security policies. Our continuation with development of military means was at the cost of economic development perceived as more important by East Pakistan. Ironically, therefore, development of military strength as means to ensuring national defence actually further weakened the national defence against total threat spectrum.

Military Strategy

208. **Implications of the Basic Premise.** The basic premise of military strategy that defence of East Pakistan lies in West Pakistan had two implications:-

- a. Sufficient relative strength superiority in West Pakistan should have been available to execute a manoeuvre to capture strategically important areas.

- b. Freedom of action should have remained available in terms of launching an offensive and coordinating it with situation in East Pakistan in terms of effects desired.

209. **Requirements.** The requirements of both these implications were not adequately met:-

- a. **Superior Relative Strength**

- (1) Each division dispatched to East Pakistan as re-enforcement was at the cost of weakening the relative strength ratio in West Pakistan. The two division's i.e. 9 and 16 Division dispatched to East Pakistan and replaced with newly raised division were actually part of the strategic reserve which directly contributed to weakening its capability. Reinforcement of East Pakistan, therefore, negated our military strategy.
- (2) Successful Indian exterior manoeuvre and selecting winter season for commencement of operations helped them in releasing forces from Chinese borders.

- b. **Timings**

- (1) Successful diplomatic efforts by the Indian government broke the linkage between the situation in East Pakistan and the overall national security perspective of Pakistan. World perception of the issue prevented Pakistan from taking an offensive in West Pakistan in support of the worsening situation in East Pakistan. It severely restricted the freedom of action in terms of timings for starting such an offensive in the Western Theatre.
- (2) The ideal time for a counter offensive from the point of view of the imbalance in the Indian assembly and the effects that it could have produced to help situation in East Pakistan was from 12 to 25 October. The window of opportunity which existed was lost due to a number of factors but primarily because of the adverse political and diplomatic environments which had been created by a successful Indian exterior manoeuvre.
- (3) The decision to commence operations in the Western Theatre came so late that even a success at that time could not have relieved pressure on the eastern theatre. The actual decision to

launch the strategic reserve was taken when the front in East Pakistan had collapsed. It was, therefore, too late to help defence of East Pakistan.

- (4) It could even be argued that the offensive in West Pakistan did not help situation in East Pakistan because formal declaration of war by Pakistan freed the Indians of any restrictions on use of force and in that their air played a decisive role. Eastern Command may well have done better at the operational level without a formal declaration of war by Pakistan.

210. **Flaws of the Basic Premise.** The flaws of the basic premise of military strategy could, therefore, be summed up as follows:-

- a. **Linkage between the Eastern and Western Theatres of War.** The two theatres of war i.e. the western and the eastern were widely apart; operations in one could not have a decisive influence on the other, especially in the context of a short war. The operations in the two theatres should, therefore, have been conducted as if these were two separate wars. Only at the peace table their essential unity would have been possible. Therefore, even if the basic premise of our strategy was correct it was only in the strategic sense; but the expectations associated with it in terms of relieving pressure on East Pakistan were flawed as the operations conducted in West Pakistan could not affect operation in East Pakistan in a time frame where these could have been used for the ends of operational strategy.
- b. **Disregarding Nature of War.** Our military strategy presumed an initiative in taking an offensive in the Western Theatre. It failed to take into considerations the constraints which could have been imposed on its execution if the nature of war did not take its predicted shape. It was not comprehensive and flexible enough to adjust to the conditions and compulsions created by the form the war took.
- c. **Consequences of Military Strategy**
 - (1) **Psychological Alienation of East Pakistan.** It helped in strengthening the already existing perception in East Pakistan that they were dispensable in the calculations of military strategy, which, combined with the variance in threat perception of the two

wings, led to psychological exclusion of East Pakistan from the national defence effort.

- (2) **Building Wrong Perceptions in West Pakistan.** The implied indefensibility of East Pakistan helped reinforce the feelings in West Pakistan that we were better off without East Pakistan. As the crisis grew as well as its cost, the feeling grew even stronger. It had two serious effects:-
 - (a) **Eroded Ideological Base.** The argument in support of this thinking was essentially in economic and geographic terms and at the cost of ideological considerations. The gradual acceptance of this argument correspondingly eroded the ideological base.
 - (b) **Affected Political Will.** It affected the popular will to defend East Pakistan. The struggle in East Pakistan was not popularly perceived as the battle for survival of a united Pakistan.

211. **Military Aim and Objectives**

a. **India**

- (1) **Military Objectives within Available Means.** Given the political aim of dismembering Pakistan, India had initially selected capturing a chunk of land of East Pakistan for establishment of Bangladesh as its military objective. At that point in time a restricted military objective was desirable as only that much was within her available military capability.
- (2) **Military Objectives Expanded on Availability of Additional Means.** Subsequently, as a superior relative strength became available due to switching of forces from the Chinese border and the ability of employing them with the improved infrastructure, the Indians raised their military objective to that of capture of the whole of East Pakistan.
- (3) **Military Objectives in Harmony with Political Aim.** The initial military objective, though restricted, was still in complete harmony with the political aim. However, it would have required the political process to take over again employing other elements of national

power to attain the final end of creating Bangladesh comprising the entire territory of East Pakistan. It was a good example of adjusting the end to the limited means but enlarging it again once additional means became available. This also shows how threat to Pakistan transitioned from the lower to the higher level but we remained fixed to only the lower level and were therefore, unable to review and update the earlier threat hypothesis.

b. **Pakistan**

(1) **Military Objectives.** The military objectives deduced by Pakistan were:-

- (a) Deny any area of an appreciable size in East Pakistan to India which could have been used for creation of Bangladesh.
- (b) To capture strategically important Indian area in West Pakistan.

(2) **Flaws of Military Objectives in Eastern Theatre.** The defects of the military objectives selected in East Pakistan were:-

- (a) **Incorrect Assumption Regarding Indian Military Objectives.** The plan to defend East Pakistan was based on the assumption that India would be interested in capturing only a chunk of East Pakistan. Apparently, it seems a simple assumption but everything that went wrong subsequently had to do with this assumption as it related to the very nature of war we expected to fight. The nature of the two types war i.e. the one we assumed and the one which actually took place with the aim of capturing whole of East Pakistan, was totally different. It was, therefore, not simply an assumption but the supreme and most far reaching act of judgment that the leadership had to take. Clausewitz calls it “the first of all strategic questions and the most comprehensive”. Our failure to answer this strategic question correctly resulted into conditions which could not subsequently be corrected at operational level.

- (b) **Neglected Political Purpose.** Connected to this incorrect assumption is the assertion that the forward defensive posture adopted in East Pakistan was desired politically but was not militarily viable. Given the most accepted Calusewitzian Concept that *War is an extension of Policy*, this assertion is absurd. There is no sense in a militarily viable option which does not serve the political purpose or vice versa as the war is not the end in itself but the means to achieving the political end.
- (c) **Failure to Reconcile Political Ends and Military Means.** The underlying reason for this assertion was, perhaps, our inability to reconcile the political ends to the military means. If the political end was to defend every inch of East Pakistan and the military means were not sufficient then it required reconciliation of the end with the available means. This would have then led to a solution which would have been both politically acceptable and militarily viable. This inflexibility and attempt to defend everything with means which were insufficient ended up with Eastern Command defending nothing.
- (d) **Total Reliance on Military Element.** The military objective reflected our total reliance on military element alone. A better option under the circumstances would have been to defend the core areas only for a sufficient length of time in which the operations could have been developed in West Pakistan or for other elements of national power to have been employed to help in developing a more acceptable political solution. Dependence on military element alone to the exclusion of other elements led us to a 'win all or lose all' situation with the dice loaded against Pakistan, which was certainly not a rational approach.

212. **Defeat of Military Strategy.** Sun Tzu considered it of "supreme importance in war to attack the enemy's strategy". Our strategy i.e. "defence of East Pakistan lies in the west" was defeated even before it could be implemented. The linkage between the

defence of East Pakistan and total security of Pakistan was broken by a successful Indian exterior manoeuvre. It also helped India to alter relative strength ratio against Pakistan in the Western Theatre and denied us the best time to launch a counter offensive. An appropriate posture of defence helped India achieve both. Finally, when the military strategy was implemented and the Western Theatre was activated, neither the conditions existed for its success nor were the timings correct to relieve pressure on East Pakistan.

Operational Strategy

213. Centre of Gravity

- a. Dacca was correctly identified as centre of gravity by both sides. Being a provincial capital and hub of communications, its fall would have led to a general collapse.
- b. Indians proceeded to expose it very deliberately and methodically and all their actions including the preparatory manoeuvre were directed towards that end.
- c. Our forces were not deployed to protect the centre of gravity. Our initial plan catered for it but the final plan left it exposed.

214. Strategic Imbalance

- a. An imbalance existed in our system of forces because:-
 - (1) The operational centre of gravity was placed too far forward.
 - (2) The operational plan was designed to protect borders and not the strategic centre of gravity i.e. Dacca.
 - (3) Limited reserve at tactical level and almost non-existent reserve at the operational level.
 - (4) Terrain strength not used to improve the already inferior relative strength ratio.
- b. The existing imbalance was further accentuated by:-
 - (1) Indian preparatory manoeuvre to attract forces towards the borders and further away from the strategic centre of gravity.
 - (2) The indirect approach adopted by the Indian manoeuvre.
 - (3) Indian air superiority, less developed lines of communications dominated by Mukti Bahini.

- (4) In view of the accentuated imbalance, our capability was restricted to limited reaction at tactical level. This implied that recovery from a tactical set-back would be difficult. The synergetic effects of the tactical defeat could accumulate to the creation of conditions contributing to collapse at the operational level.

TACTICAL ASPECTS

South-western Sector

215. Premature Evacuation from Jessore

- a. The fall of Jessore, the strongest fortress in East Pakistan, was not only a serious blow to 9 (P) Division defences, but it considerably weakened the morale of the troops in East Pakistan. 107 Brigade decided to vacate Jessore when the defences on the both sides of the Indian penetration were still intact. The brigade commander without verifying decided that the defences had been smashed by the enemy tanks and there was nothing that could stop the enemy from entering Jessore immediately.
- b. He did not wait for the orders of the GOC. According to *Hamoodur Rehman Commission Inquiry*, on 6 December at approximately 1600 hours when the GOC rang Brigadier Hayat to enquire whether he had gone forward to see what was happening. He came to know that the brigade commander had not gone ahead. As the GOC was talking to him, he paused a little and then said, "Sir, the enemy has entered Jessore cantonment; Khuda Hafiz... and put the telephone down."⁴⁹⁸ As we know the enemy had not entered Jessore till then. Jessore was not lost due to lack of reserves but due to "premature evacuation".

216. Delayed Readjustment of Defences

- a. During the second week of November, when 107 Brigade fell back to general line of Afra – Jhingergacha, it carried out deployment without much thought about keeping reserves or tactical dictates to occupy Jessore. The redeployment left the brigade with one and a half battalion for creating reserves or guarding Jessore but the brigade preferred occupying less threatened areas: Benapole by portion of 27 FF; and Satkhira with 15 FF.
- b. It is believed that 15 FF, which was placed at Satkhira, some 30 miles away from Jhingergacha to guard a possible axis, could have been withdrawn to Jessore, to give the defensive positions more depth, especially, after the enemy had exposed its hand and was moving toward Jessore.

⁴⁹⁸ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 434.

217. Inability to Move to Dacca

- a. There was a general perception among the commanders that the Indians would occupy a small chunk of territory and declare it Bangladesh. This perception inhibited both the brigades of 9 (P) Division to leave the sector. Later on when they realized the real intentions of Indians, it was too late to move toward Dacca.
- b. Around 9/ 10 December, 57 Brigade crossed over the Hardinge Bridge and moved into 16 Division area. There, it did not participate in war till the ceasefire. The Eastern Commander wanted it to be sent over to Dacca but since the brigade commander, according to GOC 16 Division, was badly shaken and his troops exhausted/ disorganized they were not pushed toward Dacca. As per Kamal Matinuddin's account exhaustion and uncertainty had overwhelmed the formation.⁴⁹⁹ The brigade was, therefore, allowed to rest and a battalion ex-16 Division was sent in its place but in the meantime, the ferries had disappeared and lifting by helicopters had become impossible due to enemy air.⁵⁰⁰

218. Significance of Small Actions

- a. Small unit actions can have huge implications on the conduct of operations. "Kushtia Ambush" by elements of 18 Punjab and 29 Cavalry is one such example. As a reaction to this attack, the Indians shifted the weight of 4 Division offensive to capture Kushtia and clear the area upto the Hardinge Bridge. Indian decision to divert the main effort toward Kushtia shifted the centre of gravity of operations of 2 Corps away from Dacca.
- b. Indian 4 Division overreacted to this casualty-ridden action and the Indian GOC diverted the whole division to deal with the opposition at Kushtia, leaving only a battalion or so holding the west bank of River Madhumati. This diversion delayed the Indians move toward Faridpur for at least three precious days.

219. Indian Blunder

- a. Move of 107 Brigade toward Khulna and 57 Brigade toward Kushtia irretrievably split the 9 (P) Division into two with a yawning gap in the

⁴⁹⁹ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 397.

⁵⁰⁰ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 436.

centre. The route to Dacca lay open with only a task force comprising elements of 38 FF and 50 Punjab with one artillery battery in support. At this stage a great opportunity offered itself to the Indian 2 Corps along the front of both its divisions for a drive towards Goalundo Ghat en-route to Dacca, but it was not seized.

- b. Rather than developing their operations toward Magura, the Indians on finding Jessore empty, followed in pursuit of 107 Brigade toward Khulna. This mistake by the Indians cost them dearly; they had to fight fierce battles all the way to Khulna.

North-western Sector

220. Faulty Deployment

- a. The intelligence appreciation upto 1970 was that the Indians' major offensive would be launched in this sector which appeared to be suitable for the use of tanks. 16 Division was, therefore, made comparatively stronger than the other divisions located in East Pakistan. But, the Division without appreciating the threat deployed troops all along the border. There was as such no brigade defensive position as admitted by both General Niazi and General Nazar Hussain.⁵⁰¹
- b. Had 16 Division deployed a brigade each in Rangpur and Bogra Sub-sectors with a task force in Nator, the division would have had 34 Brigade as reserve to influence the battle. Instead, 16 Division distributed a brigade each to all the sub-sectors. 34 Brigade was tasked to defend Nator Sub-sector but at the same time, it was expected to act as division reserve. Besides, 34 Brigade was considerably depleted by the withdrawal of units and sub-units from it to fill in the gaps in defence both within and outside the divisional area. 12 Punjab was taken away from this brigade and sent to Jessore. Another two companies of 32 Baloch were also given to the colonel staff of the 16 Division when he was put in command of the troops west of River Tista.
- c. Similarly, the division had no contingency plan for withdrawal across Jamuna towards Dacca.⁵⁰²

⁵⁰¹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 444.

⁵⁰² *Ibid.*, 436.

221. **Inability to Appreciate the Vital Ground – Pirganj.** The capture of Pirganj by Indians on road Rangpur – Bogra cut the 16 Division into two parts. The Indians after securing this central position, decided to deal with each sub-sector separately. This happened on 7 December and thereafter 16 Division lost cohesion in its defences. The inability of commander to appreciate the significance of Pirganj as a vital ground and its timely occupation cost the division heavily.

222. **Fixing Forces East of Tista**

- a. 16 Division was defending an area east of Tista with 25 Punjab and few elements of 8 Punjab. Though the possibility of development of Indian offensive from this direction was remote but, any offensive in the area would threaten 16 Division's rear.
- b. Realizing this implication, the brigade ex 6 Mountain Division, which was concentrated in the Siliguri Corridor, launched an attack. The Indians thus successfully tied down our forces and remained content to keep them there, while other Indian formations tried to break through 205 Brigade defences around Hilli.

223. **Defence of Hilli**

- a. Indians tried to breakthrough an expected approach. But, excellently sited localities in Hilli took heavy toll of enemy and she had to revise her plan of manoeuvre. It can be accrued from this that where the appreciation of enemy threat was correctly made and troops prepared their defences well, the Indians struggled to clear those positions.
- b. Had Hilli fell like Jessore, the collapse of 16 Division would have been much quicker and total.

Central Sector

224. **Weakly Held Defences.** Incorrect appreciation of the enemy's intention led to faulty conclusions. The Central Sector was very lightly held even though it had no major obstacles which the Indians had to cross to reach Dacca. "Only in September an adhoc division was raised with 53 Brigade and an adhoc brigade plus some EPCAF elements. The Indians also did not give this sector much significance."⁵⁰³ Nevertheless, as it finally turned out it was the troops along this approach which were the first to reach Mirpur Bridge outside Dacca.

⁵⁰³ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 439.

225. **Failure to Check Indian Advance South of Brahmaputra (L).** Area ahead of River Brahmaputra (L) should have been considered as a security zone with main defences south of the river. This would have allowed the 36-A Division to correctly identify the enemy main and secondary efforts. River as a formidable obstacle could have also provided extra strength to the weakly constituted division.

226. **Decision to Abandon Jamalpur & Maymensingh.** Had 93-A Brigade not abandoned Jamalpur and Maymensingh and held Tangail Bridge in strength, the Indians would not have heli-landed their troops. The wisdom of the decision to withdraw these troops from strong defensive positions apart, the move was an extremely hazardous one as the line of communication had, in the meantime, become extremely vulnerable due to intensification of Mukti Bahini activities.⁵⁰⁴

227. **Indecision to Attack Para Troops**

- a. When the Indian helicopters dropped their forces, most of our 93-A Brigade was well south of Tangail. The commanders' indecision to aggressively tackle this new menace which was most vulnerable during their landing phase cost 36-A Division capture of its troops.
- b. The successful landing also badly affected the morale of own troops. 93-A Brigade should have kept some troops as reserve during its withdrawal to achieve a clean break from enemy and to cater for such contingency.

North-eastern Sector

228. **Withdrawal of 313 Brigade to Sylhet**

- a. Complete front of the 27 Brigade had collapsed by night 4/5 December. The GOC, at this stage, ordered the brigade to withdraw to Brahmanbaria. The appreciation of the divisional commander, who was personally in control of the battle, was that the enemy with its three brigades would launch brigade attacks from the east and north on Brahmanbaria and would send the third brigade straight to Ashuganj from Sarail and thus cut his division out from the rear. 27 Brigade had only two battalions and a company with him to defend Brahmanbaria. This force was not considered to be sufficient to prevent encirclement, which would have given the enemy the control of the river (Meghna) and of Bhairab Bridge which were the only axes into Dacca Triangle area from the east. Realizing this danger, the GOC asked for permission to withdraw the 313 Brigade from

⁵⁰⁴ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 440.

Maulvi Bazar to Ashuganj but this permission was not granted. He, therefore, decided in view of the strategic importance of Ashuganj, lying immediately opposite to Brahmanbaria on the other side of the river, to abandon Brahmanbaria and defend Ashuganj which too was prepared as a strong point and sufficiently stocked with ammunition.⁵⁰⁵

- b. The outflanking of Brahmanbaria could have been prevented if the Eastern Command had permitted the division to withdraw its 313 Brigade to Brahmanbaria instead of sending it to Sylhet.

229. **Abandoning Brahmanbaria**

- a. The units which threatened Dacca were those that broke through the 27 Brigade at Brahmanbaria. The commander, Eastern Command had bitterly complained that he was badly let down by the GOC 14 Division who abandoned Brahmanbaria; an almost impregnable fortress without a fight. The GOC on the other hand ascribed his failure to fulfil the mission to the defective planning of the Eastern Command itself. According to him, the bifurcation of the area of divisional responsibility as late as 19 November was an act of folly. The area should have been left with him as it was. If necessary, the 53 Brigade could have been placed under his command and he could then have planned for an effective brigade battle at Ashuganj and not at Brahmanbaria.⁵⁰⁶
- b. Analysing the development of Indian operations in this sector, it is opined that the fall of Brahmanbaria and the successful heli-landing at Narsinghdi by the enemy could have been prevented if the Eastern Command had given to the GOC 14 Division mission type orders and not tied him down to the defence of Brahmanbaria.⁵⁰⁷

230. **Defence of Chandura.** On 8 December, the Indians crossed the river and occupied Brahmanbaria without any resistance. While the 27 brigade's move to Ashuganj was still going on, the enemy during the night between 8/9 December managed to pass through Sarail and encroached into the northern portion of Ashuganj town. It was development of this threat from north that forced the brigade to leave Brahmanbaria in hurry. Had the brigade secured its northern flank by deploying some

⁵⁰⁵ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 443.

⁵⁰⁶ *Ibid.*, 445.

⁵⁰⁷ *Ibid.*

troops at Chandura, the Indian Sierra Force would not have outflanked them from the north.

231. **Unopposed Crossing of Meghna by Indians**

- a. The Eastern Command repeatedly asked 14 Division to send troops to neutralize the the Indian troops heli-landed at Narsingdi on 10 December 1971 and was bitter with the 14 Division for not doing so.⁵⁰⁸ GOC 14 Division, however, maintains that the task was an impossible one; as the enemy troops being landed were well beyond his guns range and the enemy which had already built-up a brigade strength around Bhairab Bazar would have prevented him from moving forward with its mastery of the skies.⁵⁰⁹ It is nevertheless, suggested that if 27 Brigade had tried to hinder the Indian crossing and subsequent build-up by sending strong fighting patrols, it might have delayed Indian move toward Dacca.
- b. 27 Brigade remained bottled up at Bhairab Bazar between 10 -16 December when the surrender came. As per commander 27 Brigade; the brigade spent this time building up the defences of Bhairab and would have fought on had the order of surrender not come on 16 December 1971.

232. **Role of Sylhet Fortress**

- a. The Indians attacked the Sylhet fortress on 7 December by heli-landing a battalion troops just on the outskirts of the town but fortunately the 202 Brigade pushed back the attack. The enemy entrenched itself about 3 kilometres out of the town and continued to make efforts to occupy the town. Our troops held on but with the withdrawal of troops from the border outposts the enemy converged from all sides and started firing from all directions. The fortress, nevertheless, gallantly held on till 16 December.⁵¹⁰
- b. It is believed that the Sylhet could have attracted more troops for its investment had the forces inside the fortress reacted more aggressively.

⁵⁰⁸ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 445.

⁵⁰⁹ *Ibid.*, 444.

⁵¹⁰ *Ibid.*, 445.

Mid & South-eastern Sector

233. **Last Minute Changes in Area of Responsibility.** After Major General Rahim took over as GOC of this division, he made certain regrouping within the division itself by moving units from one place to another which had an adverse effect and materially affected the formation operational readiness. Some of the readjustment at a time when war was imminent, displayed lack of foresight and as events proved the shifting of 15 Baloch from Comilla and 30 Baloch from Laksham proved disastrous. The newly-inducted units in these areas were neither familiar with the defences nor had any opportunity to be acquainted with the area.⁵¹¹

234. **Incorrect Assessment by the GHQ**

- a. The deployment of the 53 Brigade at Feni on 19 November, was justified by Major General Rahim and the Eastern Command on the ground that this was done under the instructions of GHQ. No written instructions to this effect could, however, be produced. The only order available is on what came two days later on 22 November and reads as follows:

From Chief of Staff for Commander, Eastern Command. Apparent enemy is aiming at capture of Chittagong from land and sea. Vital defend all approaches to Chittagong at all cost. To this end, reinforce defences of Chittagong area by pulling out troops from less important sectors as necessary.⁵¹²

- b. It should have been apparent to the commander, who was not new to the East Pakistan, that it would be hazardous in the extreme to attempt to secure the road and rail communications to Chittagong through the Feni Chicken-neck in view of the fact that these lines of communications were, as already pointed out, running so close to the border as to be within the range even of enemy small arms. The location of troops at Feni was faulty planning. It would have been more profitable to keep this brigade at Laksham, a carefully prepared fortress, to defend the road junction at Mudafarganj and to bring up some troops from Chittagong to the Feni River to protect the approach to Chittagong from that end.⁵¹³

235. **Sudden Collapse of Centre.** The sudden collapse of 23 Punjab and 25 FF put the whole divisional defence plan into jeopardy and created a serious situation.

⁵¹¹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 446.

⁵¹² Ibid.

⁵¹³ Ibid., 446-447.

23 Punjab was defending approach leading through Chaudagram. When the enemy encircled its position and it withdrew, the withdrawal turned into a rout. The battalion headquarters with some elements of one company managed to reach Laksham but the remaining lost their way and got dispersed. A similar thing happened to 25 FF, major portion of which was defending position in and around Mian Bazar. When the brigade commander ordered the battalion to fall back to its depth position in gap between Lalmai Hills and Laksham, he did not know that the Indians had already occupied position behind 25 FF. As a result, the CO and about 35 persons on arriving at the rear position found themselves surrounded by enemy and surrendered.⁵¹⁴

236. **Abandoning Laksham – A Fortified Position.** The decision to exfiltrate was not a fool hardy act but also a reckless and callous decision which deliberately sacrificed many lives, including those of the sick and wounded. Leaving behind of the sick and wounded was an act of gross violation of military ethics. The story about shortage of ammunition and other weapons is also false because Laksham had enough weapons and sufficient stock of ammunition and other supplies. Even the operation of exfiltration was poorly conceived and still more poorly executed. Proper orders were not issued and no route for exfiltration determined. The troops just moved out in two columns on the night of 9 December to cross an enemy invested area and marched across some 12-15 kilometres. Out of a total number of 4000, combatants and non-combatants who moved out of Laksham only 500 or so, including the brigade commander and the CO 15 Baloch managed to reach Comilla. The rest were killed or captured.⁵¹⁵

237. **Lack of Understanding of Local Commanders.** Troops' withdrawal from Comilla and southern tip of Lalmai Hills allowed Indians to open up and maintain their main supply route to Chandpur via Lalmai.

Dacca Bowl

238. Denuding the Centre of Gravity

- a. As such no detailed plan either for the defence of Dacca bowl or for the inner defence of Dacca was prepared nor were the troops allocated for this purpose although it was fully known that Dacca would eventually be the lynch pin in any strategy for the defence of East Pakistan.⁵¹⁶
- b. After 25 March, when the strength of the troops in East Pakistan was raised to three divisions, no thought was given to formulating any scheme

⁵¹⁴ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 447.

⁵¹⁵ *Ibid.*, 449.

⁵¹⁶ *Ibid.*, 453.

for collecting such a force as the troops were fully engaged in counter insurgency operations and it was not expected that the Indians would start an all-out war in East Pakistan. Dacca was allowed to be denuded of troops until August 1971, when under the instructions of GHQ, the 53 Brigade was called back from Chittagong and placed as command reserve and then in September, 1971, the 36-A Division was raised. However, when a threat developed in the east and a breakthrough at Feni was becoming real, Eastern Command released the only brigade it had in Dacca for defence of border town.⁵¹⁷

- c. Besides this, the Eastern Command had not given any serious thought to planning and preparing these defences for the fear of undermining the determination of their troops to fight to the last man and last round in the designated theatre fortresses. Not even a hint had been given to the divisional or brigade commanders that they might have to fall back from the fortresses to defend the Dacca bowl.

239. Effective Utilization of Irregular Troops

- a. There was a general perception that irregular troops – the Razakars, the East Pakistan police, the Mujahids and the other elements of locally raised EPCAF – could not be relied upon. Most of them, in the opinion of officers, were ineffective unless backed up by regular troops.
- b. As a result, when only these troops were available for defending Dacca, the Eastern Command discounted them and did nothing to gel these elements into a coherent fighting force. It is difficult to accept that the morale of the Bihari elements of EPCAF, Razakars and Mujahids could have been so low. They had been adequately trained and armed and would have fought shoulder to shoulder with their West Pakistani comrades-in-arms to the last, if properly commanded.

240. Withered Will to Resist. Cities are difficult to secure or capture by a military force, but in the case of Dacca, it fell like a ripe mango. Eastern Command had troops which could have delayed the collapse for a week or two. But the will to resist had exhausted. The feeling of impending defeat and insecurity pervaded Dacca. No commander was prepared to send even a battalion from his sector. Most divisional

⁵¹⁷ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 441.

commanders appreciated that their troops could not reach Dacca safely even if ordered to move. 14 Division had sufficient troops at Bhairab Bazar to interfere with the Indian build-up in the Narsinghdi area or fall back via Tungi to defend Dacca, but it remained supinely inactive for a whole week in the safety of its fortress at Bhairab Bazar and played no active part in the crucial events around Dacca.

Common Errors

241. Notion of Defending Every Inch of Land

- a. General Niazi personally identified himself and his command with this notion without understanding its implications in the context of the developing possibility of Indian intervention. He kept telling his troops “not an inch of territory would be allowed to be lost.” As events moved to a climax, he became obsessed with the idea that a tactical withdrawal from the forward posture would be a personal defeat for him and a stigma on his honour as a soldier.
- b. Eastern Command was gradually squeezed by Mukti Bahini. They inflamed the entire border with well-planned attacks on BOPs accompanied by efforts to capture some salients inside East Pakistan which would help India’s eventual full-fledged intervention. These raids across the border gradually built-up from a low pitch to a crescendo from early October to the end of November with a purpose.
- c. It may be said that by the time Indians launched an all out war on 21 November, these nibbling operations were considerable. Clearance of Belonia, Ghazipur, areas east of Tista, Pachagarh forced local commanders to rush reinforcements thus diluting our reserves.
- d. To hold the border, the Eastern Command had to disperse her troops more widely, eventually leading to a break down of integrity of formations and of fire-units in support to plug holes, here and there, and reinforce the defences at points where threats were increasing. The decision to hold border in strength put further pressure on the existing resources of regular troops and caused their wider dispersal.

242. Adhoc Grouping/ Formation Raisings

- a. This expedient grouping no doubt increased the number of fighting sub-units, units and formations, but it reduced their military potential greatly. The accompanying dispersal in deployment also diluted the supporting

arms units. It was not uncommon to find a single tank or a gun supporting detachments well away from their parent units. This affected the command and control aspects, and in his effort to rationalize the situation General Niazi organized two adhoc divisional headquarters and three or four brigade headquarters. But these hurriedly organized headquarters suffered the attendant shortcomings of adhocism lacking adequate communications, trained staff and other ancillary units, and were therefore not fully effective.⁵¹⁸

- b. Similarly, for some inexplicable reason, Headquarters 9 (P) Division was moved to the South-western Sector to take over two brigades originally belonging to 14 Division, while Headquarters 14 Division were commanding two brigades of 9 (P) Division in the North-eastern Sector.

243. **Inadequate Logistics.** Inadequate logistic backing had not helped matters. The logistic area established in East Pakistan was originally meant to cater for one infantry division and the attendant administrative units. Stockpiling had taken into consideration the likelihood of the eastern wing being isolated for a limited period, but it did not visualise that the force level would be increased fourfold in a crash programmed time schedule, especially when the new inductions could not bring in their integral transport and stores because of the limited airlift. Surface transport could be mustered locally from unwilling owners, from a truck to a cycle rickshaw on the roads and the water transport of country boats. Troops deployment in pursuit of Mukti Bahini guerrilla was spread so far from the existing lines of communications that the administrative backing could not catch up with the fighting troops.

244. **Psychological Pressure**

- a. Added to the physical discomfort was the psychological pressure of being isolated amid a hostile population. Sustained operations for about eight months in an unfavourable environment of climate, terrain and antagonistic population had resulted in battle fatigue. Battle casualties were mounting and could not get proper attention because of inadequate facilities for their evacuation. Thus there was a steady erosion of morale, aggravated by international media which condemned outrightly the part Tikka Khan and his West Pakistani troops played in Bangladesh.

⁵¹⁸ Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 346.

- b. The Indian propaganda, as well as the realities of situation, created the impression in the minds of the Pakistani soldiers that in the event of war they would be isolated from their homes and would face inevitable surrender and incarceration as prisoners of war. Thus, on the outbreak of hostilities on 21 November, the Pakistani troops quickly got tired and disillusioned.

245. **Concept of Fortress Defence**

- a. It exposed completely the failure of the fortress concept as implemented in East Pakistan. The insistence of the Eastern Command to stick to it resulted ultimately in the whole area being surrendered. Even the divisional plans were ill-conceived and ill-executed. A linear defence, without any depth, of such vital areas was doomed to failure.
- b. General Niazi's contention that his fortress defence catered for both the contingencies, namely, counter insurgency and all out war appeared to be based upon wrong assumptions.
- c. His claim that he "rehashed" his plans after receipt of information of Indian plans from the GHQ and tailored his operational instructions on the basis of firm commitments of further reinforcements from West Pakistan is equally untenable. As already indicated, the only change that he made was the raising of an adhoc division and committing his command reserves into the area of that division at a place where it could have served no useful purpose. No other major changes were made.⁵¹⁹
- d. Likewise, the three battalions received from West Pakistan between 25-29 November were not utilized to create another command reserve but were immediately committed to plug gaps which had already become apparent in the front lines. No plans were prepared for any strategic withdrawal of troops into the Dacca Triangle to guard the axes of entry therein or to deal with enemy heli-landing, if any. No attempt was made to see the ferries were kept in place so as to be available to bring over troops across the big rivers bounding Dacca.⁵²⁰

⁵¹⁹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 451.

⁵²⁰ *Ibid.*

246. Some Cases of Lack of Courage and Leadership

- a. The debacle could not be ascribed solely to the defective planning of the Eastern Command but also to the weak performance of some units and formation commanders, who in the face of danger did not deliver as required.
- b. Leaders of men are to act with sagacity and be bold enough to absorb reverses as well. At the same time let it be also said to the credit of the junior officers and their men that they fought well and bravely and would have continued to fight on to the last, if properly led.⁵²¹

⁵²¹ *The Report of Hamoodur Rehman Commission*, 453.

CONCLUSION⁵²²

247. It was not the first time that a country's political boundaries have been altered. Armies have surrendered in much larger numbers in other parts of the globe. Interventionist policies by powerful neighbours have often exacerbated the instability across the border. But none of these indisputable facts of history can condone the errors and omissions committed by the civil and military leadership in Pakistan since independence which led to the eventual tragedy.

248. The pain and anguish of December 1971 would gradually fade away. But what should always be remembered is that history has a cruel habit of repeating itself if past mistakes are made over and over again. What then are the lessons we must learn from failure to maintain the territorial integrity of Pakistan which we had jointly struggled to establish.

249. *First:* A delicate fabric woven from a single strand cannot sustain the pulls and pressures inherent in a multi-ethnic and poly-lingual society, more so when one of its constituent units happens to be located in a different geographic zone. Such a parchment needs to be strengthened by weaving into it other core values which respective interest groups within a nation consider essential.

250. *Second:* Ethno-centric sub-nationalism is not an unusual phenomena. It is an intrinsic component of multi-ethnic societies. It need not become a hindrance to national integration. But to keep it within bounds a great deal of tolerance and accommodation has to be shown by other dominant groups within the country. Cultural pluralism has to be accepted. Any attempt to force a uniform way of life on those who cherish their own identity will be counter-productive. The dominant-subordinate syndrome must be avoided.

251. *Third:* The legitimacy of a regime in power is an essential factor in making it acceptable to the majority of a country's population. *Coup d' etats*, martial laws, prolonged military rule, and undemocratic methods to remain in power always lead to frustration and bitterness. Attempts are then made to use street power to remove a government which lacks the popular will.

252. *Fourth:* Distortions in economic development exacerbate internal conflict. Though no government can ensure a uniform pace of development in all regions of a state but the least that can be done is to let the people utilise to a large extent the wealth generated from their respective areas. In other words greater devolution of power and

⁵²² Matinuddin, *Tragedy of Errors*, 491-493.

avoidance of centralisation and more regional autonomy would remove much of the grievances which self interested politicians capitalise on.

253. *Fifth*: Extensive, indiscriminate, and excessive use of the army to suppress a popular movement provides a spark to an already volatile situation.

254. *Sixth*: Use of force to solve a political problem or achieve a political objective is never durable. It is at best a temporary solution. The root cause of an insurgency has to be removed for peace and tranquility to be sustained.

255. *Seventh*: Internal disharmony provides golden opportunities to powerful neighbours to achieve their aims and objectives. A correct reading of the domestic scene and its frank and forthright presentation by intelligence agencies to the policy makers can prevent a situation where citizens of a state begin seeking outside assistance.

256. *Eighth*: It is naïve to expect all out support from allies when the domestic policy leads to a civil war within the country unless national interests of a particular ally are being harmed.

257. *Ninth*: The integrity of a nation does not depend on the strength and size of the military forces alone. Economic strength and political stability are as important if not more so for the security of a country.

258. While pointing out some of the lessons that the younger generation of Pakistanis should draw from the East Pakistan debacle the mind continues to be haunted with the basic question – who was to blame for this national tragedy?

259. No one person, event or happening can be made responsible for the dismemberment of Pakistan. It was a combination of mistakes made by several people at different stages of its history which resulted in the secession of the eastern wing.

260. The inability of the Muslim League to fulfil the aspirations of the Bengalis, the delay in arriving at a constitution acceptable to them, the Bengali language movement and its inept handling, the derailing of the democratic process by a civilian head of state, the frequent military take over which deprived the Bengalis their due share in ruling the country, the half hearted attempts at reducing economic disparity, the demeaning of the West Pakistanis towards their co-citizens in the east, the exploitation of the grievances by the Awami League, the decision of the People's Party not to attend the National Assembly session and the military debacle in East Pakistan were all part of the tragedy of errors which culminated in the dismemberment of Pakistan.

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